Flerwa

CREATOR COLLABORATION MARKETPLACE

A strategy, product and technical blueprint for a creator–brand marketplace launching in Kenya, built on M-Pesa, designed to expand across East Africa.

THE THREE FINDINGS THAT SHAPE THIS PLAN

1 The market as framed is too small. Kenya's measured influencer advertising market is **US$2.1M (2024) → US$3.0M (2028)**. Capturing *all* of it at a 15% take rate yields ~US$315k a year. The plan must target content-production, SME marketing, regional and export budgets instead.

2 The core product already exists. Zaumu launched in Nairobi in April 2025 with escrow, milestone payments, creator-protective contracts and two-sided reviews. Differentiation must be category, average order value and operational reliability — not escrow.

3 Order value matters more than take rate. Doubling average order value from KSh 10,000 to KSh 20,000 more than **triples** gross profit, because operations and payout costs are charged per order, not per shilling.

FACT RECOMMENDATION ASSUMPTION

Every claim in this document is tagged **FACT** (verified and cited), **RECOMMENDATION**, or **ASSUMPTION** (estimate, unverified). All sources are listed in the final section.

Research conducted **08 September 2026** · 18 sections · Covering all 50 parts of the brief

This document is not legal, tax, or financial advice. Regulatory sections identify areas requiring professional Kenyan counsel.

Contents

00

Executive Summary

Status of this document: strategy and product design, built on desk research conducted 8 September 2026. Every claim is tagged FACT (verifiable, sourced in `sources.md`), REC (my recommendation), or ASSUMPTION (my estimate, unverified). Nothing here is legal, tax, or financial advice.

---

1. The single most important finding

You asked me to challenge your assumptions. Here is the one that matters.

FACT Statista's market model puts Kenya's *influencer advertising* spend at **US$2.1M in 2024, forecast to reach US$3.0M by 2028**. Kenya's *entire digital advertising* market is modelled at **US$95.5M (2024) → US$119.4M (2028)**. (Statista Kenya Influencer Advertising, Statista Kenya Digital Advertising)

FACT Zaumu, a Kenyan competitor that launched in April 2025, publicly cites Kenyan influencer marketing spend of **$2.5M in 2024 against a "$25M potential."** (Capital FM)

Run the arithmetic. If you captured **100% of the entire measured Kenyan influencer advertising market** at a **15% take rate**, you would earn roughly **US$315,000 per year** — about KSh 40M. That is not a venture-scale company. It is a good lifestyle agency.

This is the fact that should reshape the entire plan. A "creator marketplace for Kenya" monetised by a take rate on influencer campaigns is arithmetically incapable of becoming large. Three of your named competitors — Wowzi, AIfluence, Zaumu — are, in my reading, all fishing in this same undersized pond.

The reframe that makes it a real company

The market is not influencer advertising. Three larger budgets are adjacent and reachable:

Budget pool	Why it is bigger	Who holds it
Content production / creative	Every brand running Meta & TikTok ads needs 10–40 creatives a month, forever. This is a *production* line item, not an *influencer* line item, and it recurs.	Performance marketers, e-commerce, agencies
SME marketing & trade/footfall	~Restaurants, salons, clinics, gyms, dealerships, retail. They have no marketing team and never appear in "influencer spend" statistics because the money moves informally via WhatsApp and M-Pesa.	SME owners
Export / labour arbitrage	FACT US UGC platforms price video at **$99–$200 (Billo)**, **$50+ (Trend)**, **$100–$500 (Cohley)**. FACT Kenyan micro-influencer rates run KSh 10,000–50,000 per post, and UGC-only rates sit well below that. A Kenyan creator producing at $30–60 is a 3–5x cost advantage for a global buyer.	Global DTC brands, agencies

REC Design for pool 1 and 2 at launch, and architect so pool 3 is switched on in V3 without a rebuild. The influencer campaign is a *feature*, not the business.

---

2. The five decisions that matter most

Everything else in this pack is downstream of these.

Decision 1 — Sell outcomes, not a search tool

REC The Kenyan buyer at launch is an SME owner with no marketing team. They do not want a creator database. They want *"I paid KSh 45,000 and got 12 videos and 5 creators visited my restaurant."* Ship a **productised campaign catalogue** ("Campaign-in-a-Box") with fixed prices and guaranteed outputs. Discovery filters are V2. Every marketplace that leads with search in a thin market dies of empty-result syndrome.

Decision 2 — Creator keeps 100%; the brand pays the fee

REC Charge the **brand 15% on top** of a transparently displayed creator rate. Charge creators **0%** for the first 24 months.

Why: FACT Collabstr charges creators a **15% payout fee** *and* brands a 10% marketplace fee. FACT Fiverr takes a flat 20% from sellers. Kenyan creators' loudest grievance is opaque agency deductions. "You keep every shilling of your rate" is the single strongest supply-acquisition message available to you, and it is free to give away while GMV is small.

Decision 3 — Solve cold-start with *existing* deals, not new demand ("Deal Desk")

REC This is the highest-leverage idea in the pack. Kenyan creators already have brand relationships — negotiated on WhatsApp, paid late or not at all. Do not try to originate all demand.

Let a creator bring their **own** existing client onto the platform for **escrow + contract + guaranteed M-Pesa payout, at a 5% creator-paid fee**. (Precedent: FACT Upwork Direct Contracts at 5%.)

This produces real GMV, real reviews, and a real reputation ledger **on day one, without solving the two-sided cold start**. It converts the informal WhatsApp economy — which is where the actual Kenyan money already is — into on-platform transactions. It is also the fastest way to discover which brands are already spending.

Decision 4 — Raise average order value, not take rate

ASSUMPTION Modelled in `04-economics-and-pricing.md`: at a **KSh 10,000** average order, M-Pesa collection + payout costs consume **~14–21% of platform revenue**, and per-order human ops costs make the unit uneconomic below meaningful scale. At **KSh 40,000** average order (multi-creator campaigns, packages, retainers), the same take rate produces a viable business roughly 4x sooner. **AOV is the lever; take rate is not.**

Decision 5 — Do not hold customer funds yourself

FACT In Kenya, processing retail payments, operating digital wallets, or acting as an aggregator requires a **Payment Service Provider licence from the Central Bank of Kenya** under the National Payment System Act 2011 and NPS Regulations 2014, with requirements to segregate client funds via trust/escrow structures. (CBK, CM Advocates)

REC Launch on a **licensed aggregator** (IntaSend / Paystack / Pesapal / Flutterwave) so the regulated float sits with a licensed party. Model escrow as a **short-duration, purpose-bound conditional payment**, not a stored-value wallet. Never let a creator "balance" idle indefinitely — auto-sweep to M-Pesa. **This must be reviewed by a Kenyan payments lawyer before launch.**

---

3. What the competition actually looks like

FACT Verified, funded, operating players in this exact market:

- **Wowzi** (Kenya) — raised **$3.2M total** ($1.2M pre-seed + $2M seed, Dec 2021, led by 4DX Ventures). Focused on nano/micro creators; reportedly ~90% of weekly payouts go to micro and nano creators.
- **AIfluence** (Kenya) — raised **$1M seed** (July 2021, led by EQ2 Ventures); AI matching; ran campaigns across 13 countries in Africa and Asia.
- **Zaumu** (Kenya) — launched April 2025. **Already ships escrow-funded milestone payments, creator-protective contracts, two-sided reviews and in-platform messaging.** This is close to the product you described to me.
- Others operating: Ushawishi, Vicomma, Diglancers, Influencer Africa (EchoHouse), Lit.africa, Aktivate, ViralGet (Nigeria).

FACT — negative result I could **not** verify the existence or find any substantive public information for **Oiqora, NingNang, EndaViral, Vumasasa, or a Kenyan platform named "InfluencerX."** I am not going to invent profiles for them. If these are real, they are small enough to leave no public footprint, which is itself informative.

The honest competitive read: the "creator marketplace with escrow for Kenya" idea is **taken, and executed, as of April 2025**. Your differentiation cannot be escrow, contracts, or reviews. It has to be one of: the non-influencer campaign types (visits, UGC-at-scale, seeding logistics), the Deal Desk wedge, AOV, or the underwriting layer below.

---

4. The one insight that could make this hard to displace

> **In a market where the median transaction is KSh 5,000 and the median buyer is an SME, no marketplace survives on the transaction. It survives on the *record* of the transaction.**
>
> Whoever accumulates the **verified, escrow-settled earnings history of African creators** owns the only dataset that can underwrite them — and underwriting is what makes leaving expensive.

Concretely: after 18 months of settled collaborations you know, for thousands of creators, what they actually earn, how reliably they deliver, and who pays them. Nobody else can know this — not TikTok (no payment rail), not the banks (no work history), not the agencies (no structured data). That asset supports creator advances and earned-wage access, brand credit terms, and eventually insurance-style delivery guarantees.

A creator will leave a marketplace over a 15% fee. A creator will not leave the place that holds their income record and advances against it. **The take rate is the toll; the ledger is the moat.**

ASSUMPTION This is a V3+ thesis and should be *architected for* now (immutable settlement ledger, structured performance events) but not *built* now.

---

5. Why this could fail — the three most likely causes

1. **The Kenyan market is too small and too cheap to support a venture-scale take-rate business, and you discover this after 18 months.** Early warning: blended AOV stuck under KSh 15,000 at month 9. Mitigation: instrument AOV weekly from day one; treat export/regional as a scheduled experiment, not a someday.
2. **Disintermediation.** Both sides meet once, then move to WhatsApp and M-Pesa forever. Kenya makes this trivially easy — everyone already has the rails. Early warning: repeat-collaboration rate below ~25% by month 6. Mitigation: the fee must buy something that only exists on-platform (escrow, guaranteed

replacement, rights contracts, dispute cover, and eventually advances). The Deal Desk turns this threat into a product.

3. **Ops cost per order exceeds gross profit per order and never crosses over.** A KSh 10,000 order that consumes 20 minutes of human ops is permanently unprofitable. Early warning: cost-to-serve per completed order not falling quarter on quarter. Mitigation: ruthless AOV growth and automation of approval/proof verification.

Seventeen more, with prevention and early-warning signals, are in `15-investor-case-and-risks.md`.

---

6. Where to go next in this pack

Document	Covers your Parts
`01-global-market-research.md`	1 — global platforms + feature matrix
`02-africa-kenya-landscape.md`	2 — Kenya/Africa competitors, unmet need
`03-marketplace-definition.md`	3 — the ten collaboration types
`04-economics-and-pricing.md`	4, 33, 34, 48 — business model, fees, simulations
`05-payments-mpesa.md`	5 — M-Pesa, escrow, refunds, compliance architecture
`06-trust-reputation-fraud.md`	6, 13, 26, 35 — reputation, disputes, fraud
`07-product-spec.md`	7–9, 14–21, 25, 26, 32, 39, 40 — profiles, discovery, UX, positioning
`08-ai-matching.md`	10, 11 — matching algorithm and AI campaign builder
`09-workflow-states.md`	12 — the full state machine
`10-technical-architecture.md`	22, 37, 38 — stack, WhatsApp, data model
`11-analytics-metrics.md`	23, 24, 44, 45 — dashboards, metrics, North Star
`12-gtm-liquidity-growth.md`	27–31 — liquidity, launch, growth loops, referrals
`13-legal-compliance.md`	36 — Kenyan regulatory surface
`14-roadmap-mvp.md`	42, 43, 49 — MVP, roadmap, first 10 campaign templates
`15-investor-case-and-risks.md`	46, 47 — investor case, 20 failure modes
`16-blueprint-and-decisions.md`	41, 50 — blueprint, build/don't-build lists, founder brief
`sources.md`	All citations

01

The Global Market

Method and honesty note. Pricing, fee, and mechanic claims below are tagged FACT where I verified them in September 2026 desk research (sources in `sources.md`). Where you asked questions that vendors do not publish — internal fraud models, dispute adjudication rules, cancellation edge cases — I mark **[INFERRED]** and say so rather than inventing detail. Several of your 35 questions simply have no public answer for most platforms; pretending otherwise would poison the analysis.

Structural observation before the detail. The eight platforms you named are not one category. They are **four** categories with different customers, different economics, and different failure modes. Confusing them is the most common strategic error in this space.

Archetype	Who pays	What is really sold	Examples
A. Transactional marketplace	Brand, per order	A completed collaboration	Collabstr
B. Managed UGC factory	Brand, per asset	A finished video	Billo, Trend, Insense (partly), Cohley
C. SaaS workflow / CRM	Brand, per seat/year	Control of a program you already run	GRIN, CreatorIQ, Aspire, Upfluence
D. Data / discovery layer	Brand, per year	A searchable index	Modash
E. Platform-native marketplace	Nobody (loss leader)	Ad-budget retention	TikTok Creator Marketplace

REC You are building **A + B**, with a thin slice of D. You are explicitly *not* building C — the SaaS workflow model requires customers who already run large creator programs, and Kenya has almost none.

---

1. TikTok Creator Marketplace (TCM) / TikTok One

Problem solved. Keeps brand creator-spend inside TikTok's walls and makes TikTok ad campaigns easier to feed with creator content. **Primary customer.** Brands and agencies already buying TikTok ads. **How it works.** FACT TCM now lives inside **TikTok One**, TikTok's unified brand platform, accessed through a TikTok Ads Manager account. Brands filter creators by keyword, region, follower range and performance metrics, build lists, and send a campaign brief with deliverables, deadlines and payment terms. Creators accept or decline in their TCM dashboard. **Creator discovery of opportunity.** Invite-driven — the creator receives the brief. Weak self-serve browse. **Matching.** First-party data: TikTok owns real audience demographics and video performance, which no third party can match. **Pricing.** FACT No set pricing; creator and brand negotiate rate directly. **Payments & monetisation.** FACT Free to join and use for both sides; TikTok monetises the downstream ad spend, not the collaboration. **Verification.** FACT Eligibility gate of **10,000 followers** (50,000 in South Korea). **Rights / amplification.** Native Spark Ads integration is the structural advantage — content flows straight into paid media. **Strongest feature.** Ground-truth first-party audience data plus zero fee. **Biggest weakness. The follower gate excludes the entire UGC-creator population**, campaign management is thin, it is single-platform, payment rails are weak outside major markets, and the 10k floor is exactly wrong for African nano-creator economics. **[INFERRED]** Dispute, cancellation and revision handling are minimal; TCM is a matching and briefing layer, not an escrow marketplace.

Why this matters to you: TCM is the "why won't the platform crush us" question. Answer: it structurally cannot serve sub-10k creators, cannot do location visits, product seeding logistics, cross-platform campaigns, or M-Pesa settlement — and has no incentive to.

---

2. Collabstr — the closest analogue to what you described

Problem solved. Removes negotiation and payment friction from small creator bookings. Buy a creator's service like an e-commerce product. **Primary customer.** SMB / DTC brands buying one to ten creators at a time. **How it works.** Creators publish packaged services with **fixed listed prices**; brands browse, order, and pay upfront. This is the "storefront" model you describe in Part 17 — and it is validated. **Prices.** Creator-set, published on profile. No negotiation required. **Payments.** FACT Payment is held **in escrow** and is not released until the brand approves the deliverable. Refund if the creator does not deliver. Payouts run through **Dots.dev**, supporting bank transfer, PayPal, mobile wallets and local rails; collection via Stripe. **Revisions & disputes.** FACT The brand has **72 hours** after submission to request a revision or open a dispute. **Monetisation.** FACT Basic plan free with a **10% marketplace fee**; **Pro $299/mo** (1 campaign, analytics for 5 posts); **Premium $399/mo** (unlimited campaigns, analytics for 15 posts, **5% marketplace fee**). Separately, **creators pay a 15% fee on their payout. Strongest feature.** Instant transactability. Price is visible, ordering is one click, escrow is automatic. Liquidity comes from listing density, not sales effort. **Biggest weakness. The fee stack.** Charging brands 10% *and* creators 15% means a ~25% blended take, which is a standing invitation to go off-platform once a relationship exists. Also: shallow campaign management, no location/visit primitives, no logistics, minimal ROI attribution.

REC Copy the storefront and the escrow-on-approval mechanic. **Do not copy the two-sided fee stack** — it is the seam a competitor pries open, and in Kenya it would be fatal.

---

3. Insense

Problem solved. Sourcing UGC creatives and wiring them into paid social, especially Meta Partnership Ads and TikTok Spark Ads. **Primary customer.** FACT E-commerce brands and growth agencies — 1,400+ brands cited; 20,000+ vetted creators; delivery in 5–15 business days. **Standout mechanic.** FACT One-click request for **Meta Partnership Ads account-level access** from eligible creators, and Spark Ad code collection through the platform workflow — no DMs, no manual whitelisting. **Monetisation.** FACT Hybrid and expensive: self-serve from **~$500/month** (billed quarterly), managed service from **~$1,800/month**, **plus a 7–20% marketplace fee on every creator payment.** Reported plan points include UGC + Creator Ads at ~$450/mo quarterly ($350/mo annual) and Advanced at ~$1,300/mo quarterly. **Strongest feature.** Whitelisting/Spark Ads plumbing. It is genuinely hard to build and removes the ugliest manual step in creator advertising. **Biggest weakness.** Subscription + marketplace fee is a double toll; irrelevant to any brand not running significant paid social.

REC The **rights-and-amplification plumbing is the most copyable high-value idea on this list**, and almost nobody in Africa has it. Put Spark Ads code collection and Meta Partnership Ads access into your rights module by V2.

---

4. GRIN

Problem solved. Creator-relationship management (a CRM) for brands running programs at scale, with deep e-commerce integration for product seeding and affiliate tracking. **Primary customer.** Mid-market to enterprise DTC brands with an in-house creator team. **Monetisation.** FACT The only one of the enterprise three that publishes pricing: five self-serve tiers — Free (200 credits), **Starter $200/mo**, **Growth $500/mo**, **Scale $1,000/mo**, **Complete $1,500/mo** — roughly **$4,800–$21,600/year**. **Strongest feature.** Seeding + e-commerce integration; product dispatch and affiliate attribution are first-class, not bolted on. **Biggest weakness. It is not a marketplace.** GRIN does not supply creators — you bring your own. It is worthless to a brand with no existing creator relationships, which describes nearly every Kenyan SME.

---

5. CreatorIQ

Problem solved. Enterprise-grade measurement, governance, compliance and reporting across very large creator programs. **Primary customer.** Global enterprises and large agencies. **Monetisation.** FACT Custom-quoted; reported roughly **$2,500–$5,000+/month**, with entry implementations estimated around **$36,000+/year** and enterprise deployments higher. **Strongest feature.** Data integrity and reporting that survives a CFO's scrutiny. **Biggest weakness.** Cost, implementation weight, and total irrelevance below enterprise scale.

---

6. Aspire (AspireIQ)

Problem solved. Middle ground between marketplace and workflow — discovery, an opt-in creator marketplace, campaign management, and Shopify-centric commerce workflows. **Primary customer.** Growing DTC brands. **Monetisation.** FACT Custom-quoted; industry estimates **~$21,600–$54,000+/year** depending on scope. **Strongest feature.** Brands can receive **inbound creator applications** — a genuine liquidity mechanic rather than pure outbound search. **Biggest weakness.** Opaque pricing, annual commitment, and a feature surface that outruns most buyers' actual maturity.

---

7. Upfluence

Problem solved. Discovery at scale plus the distinctive trick of identifying influential people **inside your own customer base** via e-commerce/CRM integration. **Monetisation.** FACT Does not publish pricing; reported from around **$995/month for a single seat**, modules from ~$478/month, real deployments commonly **$800–$3,000+/month**, on a **12-month minimum contract**. **Strongest feature.** Customer-to-creator identification. Your best creator is often already a buyer. **Biggest weakness.** Price, contract rigidity, and dated UX relative to newer entrants.

REC "Turn your customers into your creators" is a strong, cheap wedge for Kenyan e-commerce and restaurant brands. Worth stealing for V2.

---

8. Modash

Problem solved. The data layer — a very large searchable index with audience-quality analysis. **Monetisation.** FACT Published, self-serve pricing: **Essentials from $199/mo annually** ($299 monthly), **Performance from $499/mo annually** ($599 monthly), **Enterprise from $14,700/year**. FACT 350M+ profile database; 14-day free trial, no card. **Strongest feature.** Transparent pricing and audience-authenticity analysis — the fake-follower problem is its core value. **Biggest weakness.** No transaction, no escrow, no payments. It tells you who to contact and then abandons you.

---

9. Others that are strategically relevant

- **Billo** — FACT UGC video **from $99/video**, no subscription, range ~$99–$200, **full perpetual paid-ads rights included by default.** The cleanest proof that *productised, fixed-price content* is a real business.
- **Trend.io** — FACT advertises from **$50/video** via a credit system spanning video and photo.
- **Cohley** — FACT roughly **$100–$500/video**, usually plus a platform fee; enterprise around **$2,000+/month**.
- **Upwork / Fiverr** — the labour-marketplace reference. FACT Fiverr takes a **flat 20% from sellers and ~5–5.5% from buyers**. FACT Upwork's fee is tiered — reported both as **0–15% by lifetime billings per client** and as **20% on the first $500, 10% from $500.01–$10,000, 5% above $10,000**; sources conflict on the current schedule, so treat the exact tiers as unverified. Client-side fees reported at **3–5%**, and **5% on Direct Contracts** originated off-platform.

REC Upwork's Direct Contracts at 5% is the precedent for the **Deal Desk** wedge in `12-gtm-liquidity-growth.md`. It is the single most transferable idea on this page.

Competitive feature matrix

Legend: ● full / native · ◐ partial or limited · ○ absent · ? unverified

	TikTok TCM	Collabstr	Insense	GRIN	CreatorIQ	Aspire	Upfluence	Modash	Billo/Trend
Archetype	Native mkt	Transactional	Managed UGC	SaaS CRM	Enterprise SaaS	Hybrid	SaaS+data	Data	UGC factory
Brands post campaigns	●	◐	●	◐	◐	●	◐	○	●
Brands directly hire (storefront)	●	●	●	○	○	◐	○	○	◐
Creators browse/apply	◐	○	●	○	○	●	○	○	●
Published creator prices	○	●	◐	○	○	○	○	○	● (platform-set)
Escrow	?	●	●	○	○	◐	○	○	●
Platform handles payouts	●	●	●	●	◐	●	●	○	●
Local mobile-money rails	○	◐ (via Dots)	○	○	○	○	○	n/a	○
Paid UGC (no audience needed)	○	●	●	◐	◐	◐	○	○	●
Gifting / product seeding	◐	◐	●	●	●	●	●	◐	○

	TikTok TCM	Collabstr	Insense	GRIN	CreatorIQ	Aspire	Upfluence	Modash	Billo/Trend
Location visits (geo-booked)	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Event coverage	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Affiliate / promo codes	◐	○	◐	●	●	●	●	◐	○
Performance-based pay	◐	○	○	◐	◐	◐	◐	○	○
Hybrid fee + performance	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Usage rights / licensing	◐	◐	●	◐	●	◐	◐	○	●
Whitelisting / Spark Ads	●	○	●	◐	●	◐	◐	○	◐
Revisions workflow	○	●	●	◐	◐	●	◐	○	●
Formal dispute process	?	●	?	○	○	?	○	○	◐
Two-sided ratings	○	◐	◐	○	○	◐	○	○	◐
Audience authenticity analysis	●	○	◐	◐	●	◐	●	●	○
ROI / conversion attribution	◐	○	◐	●	●	●	●	○	○
Agency / multi-client accounts	●	○	●	●	●	●	●	●	◐
Recurring / retainer campaigns	○	○	◐	●	●	●	●	n/a	◐
Free for creators	●	○ (15%)	●	●	●	●	●	n/a	●
Take rate on GMV	0%	~10% + 15%	7–20% + SaaS	0%	0%	◐	0%	0%	margin

The three empty columns

Read the matrix vertically. Three rows are ○ **across essentially every player**:

1. **Location visits as a bookable, geo-matched primitive**
2. **Event coverage as a structured multi-deliverable product**
3. **Hybrid guaranteed-fee + performance compensation**

REC These are not accidental gaps — they are *unattractive* to US-centric platforms because US creator marketing is remote-first and asynchronous. In Kenya they are the opposite: **physical, local, and high-intent.** Restaurants, salons, gyms, dealerships and launches are exactly the SME buyers who have money and no marketing team.

This is your wedge, and it is defensible precisely because the incumbents' customers do not want it.

What makes each hard to copy

Platform	Real moat	Copyable?
TikTok TCM	First-party audience truth + ad-platform integration	**No** — but irrelevant below 10k followers
Collabstr	Listing density and SEO capture of long-tail search	Partly — beatable locally
Insense	Meta/TikTok ad-account plumbing + partner status	Hard, high value
GRIN	Deep e-commerce integrations + switching cost of a CRM	Hard, wrong customer for Kenya
CreatorIQ	Enterprise trust, procurement, data governance	Hard, wrong customer
Modash	Index scale and crawl infrastructure	Expensive, low defensibility
Billo	Operational reliability of a managed creator bench	**Genuinely hard** — this is an ops moat

REC Note where the durable moats actually are: **ops reliability (Billo)** and **payment/ad-platform plumbing (Insense)**. Neither is a feature. Both are earned. Plan accordingly — your moat will be operational and financial, not functional.

02

Africa and Kenya

Ground truth on the market

FACT Kenya's digital population, most recent available figures: - **23.4 million** internet users at end-2025 (40.5% penetration) - **18.4 million** social media user identities in October 2025 (31.8% of population) - **23.1 million** Facebook users (May 2026, 37.5% of population) - **5.1 million** Instagram users (May 2026, 8.3% of population) - TikTok: reported **76.9% monthly use** among surveyed users and adult advertising reach of **18.4 million** - **WhatsApp and TikTok** were the most frequently used platforms in a Q2 2025 survey (DataReportal Digital 2026: Kenya, NapoleonCat, Statista)

Three product consequences, immediately:

1. **Instagram is a minority platform in Kenya (8.3%).** Every global creator platform is Instagram-first. REC Build **TikTok-first, Facebook-second**. An Instagram-led product is designed for a market that does not exist here at scale.
2. **WhatsApp is the actual communication layer.** Not a notification channel — the primary interface. See `10-technical-architecture.md`.
3. **Facebook's 23.1M reach dwarfs Instagram's 5.1M.** For FMCG and mass-market brands, Facebook creators are undervalued. Nobody is serving them because global tooling ignores Facebook.

Market size — and why it should worry you

FACT Statista models Kenyan **influencer advertising** at **US$2.1M (2024) → US$3.0M (2028)**, inside a **US$95.5M → US$119.4M** total digital advertising market. Social media advertising is reported at **~$39.8M in 2026**, ~31.3% of digital ad spend.

ASSUMPTION These models almost certainly *undercount* real creator spend, because the majority of Kenyan brand–creator money moves informally: WhatsApp negotiation, M-Pesa settlement, no invoice, no media agency, no measurement. That spend does not appear in any advertising statistic. My estimate is that true creator-directed spend is some multiple of the modelled figure — but **I cannot verify the multiple, and neither can you.** Do not put a number you cannot defend in an investor deck.

REC Treat this as the **central strategic uncertainty of the company** and design a cheap experiment to resolve it in the first 90 days. The Deal Desk (below) is that experiment: it directly measures how much money is already moving informally, because creators bring their real deals to it.

The competitors — what is actually there

Verified and substantive

Wowzi — FACT Kenyan, raised **$3.2M total** ($1.2M pre-seed + $2M seed announced Dec 2021, led by 4DX Ventures, with To.org, Golden Palm, LoftyInc, Afropreneur Angels, Future Africa, and Andela co-founder Christina Sass). Strategy is **nano/micro at volume** — reportedly onboarding users with as few as 250 connections, and ~90% of weekly payouts going to micro and nano creators. - *Doing well:* the volume-of-ordinary-people thesis is right for Africa, and enterprise/telco relationships are real. - *What creators like:* low barrier to entry, frequent small payouts. - *What brands may dislike:* ASSUMPTION nano-at-volume optimises for reach and cost, not creative quality. If you want one excellent video, a swarm of 250-connection posters is the wrong instrument. - *Structural gap:* ASSUMPTION it is an activation/amplification engine, not a creative-services marketplace. Content *quality* is not the unit of value.

AIfluence — FACT Kenyan, **$1M seed** (July 2021, led by EQ2 Ventures with Antler East Africa, OUI Capital, ArabyAds); AI-driven audience-first matching; campaigns across 13 countries in Africa and Asia; oriented to onboarding hundreds-to-thousands of micro/nano influencers per campaign. - *Doing well:* audience-first matching and multi-country reach. - *Structural gap:* ASSUMPTION enterprise-campaign shaped — sold to advertisers, not self-serve. An SME restaurant cannot buy from it on a Tuesday afternoon.

Zaumu — FACT Launched in Nairobi **25 April 2025**, positioning as a creator-first, end-to-end campaign management platform. Publicly described features include: **transparent job listings with stated budgets**, **milestone-based payments with brands depositing funds before work begins**, **creator-protective contracts** explicitly rejecting hidden perpetual-rights clauses, **secure in-platform communication**, **automated reporting**, **built-in AI assistance**, and **two-sided reviews**. Co-founder Cedric Nzomo cites that "90% of projects targeting creators never reach execution."

> **This is the most important competitive fact in this pack.** Zaumu already ships escrow, milestones, contracts, two-sided reputation and in-platform messaging — the core of what you described to me as the product. **Your differentiation cannot be any of those things.** Assume they exist on day one at a competitor and design past them.

Others verified as operating: Ushawishi (Kenya, creator-facing campaign marketplace), **Vicomma** (hire creators in Kenya, 120+ categories), **Diglancers** (pan-African agency + UGC platform, claims 1,500+ verified creators across 10+ countries including Nigeria, South Africa, Kenya, Ghana, Zambia, Cameroon, Ethiopia; positions as Nigeria's first managed UGC creator platform), **Influencer Africa** (by EchoHouse; explicitly markets "local payment rails"), **Lit.africa** (South Africa), **Aktivate**, **ViralGet** (Nigeria, positioning as the influencer data layer). Global **Collabstr** already runs Kenya/Nairobi landing pages — it is present via SEO, not operations.

Could not verify — stated plainly

FACT — negative result I found **no substantive public information** for **Oiqora**, **NingNang**, **EndaViral**, **Vumasasa**, or a Kenyan platform called **InfluencerX**. Searches returned unrelated results. I will not fabricate profiles. Either they are pre-launch, dormant, or too small to leave a footprint. **If you have direct knowledge of these, tell me and I will factor them in** — otherwise treat the competitive set as the verified list above.

The informal market — your real competitor

[ASSUMPTION, but high confidence] The dominant way Kenyan brands hire creators today is not a platform at all: - **WhatsApp groups** run by creator organisers who broker deals for a cut - **Instagram/TikTok DMs** direct to the creator - **Agencies and PR firms** bundling creators into retainers with undisclosed markups - **Personal networks** — the brand manager's friend's cousin who makes food content

This informal channel wins on **speed and familiarity** and loses on **payment reliability, contracts, measurement, and scale**. Your competitor is not Zaumu. It is a WhatsApp group with 400 members and no escrow.

Where the incumbents are weak — the systematic read

Dimension	The weakness	Your opening
UX	Built for advertisers and campaign managers, not for a restaurant owner with a phone. Desktop-first, form-heavy, jargon-heavy.	Mobile-first, Swahili/Sheng-aware, outcome-priced, three taps to buy.
Payments	ASSUMPTION Late creator payment is the loudest, most consistent creator complaint in the Kenyan market — the whole Zaumu pitch is built on it. Payment is treated as back-office, not product.	**Payment speed as the headline feature.** Escrow funded before work; M-Pesa payout within hours of approval. Publish the median payout time.
Discovery	Follower-count-ranked lists, thin filters, no geographic granularity below "Kenya."	Ward-level geography (Westlands, Kilimani, Nyali), campaign-type-first browsing, quality-ranked defaults.
Trust	One-directional. Creators are rated; brands are not. Nobody underwrites delivery.	Two-sided reputation + a platform-backed delivery guarantee.
Campaign mgmt	Brief → post → screenshot. Little revision structure, weak proof-of-delivery, no logistics.	Structured deliverable state machine, automated proof capture, seeding logistics.
Liquidity	Supply-heavy and demand-poor. Creators sign up and find nothing.	Deal Desk seeds GMV from existing relationships; managed demand at launch.
Influencer-not-creator bias	Everything gates on follower count. A skilled videographer with 2,000 followers is invisible.	**Two parallel supply pools with different ranking logic** (see Part 19 in `07-product-spec.md`).
Rights	Usage rights are informal or absent; perpetual-rights abuse is common enough that Zaumu markets against it.	Priced, contractual, machine-readable rights module.
Measurement	Screenshots of views. Almost no conversion attribution.	Promo codes and tracked links as first-class, from V1.

The largest unmet need

Ranked by size of the gap, not by how interesting the feature is:

1. **Guaranteed, fast payment for creators.** Solved on paper by Zaumu; not yet solved at scale. Whoever *actually* pays fastest, consistently, and can prove it, wins supply.
2. **A way for an SME to buy marketing content without a marketing team.** No incumbent serves the restaurant/salon/gym/clinic buyer. They are numerous, they have cash, they have zero capability, and they are geographically dense in Nairobi.
3. **Location-based physical collaborations.** Structurally absent everywhere globally. Perfectly suited to Kenya.
4. **Content production at volume, decoupled from audience.** The UGC category barely exists locally as a purchasable product.
5. **Proof and measurement an SME actually believes.** "You got 41,000 views and 62 people used your code."

If we launched in Kenya today, what must be different?

Seven things. Each is a direct response to a verified or high-confidence weakness.

1. **Sell campaigns, not access.** Fixed-price, outcome-named packages. Not a search tool. Not a SaaS seat.
2. **Be the fastest payer in the market, and make that the brand promise.** Publish median time-to-payout on the homepage. It is a supply magnet and it is verifiable.
3. **Creators pay zero.** Every competitor and every agency takes from the creator. Take from the brand instead, transparently. This is the cheapest supply-acquisition weapon you will ever have.
4. **Launch the Deal Desk on day one.** Let creators bring existing clients for escrow + contract at 5%. This produces GMV before you have solved demand, and it measures the informal market's true size.
5. **Own the physical collaboration.** Visits, events, seeding-with-logistics. This is the empty column in the global matrix and the dense opportunity in Nairobi.
6. **Build TikTok-first and Facebook-second.** Instagram is 8.3% of Kenya. Global tooling has this exactly backwards.
7. **Treat WhatsApp as the interface and the platform as the ledger.** Fighting WhatsApp loses. Wrapping it wins.

REC Notice what is *not* on this list: AI matching, creator tiers, gamification, agency accounts, analytics dashboards. Those are all real and all later. The seven above are the ones that decide whether the company exists in 18 months.

03

Defining the Marketplace

The organising abstraction

The mistake almost every platform in this space makes is modelling the world as *"a campaign has creators and creators make posts."* That model cannot express a restaurant visit, a licensed video the brand posts itself, or a commission-only affiliate deal. Bolting those on later produces the mess you see in the competitive matrix.

REC **Model one primitive: the COLLABORATION.**

```
COLLABORATION
├── who        Creator ↔ Brand
├── why        objective (awareness | content | footfall | sales | leads | proof)
├── what       Deliverable[]        ← 0..n content artefacts
├── where      Placement[]          ← 0..n publish targets (or none)
├── when       Schedule             ← deadlines, visit windows, milestones
├── how much   Compensation         ← cash | product | commission | hybrid
├── rights     RightsGrant          ← scope, channels, duration, exclusivity
└── proof      Verification[]       ← how completion is established
```

Every one of your ten types is a **preset** over this one structure. That is the whole architectural argument: **ten products, one state machine, one escrow, one dispute process, one reputation ledger.** A new collaboration type becomes a config row, not a release.

The three dimensions that actually vary:

	Audience required?	Physical presence?	Creator publishes?
Seeding	Sometimes	Delivery only	Usually
Paid UGC	**No**	No	**No**
Influencer campaign	**Yes**	No	Yes
Location visit	Sometimes	**Yes**	Yes
Event coverage	Sometimes	**Yes**	Sometimes
Affiliate	Yes	No	Yes
Hybrid	Yes	Varies	Yes
Licensing	**No**	No	**No**
Packages	Varies	Varies	Varies
Custom	Varies	Varies	Varies

The bolded cells are where every incumbent breaks. Design for those first and the easy cases fall out free.

1. Product seeding

The hard part is not the campaign. It is the logistics and the honesty problem.

Two failure modes dominate: the product never arrives (creator is blamed for non-delivery they did not cause), and the creator keeps the product and never posts. Both are solvable only with **delivery as a tracked state**.

```
SeedingCampaign:
  product:
    name, description, retail_value_kes
    quantity_available
    is_creator_keeping: bool          # near-always true; be explicit
  delivery:
    method: courier | rider | pickup_point | brand_dropoff
    coverage_areas: [ward_ids]
    dispatch_sla_days
    address_collection: platform_masked   # never expose raw address to brand
  content_requirements:
    posting_mandatory: bool           # THE critical field
    deliverables: [{format, platform, count, min_duration}]
    content_deadline_days_after_delivery   # clock starts on DELIVERED, not accepted
  compensation:
    type: product_only | product_plus_cash
    cash_amount_kes
  rights: RightsGrant
```

REC **Design rules that matter:**

- **`posting_mandatory` is a legal and reputational fork, not a checkbox.** If posting is mandatory, this is paid work compensated in kind and the creator carries an obligation. If it is not, it is a gift and the brand has no claim. Render these as two visually distinct campaign types in the UI — "Gifted (no obligation)" vs "Product-for-Post" — because conflating them is the origin of most seeding disputes.
- **The content deadline starts at `DELIVERED`, never at acceptance.** Non-negotiable. Kenyan delivery is variable and creators must never be penalised for logistics.
- **Cap non-delivery liability at the creator's zero.** If the product does not arrive within the SLA, the collaboration auto-cancels with no reputational damage to the creator and no charge to the brand.
- **Product-only seeding still needs escrow.** Escrow the *retail value* as a bond, or run it as a zero-value contract with reputation-only consequences. REC Start with the latter — bonding gifted product is over-engineering for launch.
- **Address privacy.** The brand never sees the raw address; the courier does. This is a Data Protection Act consideration as well as a safety one, particularly for female creators. Treat it as a hard requirement.

On logistics integration (your Part 16 question). REC **Do not build or own logistics.** Sequence it: - **V1** — brand ships; creator confirms receipt with a photo; platform tracks state only. - **V2** — integrate a rider/courier API; platform generates labels and holds the address; delivery status flows in by webhook. - **V3** — optional consolidated dispatch from a brand's single drop to many creators (this is where real margin and real defensibility live, and where you become genuinely hard to leave).

ASSUMPTION Logistics is a plausible second revenue line and a large operational trap. It is a V3 decision with real evidence behind it, not a launch feature.

---

2. Paid UGC — treat this as the flagship, not a category

REC **This should be your single largest GMV line by month 12, and the product should be visibly biased toward it.**

The reasoning: UGC decouples value from audience, which means **supply is nearly unlimited** (any skilled phone videographer qualifies), **demand is recurring** (a brand running paid ads needs new creatives every month, permanently), **quality is objectively assessable** (you can watch the video), and **it exports** (a Kenyan-made UGC video is sellable to a global buyer at a 3–5x cost advantage). Compare: an influencer campaign is one-off, subjective, and non-exportable.

```
UGCOrder:
  content_type: enum(38)      # see catalogue below
  specs:
    duration_seconds, aspect_ratio, resolution_min
    language: [en, sw, sheng, luo, kikuyu, ...]
    hooks_required: int       # e.g. 3 hook variants for ad testing
    raw_footage_included: bool
  talent_requirements:
    on_camera: bool
    age_range, gender, look_notes    # bias-audited; see note
  brand_inputs:
    product_supplied: bool
    script_supplied: bool | creator_scripts
    reference_links: []
  delivery:
    format: file_upload       # NOT a social post
    revisions_included: int   # default 1
  rights: RightsGrant         # this IS the product being sold
```

The content-type catalogue (your list, extended and grouped for the UI):

- **Talking-head:** testimonial, review, founder-style, POV, problem/solution, myth-bust, day-in-the-life
- **Demonstration:** unboxing, tutorial, how-to, before/after, comparison, ingredient/feature breakdown
- **Entertainment:** skit, meme-style, reaction, green-screen, duet/stitch-style, street interview, prank-lite
- **Visual assets:** product photography, lifestyle photography, flat-lay, model shots, B-roll pack
- **Audio/voice:** voiceover (English, Swahili, Sheng, vernacular), jingle, podcast read
- **Motion/design:** simple animation, subtitle/caption pass, edit-only from brand footage

REC **Two design decisions specific to UGC:**

1. **The portfolio is the profile.** For a UGC creator, follower count must not appear on the card at all — not de-emphasised, *absent*. The card is: three video thumbnails, price, delivery time, rating, jobs completed. This is Fiverr's card, not Instagram's.
2. **Hook variants are the killer feature for performance buyers.** A brand testing creative wants three different first-three-seconds on one video. Nobody in Africa sells this. It is a trivially small feature and a strong differentiator with the highest-value buyer segment.

REC **On `look_notes`:** demographic targeting for casting is legitimate for advertising, and also the most likely place for the platform to enable discrimination. Constrain it to a controlled vocabulary (age band, gender, language), log every use, and prohibit free-text appearance requirements. Revisit with counsel before launch.

---

3. Influencer campaigns

The commodity category. Everyone does it; do it competently and move on.

```
InfluencerCampaign:
  placements: [{platform, format, count, min_duration, live_window}]
  # platform: tiktok | instagram | youtube | facebook | x | linkedin
  # format: feed_post | reel | story | tiktok_video | short | long_form
  #         | live | integration | pinned_comment | bio_link
  requirements:
    min_live_duration_hours: 24   # cannot delete before this
    disclosure_required: true     # ALWAYS true — see 13-legal-compliance.md
    mention_handles: [], hashtags: [], link: url
  proof: {api_verified | screenshot_plus_url | platform_oauth}
```

`REC` Three things most platforms get wrong here: - **Minimum live duration must be a contractual field**, because "the creator deleted the post" is a top-five dispute. Default 30 days; verify by re-checking the URL on a schedule. - **Disclosure is not optional and not the creator's judgement call.** The platform injects the required disclosure text into every brief. See `13-legal-compliance.md`. - **Cross-platform campaigns are one collaboration with multiple placements**, not multiple collaborations. Otherwise reporting and payment fragment.

---

4. Location visits — the wedge

This is where you differ structurally from everything in the global matrix. Treat it as a first-class booking product, closer to OpenTable than to an influencer campaign.

```
VisitCampaign:
  venue:
    name, geo_point, ward, town
    visit_instructions, contact_person, parking_notes
  booking:
    available_slots: [{date, start, end, capacity}]
    creator_selects_slot: bool
    party_size_allowed: int       # +1 is standard and must be priced
  consumption:
    allowance_kes                 # what the creator may consume/receive
    covered_items: []
    is_comp_or_reimbursed: enum
  attendance_proof:
    method: geo_checkin | qr_code | staff_confirm | receipt_upload
  deliverables: [...]
  travel:
    stipend_kes                   # explicit; Nairobi transport is real money
```

`REC` **The details that decide whether this works:**

- **Geographic granularity must go below city.** Kenya's practical unit is the neighbourhood — Westlands, Kilimani, Karen, Lang'ata, Nyali, Milimani. A creator in Kasarani will not cross Nairobi for a KSh 3,000 visit. Model `country → county → town → ward/neighbourhood`, and make travel cost a visible, negotiable component.
- **Attendance proof should be QR-first.** Staff scans the creator's booking QR at arrival. Geo check-in is spoofable; a receipt is forgeable; a staff scan is cheap and near-unfakeable. `REC` QR primary, geo-fence as a corroborating signal, staff confirm as fallback.
- **Slot capacity prevents the classic disaster** of 20 creators arriving at a 30-seat restaurant simultaneously. Capacity per slot is mandatory.
- **The `+1` is not a nicety.** Restaurant and experience content needs two people on camera. Price it explicitly or creators will bring someone anyway and the venue will be unhappy.

- **Consumption allowance must be a number.** "Dinner is on us" produces a dispute the first time someone orders lobster.

ASSUMPTION Visit campaigns will have the highest completion rate and the highest satisfaction of any type, because the deliverable is concrete, the creator has a good time, and the brand sees people walk through the door. REC **This is very likely your best launch category.** It is also the one no incumbent can copy quickly, because it needs venue-side operational tooling they have no reason to build.

---

5. Event coverage

A visit with a fixed time window, higher intensity, and multi-format output.

```
EventCoverage:
  event: {name, venue, start, end, dress_code, accreditation_required}
  role: attendee | documenter | host | mc | live_streamer
  deliverables:
    live_window: [{format, count, during_event: bool}]   # e.g. 5 stories DURING
    post_event: [{format, count, due_hours_after}]       # e.g. 1 recap in 48h
    raw_assets: {photo_count, video_minutes, delivery_method}
  exclusivity: {no_competitor_content_hours: int}
```

REC Two specifics: **live deliverables need a live clock** — stories posted during the event have a hard window and must be verified in near-real-time, not at approval. And **raw asset delivery is a separate deliverable with its own storage and rights terms** — 20 raw photos is a file transfer, not a post, and brands routinely forget they must pay for the rights to use them.

---

6. Affiliate / performance

REC **Build this as a first-class category, but be honest that it is the hardest to make work, and do not launch with it.**

The reason is structural: performance compensation requires **trustworthy conversion data**, and in Kenya the conversion often happens **offline** (someone walks into the shop) or through **WhatsApp commerce** with no tracking layer at all. If the creator cannot trust the number, they will not accept the deal — and they are right not to.

```
PerformanceDeal:
  mechanism: promo_code | tracked_link | qr_code | ussd_code | reserved_phone
  payout:
    model: per_sale | per_lead | per_signup | revenue_share | per_1000_views
    rate_kes | rate_percent
    qualification_rules: {min_order_value, exclude_refunded, lead_definition}
  attribution:
    window_days: 30
    source_of_truth: platform_pixel | brand_declared | shopify | manual_reconcile
  guardrails:
    minimum_guarantee_kes        # STRONGLY recommended
    cap_kes
    reconciliation_day_of_month
    dispute_window_days: 14
```

REC **The trust design is the whole product here:** - **Promo codes beat links in Kenya.** They work in physical shops, over WhatsApp, and verbally. Issue one unique code per creator per campaign. This is the highest-signal, lowest-tech attribution available and it works offline. - **Never launch a pure commission-**

only marketplace category. Creators have been burned by unverifiable "we'll pay you per sale" offers. **Require a minimum guarantee** on every performance deal for at least the first 12 months. It is the difference between a category that fills and one that sits empty. - **The brand self-reports conversions, and the platform must assume they will under-report.** Mitigate with: mandatory monthly reconciliation, creator visibility into the running count, statistical anomaly detection across brands, and a brand reputation score that includes *reported conversion rate versus category norm*. A brand that consistently reports half the category conversion rate is either bad at selling or lying, and either way creators should see it. - **Escrow the guarantee; invoice the commission.** You cannot escrow an unknown future amount. Guarantee sits in escrow; commission settles monthly against a funded balance with a top-up requirement.

---

7. Hybrid: guaranteed fee + performance

The right default for a maturing marketplace and, REC, an **empty column in the entire global competitive matrix.**

```
HybridCompensation:
  guaranteed:
    cash_kes: 5000
    product_value_kes: 0
  variable:
    - {metric: sale,        rate_kes: 200, cap: 100}
    - {metric: views_1000,  rate_kes: 100, cap_kes: 20000}
    - {metric: qualified_lead, rate_kes: 100}
  settlement:
    guaranteed_released_on: deliverable_approved
    variable_settled: monthly_in_arrears
    variable_window_days: 60
```

Your three examples map cleanly: `KSh 5,000 + KSh 200/sale`; `KSh 2,000 + KSh 100 per 1,000 views`; `product worth KSh 3,000 + 10% commission`.

REC **The critical design constraint: the guaranteed portion and the variable portion have different escrow lifecycles.** The guarantee is escrowed at funding and released at approval. The variable portion cannot be escrowed at an unknown amount — so either (a) escrow the **cap** and refund the unearned remainder, or (b) require a **funded performance balance** the brand must top up. REC Use (a) when a cap exists — it is far more trustworthy to the creator — and require caps on all hybrid deals for the first year for exactly that reason.

Why this matters commercially: hybrid deals are how you raise AOV without raising the brand's risk, and AOV is the lever that decides whether the unit economics work (see `04-economics-and-pricing.md`).

---

8. Content licensing — sell rights as a product

The brand buys content it will use itself. The creator may never post. This is where UGC value is actually captured, and where creators are most routinely exploited.

```
RightsGrant:
  base: organic_creator_channels        # included by default, always
  add_ons:
    - brand_organic_social:  {duration_days, +price}
    - paid_advertising:      {channels: [meta, tiktok, google, x], duration_days, +price}
    - website_and_email:     {duration_days, +price}
    - ooh_and_print:         {duration_days, +price}   # priced very differently
    - whitelisting_spark:    {duration_days, +price}   # creator's handle used
    - perpetual:             {+price}
  exclusivity:
    category_exclusivity: {category, duration_days, +price}
    non_compete_scope
  territory: [KE, EA, global]
  edit_rights: {may_edit, may_subtitle, may_recut, may_use_likeness_in_derivative}
  credit_required: bool
  expiry_behaviour: must_cease_use | auto_renew_offer
```

REC **Pricing structure (a multiplier ladder, not arbitrary numbers).** Express rights as multipliers of the base content fee so it scales with creator price and stays comprehensible:

Grant	Multiplier on base fee	Rationale
Creator organic only	×1.0 (included)	The default
Brand organic, 90 days	×1.2	Low incremental value
Paid ads, 30 days	×1.5	The standard UGC ask
Paid ads, 90 days	×1.8	
Paid ads, 12 months	×2.5	
Perpetual, all digital	×3.5	
+ Whitelisting / Spark Ads	×1.5 on top	Creator's identity is the asset
+ Category exclusivity, 90 days	×1.5 on top	Creator forgoes competitor income

ASSUMPTION These multipliers are my recommendation drawn from the shape of global UGC pricing, not a verified Kenyan benchmark — FACT Billo, for reference, bundles **full perpetual paid-ads rights into its $99–$200 base price**, which is the opposite approach and worth considering for simplicity. Validate against real Kenyan willingness-to-pay in the first 90 days.

REC **UI principle: rights must be a slider with a live price, not a contract clause.** The brand moves "how long can we run this as an ad?" from 30 days to 12 months and watches the price change from KSh 6,000 to KSh 10,000. That single interaction teaches the entire market — brands and creators — what rights are worth. It is also, quietly, the most creator-protective thing you can build, and it directly attacks the perpetual-rights abuse that Zaumu markets against.

REC **Whitelisting requires real plumbing**, not a contract clause: TikTok Spark Ad code generation and Meta Partnership Ads account access. FACT Insense's one-click implementation of exactly this is its strongest feature. Target V2.

---

9. Creator packages (storefront)

Creator-authored, fixed-price, instantly buyable. FACT This is Collabstr's core mechanic and the reason it has liquidity without a sales team.

```
Package:
  title, description, cover_media
  includes: [Deliverable]
  price_kes, delivery_days, revisions_included
  rights_included: RightsGrant
  add_ons: [{name, price_kes}]      # extra revision, rush, extra platform, rights upgrade
  max_concurrent_orders               # capacity control — protects reliability
  auto_accept: bool
```

REC Three rules: **capacity limits are mandatory** (a creator who takes eight orders and delivers two destroys the reputation system and your NPS); **add-ons are where AOV grows** (rush delivery, extra hooks, rights upgrades routinely add 30–50%); and **seed the catalogue yourself** — do not launch with an empty storefront. Write the first 20 packages with your first 20 creators, by hand, in a room.

---

10. Custom campaigns

The Upwork-shaped fallback for anything the presets do not cover. Brand writes a brief, creators apply, brand shortlists and hires.

```
CustomCampaign:
  brief: {objective, description, references, do_not}
  targeting: {creator_types, categories, locations, age_range, languages,
              min_quality_score, audience_filters}
  slots: {count: 10, budget_per_slot_kes | total_budget_kes}
  application: {requires_pitch, requires_sample, requires_quote, deadline}
  selection: {auto_accept_threshold | manual_shortlist}
```

REC **The known failure mode of this format is application spam** — 200 low-quality applications, brand overwhelmed, brand leaves. Guard it from day one: - **Limit concurrent applications per creator** (start at 10 active). - **Require a pitch that references the brief**, not a template. - **Rank applications by match score, never chronologically.** - **Show the brand only the top 20** by default, with the rest one click away. - **Charge applications against a weekly quota** that expands with reputation. A Gold creator gets more shots because they convert.

REC Custom campaigns should be a *minority* of GMV. If they exceed ~30% of volume, it means your presets do not match real demand and the catalogue needs rework. **Instrument this ratio as a product-market-fit signal** — it is one of the most informative numbers you will have.

What this buys you

One collaboration entity, one funding and escrow path, one deliverable state machine, one dispute process, one reputation ledger — and ten purchasable products on the surface. Adding "podcast sponsorship" or "billboard shoot" later is a preset, not a project.

REC **Launch with four of the ten:** Location Visits, Paid UGC, Product Seeding, Influencer Posts. Add Packages and Custom in month two. Hold Affiliate, Hybrid, Events and standalone Licensing until you have real dispute and attribution data. Rationale is in `14-roadmap-mvp.md`.

04

Marketplace Economics

ASSUMPTION All conversions at **KSh 129 = US$1**. Verify at time of use.

Part 4 — Evaluating the thirteen models

Option	Verdict	Reasoning
A. % from brands	✅ **CORE**	Brand is the party with budget, the party receiving the guarantee, and the party least fee-sensitive (they are used to 20–40% agency markups).
B. % from creators	❌ Not at launch	Every competitor and agency does this. Refusing to is your loudest supply message. FACT Collabstr charges creators 15%; Fiverr 20%.
C. Both sides	⚠️ Later, selectively	Only for creator-originated demand (Deal Desk).
D. Brand subscription	❌ Not at launch	Requires proven, repeated value. Kills trial. Kenyan SMEs do not buy SaaS.
E. Freemium + transaction fee	✅ **CORE**	Free to browse and post; pay only when you transact. Zero-risk entry, aligned incentives.
F. Managed campaign service	✅ **YES — and larger than you think**	15–25% premium over self-serve. At launch this *is* the product for most buyers.
G. Escrow fee	❌	Do not itemise. Escrow is the promise, not a line item — charging for it undermines it.
H. Payment processing fee	⚠️ Absorb, don't charge	Absorb into take rate. An extra visible fee at checkout is the #1 conversion killer.
I. Creator verification fee	❌ **Never**	Charging poor creators for the privilege of being trusted is predatory, invites fraud (people who pay expect access), and would be your worst PR moment.
J. Premium creator placement	⚠️ V3 only	Corrupts ranking integrity, which is your product. Only after ranking quality is proven and defensible.
K. Agency accounts	✅ **V2**	High AOV, low CAC, repeat. See Part 32 in `07-product-spec.md`.
L. Enterprise accounts	✅ **V2–V3**	Where large GMV actually lives — telcos, banks, FMCG.
M. Affiliate / performance rev	⚠️ V3	Best long-term margin; requires attribution infrastructure you will not have for 18 months.

The recommendation

REC **Launch model: A + E + F.**

```
Brand pays:      creator rate  +  15% service fee
Creator receives: 100% of their listed rate
Platform keeps:   the 15%
Managed service:  +10% (total 25%) when the platform runs the campaign
Creator fee:      0% — guaranteed in writing for 24 months
```

Two deliberate exceptions:

1. **Deal Desk (creator-originated):** creator brings their own existing client → **creator pays 5%, brand pays 0%**. Precedent: FACT Upwork Direct Contracts at 5%. Rationale: the creator generated the demand, so the platform's contribution is escrow + contract + guaranteed payout, which is worth 5% and not 15%.
2. **Product-only seeding: flat listing fee** (e.g. KSh 500/creator slot) rather than a percentage, because there is no cash flow to take a percentage of.

Why 15% and not 20%? FACT Collabstr's effective blended take is ~25% (10% brand + 15% creator). FACT Fiverr's is ~25%. Both operate in markets with high switching friction. **Kenya has near-zero switching friction — both parties already have M-Pesa and WhatsApp.** A 25% blended take here is an invitation to disintermediate on transaction two. 15% single-sided is defensible; 25% two-sided is not.

Why not 10%? The economics below show that at KSh 10,000 AOV, payment costs alone consume 14–21% of revenue. At 10% take you cannot fund human ops, and human ops is what makes the marketplace work in year one.

Part 34 — Fee psychology: on-top vs deducted

Your two framings:

(a) On-top: Brand pays KSh 10,000 + KSh 1,500 fee = **KSh 11,500**. Creator receives **KSh 10,000**. **(b) Deducted:** Brand pays **KSh 10,000**. Creator receives **KSh 8,500**.

Identical economics. Very different behaviour.

	(a) On-top	(b) Deducted
Creator perception	**"I keep 100%."** Recruiting weapon.	"They take a cut like everyone else."
Creator rate-setting	Honest — they list their true rate	**They inflate to compensate**, so listed prices drift upward and comparability breaks
Brand perception	Sees a fee, may resent it	Sees one clean number
Off-platform pressure	Brand tempted to skip the fee	**Creator** tempted to skip the fee
Price transparency	High — one rate, one fee	Low — rates are quietly padded
Precedent	Airbnb, Upwork client fee	Fiverr, Collabstr creator fee

REC **Use (a), on-top, displayed transparently.**

Three reasons, in order of weight:

1. **It is the strongest supply-acquisition message available, and supply is your binding constraint in year one.** "You keep every shilling you charge" is unambiguous, verifiable, and directly attacks the grievance the entire Kenyan creator market has with agencies.
2. **It prevents rate inflation.** Under (b), every creator pads their listed price by the fee, which destroys the price comparability that makes a marketplace legible.
3. **It moves disintermediation pressure to the brand, where you can defend it.** The brand is the party receiving escrow protection, dispute cover, guaranteed replacement, and a rights contract. That is a

defensible 15%. The creator, under (b), receives nothing they can point to — so their incentive to leave is unanswerable.

REC **Show the fee as a value line, never a naked deduction:**

```
Creator fee (Amina W.)                    KSh 10,000
Platform service fee (15%)                 KSh 1,500
  ↳ Escrow protection · Free replacement if she doesn't deliver
  ↳ Signed usage-rights contract · Dispute resolution
─────────────────────────────────────────────────────
Total                                     KSh 11,500
```

REC **Never itemise the M-Pesa cost separately.** Absorb it. A second fee line at checkout reads as nickel-and-diming and measurably reduces conversion.

Part 4 (cont.) — Revenue at GMV scale

Monthly platform revenue by monthly GMV and take rate (KSh):

Monthly GMV	5%	10%	12.5%	15%	20%
1,000,000	50,000	100,000	125,000	**150,000**	200,000
5,000,000	250,000	500,000	625,000	**750,000**	1,000,000
10,000,000	500,000	1,000,000	1,250,000	**1,500,000**	2,000,000
50,000,000	2,500,000	5,000,000	6,250,000	**7,500,000**	10,000,000
100,000,000	5,000,000	10,000,000	12,500,000	**15,000,000**	20,000,000

Annualised at 15% take:

Monthly GMV	Annual GMV	Annual revenue	≈ USD
KSh 1M	KSh 12M	KSh 1.8M	~$14,000
KSh 5M	KSh 60M	KSh 9M	~$70,000
KSh 10M	KSh 120M	KSh 18M	~$140,000
KSh 50M	KSh 600M	KSh 90M	~$698,000
KSh 100M	KSh 1.2B	KSh 180M	~$1,395,000

Read this table against the market size

FACT Statista models Kenya's entire influencer advertising market at **~US$2.1M (2024), ~US$3.0M (2028)** — roughly **KSh 270M–390M per year**.

KSh 100M GMV per month is KSh 1.2B per year — roughly 3–4x the entire modelled Kenyan influencer advertising market.

REC **This is the arithmetic that must drive strategy.** To reach even $1.4M ARR you must be capturing budget that is *not* classified as influencer advertising: - content **production** budgets (recurring, larger, and not in the statistic) - SME **marketing** budgets (informal, invisible to Statista, potentially large in aggregate) -

regional GMV (Uganda, Tanzania, Rwanda, Ethiopia) - **export** GMV (global brands buying African creators at a 3–5x cost advantage)

A Kenya-only, influencer-only take-rate business tops out somewhere around **$200k–$400k ARR.** That is the honest ceiling, and you should say it out loud in every strategy conversation.

Part 48 — Full business simulation

ASSUMPTION All cost inputs below are my estimates for Nairobi in 2026 and must be replaced with real quotes. Payment-cost inputs are grounded in FACT : M-Pesa B2C offers a *Business Pays* tariff where the customer pays KSh 0 on amounts from KSh 1 to KSh 250,000, a 50/50 *Shared Cost* option, and a *Customer Pays* option; aggregator collection pricing in Kenya is commonly quoted in the 1.5–3.5% range and is negotiable with volume.

Scenario 1 — 100 brands · 1,000 creators · 500 collaborations/month

Line	Amount (KSh/mo)	Note
Collaborations	500	
Average order value	10,000	
GMV	**5,000,000**	
Platform revenue @15%	750,000	
Creator payouts	(5,000,000)	pass-through
Collection cost @1.5% of 5.75M	(86,250)	STK Push via aggregator
Payout cost @1% + KSh 45/txn	(72,500)	B2C, business absorbs
Payment cost total	**(158,750)**	**21.2% of revenue**
Ops & support (4 FTE @ 80,000)	(320,000)	manual campaign ops
Gross profit	**271,250**	**36% gross margin**
Engineering & product (4 FTE @ 250,000)	(1,000,000)	
Marketing	(500,000)	
Infrastructure & tools	(100,000)	
G&A	(300,000)	
Net	**(1,628,750)**	**≈ −$12,600/month**

Scenario 2 — 1,000 brands · 10,000 creators · 5,000 collaborations/month

Line	Amount (KSh/mo)	Note
GMV	**50,000,000**	AOV still 10,000
Platform revenue @15%	7,500,000	
Collection @1.0% of 57.5M	(575,000)	volume-negotiated

Line	Amount (KSh/mo)	Note
Payout @0.5% + KSh 45/txn	(475,000)	
Payment cost total	**(1,050,000)**	**14% of revenue**
Ops & support (15 FTE @ 80,000)	(1,200,000)	~333 orders/person
Gross profit	**5,250,000**	**70% gross margin**
Engineering & product (12 @ 300,000)	(3,600,000)	
Marketing	(3,000,000)	
Infrastructure	(400,000)	
G&A	(1,500,000)	
Net	**(3,250,000)**	**≈ −$25,200/month**

Note: at this stage, cutting marketing to KSh 1M would bring it to roughly breakeven — the loss is a growth choice, not a structural one.

Scenario 3 — 10,000 brands · 100,000 creators · 50,000 collaborations/month

Line	Amount (KSh/mo)	Note
GMV	**500,000,000**	**≈ $3.9M/month — pan-African + export only**
Platform revenue @15%	75,000,000	
Collection @1.0%	(5,750,000)	
Payout @0.5% + KSh 40/txn	(4,500,000)	
Payment cost total	**(10,250,000)**	**13.7% of revenue**
Ops & support (33 FTE @ 90,000)	(2,970,000)	~1,500 orders/person via automation
Gross profit	**61,780,000**	**82% gross margin**
Engineering & product (40 @ 350,000)	(14,000,000)	
Marketing	(15,000,000)	
Infrastructure & AI	(3,000,000)	
Fraud, disputes, refunds	(2,000,000)	
G&A	(8,000,000)	
Net	**+19,780,000**	**≈ +$153,000/month · 26% net margin**

The four things these models actually tell you

1. Payment cost is a structural tax that never disappears. 14–21% of revenue, in every scenario. It improves with negotiation but not with scale beyond a point, because M-Pesa's cost floor is real. REC **Negotiate aggregator pricing from day one, batch payouts where creators consent, and build the business case for a direct Safaricom relationship at scale.**

2. AOV matters far more than take rate.

At 500 collaborations/month, holding everything else constant:

AOV	GMV	Revenue @15%	Gross profit	Δ vs baseline
KSh 10,000	5.0M	750,000	271,250	baseline
KSh 20,000	10.0M	1,500,000	862,500	**+218%**
KSh 40,000	20.0M	3,000,000	2,045,000	**+654%**

Doubling AOV more than triples gross profit, because ops cost is per-*order*, not per-shilling, and payout cost is largely per-transaction. Raising the take rate from 15% to 20% at KSh 10,000 AOV adds only KSh 250,000 of revenue and costs you competitive position.

> REC **Make average order value the primary commercial objective of the company. Not take rate. Not creator count.**
>
> The levers: multi-creator campaigns (10 creators × KSh 5,000 = one KSh 50,000 order), packages and add-ons, rights upgrades, retainers, managed service, and agency/enterprise accounts.

3. Human ops cost per order must fall by roughly 4.5x between Scenario 1 and 3 (from ~125 to ~1,500 orders per ops FTE). If it does not, Scenario 3 is loss-making. REC **Instrument cost-to-serve per completed collaboration from the first month and hold it as a board metric.**

4. Breakeven is roughly KSh 25–35M GMV/month at 15% take with a lean team — call it **~2,500 collaborations at KSh 10,000, or ~700 at KSh 40,000.** The second path is dramatically more achievable, which is the whole argument for AOV.

Part 33 — Subscriptions

REC **No subscriptions at launch. Introduce in V2, and only for brands.**

Why not at launch: FACT GRIN, Modash, Aspire, Upfluence and CreatorIQ all sell subscriptions to customers who *already* run creator programs and know the value. Kenyan SMEs are not that customer, do not buy SaaS, and will not pay before receiving value. A subscription at launch converts your funnel from "try it for free, pay when it works" to "pay to find out" — which in a low-trust market is fatal.

V2 tiering, once repeat purchase is proven:

Plan	Price	Take rate	For
Free	KSh 0	15%	Everyone. Full marketplace access.
Growth	KSh 15,000/mo	12%	3 seats, saved creator lists, campaign templates, basic analytics
Pro	KSh 45,000/mo	10%	10 seats, API, rights library, ROI attribution, priority support
Enterprise	Custom	7–8%	SSO, procurement, custom contracts, dedicated manager, invoicing terms

REC **The pricing logic must be "subscription buys a lower take rate."** This is self-selecting: a brand only upgrades when its GMV makes the maths work, which means every upgrade is a brand that has already proven repeat purchase. Breakeven for Growth is ~KSh 500,000 monthly GMV; for Pro, ~KSh 900,000. Show that calculator in the product and let brands upgrade themselves.

REC **Never subscription-gate creators.** Ever. It is the fastest way to destroy supply and the reputation of the platform.

05

Payment Infrastructure

> **This document is not legal advice.** Kenyan payments law is a licensed area. Everything in the compliance section must be reviewed by a Kenyan advocate with CBK/NPS experience before you accept a single shilling. The design below is structured specifically to *reduce* the legal surface, but it does not eliminate it.

The regulatory constraint that shapes everything

FACT Under the **National Payment System Act 2011** and the **National Payment System Regulations 2014**, an entity intending to process retail payments, facilitate e-commerce collections, operate digital wallets, or act as an aggregator must obtain a **Payment Service Provider (PSP) licence from the Central Bank of Kenya**. PSPs must protect consumer funds through **segregated client accounts or escrow mechanisms**, and applicants must submit an investment strategy for trust funds and details of any custodial trust relationship. (CBK authorisation checklist, CBK guidelines, CM Advocates)

You said: *"Do not assume we can legally hold customer funds indefinitely."* **You are right to be cautious, and the caution should go further:** the risk is not only duration, it is *character*. A balance a user can top up, hold, and spend at will is **stored value** and looks like e-money. A sum received for one identified transaction, held briefly, and paid to one identified recipient looks like **conditional settlement**. The first is a licensing problem; the second is much closer to ordinary commercial escrow.

The three architectures, and the recommendation

	A. Aggregator-settled (RECOMMENDED for V1)	B. Trust account + partner bank	C. Own PSP licence
Who holds float	Licensed aggregator (IntaSend / Paystack / Pesapal / Flutterwave)	Ring-fenced trust account, independent trustee	You
Regulatory burden	Lowest — you are a merchant	Medium — contractual trust, still needs opinion	Highest — full CBK licensing
Time to launch	Weeks	3–6 months	12–18+ months
Cost	Transaction fees	Legal + trustee + audit	Capital, compliance team, audit
Payout control	Via aggregator API	Direct B2C	Direct B2C
Economics	Worst	Better	Best
When	**Launch → ~KSh 30M GMV/mo**	KSh 30–150M/mo	Beyond, or if payments become a product

REC **Launch on A. Plan for B. Only pursue C if financial services become a business line rather than a cost centre.**

The reasoning is not just speed. Architecture A means **the regulated float never sits in your name**. Money moves brand → aggregator's regulated account → creator. Your database records *entitlement*; the licensed party holds *funds*. That is a materially smaller legal surface, and it is also the honest description of what you are: a marketplace that instructs payments, not a bank.

Design rules that keep you on the right side of the line

REC These are architectural commitments, not preferences:

1. **Escrow is always bound to one identified collaboration.** No general-purpose balance. Money enters *for* a specific contract.
2. **Escrow has a hard maximum duration.** REC 60 days. On expiry it auto-resolves (release or refund per policy) — it never simply sits.
3. **Creator earnings auto-sweep to M-Pesa.** Default: automatic payout on approval. If you offer a "hold my earnings" option at all, cap it — REC 7 days, then forced payout. A creator balance that accrues indefinitely starts to look like a deposit-taking product.
4. **No creator-to-creator transfers. No top-ups without a purchase. No withdrawal to anything but the verified owner's own M-Pesa number.** Each of these, individually, moves you toward looking like a wallet.
5. **Never pay interest on, or invest, held balances.** That is the brightest line in the room.
6. **Full double-entry ledger from day one**, reconciled daily against the aggregator. See below.

The money flows

Flow 1 — Brand funds a collaboration (STK Push)

```
Brand confirms order (KSh 11,500 = 10,000 creator + 1,500 fee)
   → Platform creates EscrowIntent (status: PENDING)
   → STK Push to brand's phone via aggregator
   → Brand enters M-Pesa PIN
   → Aggregator callback → verify amount + reference + idempotency key
   → EscrowIntent → FUNDED
   → Collaboration → IN_PROGRESS, creator notified (WhatsApp + push)
```

FACT STK Push (Lipa na M-Pesa Online) requires a registered Paybill or Till shortcode, publicly accessible HTTPS callback URLs, IP whitelisting, a signed go-live letter, and a defined use case; **6–8 weeks from sandbox to production is typical for a well-prepared team**. (Daraja go-live guide, Hostiko)

REC **Engineering non-negotiables for STK Push** — these are where teams lose money: - **Never trust the callback alone.** Always reconcile with a transaction status query. Callbacks are lost, duplicated and delayed. - **Idempotency on `CheckoutRequestID`.** Duplicate callbacks are normal, not exceptional. - **Handle the timeout ambiguity explicitly.** A user who does not enter their PIN leaves the request in limbo; poll status and expire cleanly. - **Assume partial and mismatched amounts.** Users type wrong amounts on Paybill. Reconcile by amount *and* reference; quarantine mismatches for manual review rather than auto-crediting. - **Above STK limits, fall back to Paybill with a generated account number.** Large campaign funding will exceed transaction ceilings.

REC **For orders above ~KSh 150,000, offer bank transfer / Pesalink as the primary rail.** Agency and enterprise buyers will not fund a KSh 400,000 campaign by phone prompt, and forcing them to will cost you your highest-AOV customers.

Flow 2 — Creator payout (B2C)

```
Brand approves deliverable
   → Collaboration → APPROVED
   → PayoutInstruction created (idempotency key = collaboration_id)
   → B2C to creator's VERIFIED M-Pesa number (must match KYC name)
   → Callback → PAID, receipt stored, creator notified
   → Target: under 60 minutes. Publish the median.
```

FACT M-Pesa B2C offers three tariff models: **Business Pays** (customer pays KSh 0 on KSh 1–250,000), **Shared Cost / Mgao** (50/50), and **Customer Pays**. Safaricom also cut merchant transfer fees by up to 50% effective 7 August 2026, with large Till-to-Paybill transfers capped at KSh 52. (M-Pesa charges 2026)

REC **Always use Business Pays and absorb the cost.** "KSh 10,000 means KSh 10,000 in your phone" is a promise worth far more than the KSh 40–60 it costs. Creators notice deductions and talk about them publicly.

REC **Payout speed is your headline product claim.** Publish the rolling median time from approval to M-Pesa on the homepage and in the creator app. It is verifiable, it is the thing creators care about most, and ASSUMPTION it is the grievance the entire Kenyan creator market has with agencies. Make it a number you defend, not a promise you make.

Flow 3 — Split payments and milestones

REC **Default structures by order size:**

Order value	Structure
< KSh 10,000	100% on approval (single release)
KSh 10,000–50,000	30% on acceptance / 70% on approval
> KSh 50,000	Milestones
Visits & events	100% escrowed; travel stipend released at check-in

REC **The 30% upfront is a trust device, not a cash-flow device.** Its purpose is to prove to the creator that the money is real before they spend a day filming. It should be non-refundable except for creator non-performance — otherwise it provides no assurance at all.

Milestone template for larger work:

#	Milestone	Release	Trigger
1	Concept / script approved	20%	Brand approves concept
2	Draft delivered	30%	Creator uploads draft
3	Final approved	40%	Brand approves final
4	Published + proof verified	10%	Proof verified (if publishing required)

The whole amount is escrowed at funding. Milestones govern *release*, never *collection* — otherwise the creator has no assurance, which defeats the purpose.

Refunds and the failure matrix

Scenario	Escrow outcome	Creator record	Brand record
Creator disappears (no contact 72h past deadline)	100% refund to brand	Non-completion; 3 in 90 days → suspension	Free replacement creator offered
Creator misses deadline (delivers late, work is fine)	Release in full	Late delivery logged; affects on-time %	—
Brand cancels before creator accepts	100% refund	—	No penalty
Brand cancels after acceptance, before work starts	90% refund; **10% kill fee to creator**	—	Cancellation rate ↑
Brand cancels after work started	50% refund; **50% to creator**	—	Cancellation rate ↑↑
Brand cancels after delivery	No refund	—	Cancellation rate ↑↑↑
Brand won't approve legitimate work	Auto-release after **5 days** of silence	—	Non-response logged
Poor quality work	Revision → mediation → partial/full refund	Quality flag	—
Revision requested	Escrow holds; clock pauses	—	Counts against revision limit
Product never delivered (seeding)	Cancel, no fault to creator	**No penalty**	Fulfilment reliability ↓
Creator posted, then deleted early	Clawback from future earnings or refund	Serious violation	—

REC **The auto-release rule is the single most important line in this table.** A brand that goes silent must not be able to hold a creator's money hostage. **Five days of no response after submission → automatic release.** State it in the creator terms, in the brief, and in the UI countdown. It is the mirror image of escrow: escrow protects the brand from a creator who vanishes; auto-release protects the creator from a brand that vanishes. **Without both, the marketplace is only trustworthy in one direction — and the untrusted side is the side you cannot afford to lose.**

Full evidence standards, revision limits and adjudication rules are in `06-trust-reputation-fraud.md`.

KYC — tiered to transaction value

REC Do not front-load KYC. Every field before a creator's first earning is a drop-off. Escalate with money at stake:

Tier	Trigger	Required	Enables
0	Signup	Phone OTP (M-Pesa-registered number)	Browse, apply
1	First paid collaboration	Full name matching M-Pesa registration; email	Earn up to KSh 20,000/month
2	Cumulative KSh 50,000	National ID / passport + selfie liveness; ID-to-M-Pesa name match	Up to KSh 200,000/month

Tier	Trigger	Required	Enables
3	Cumulative KSh 500,000 or business	**KRA PIN**; business registration if applicable	Unlimited; withholding-tax handling

Brands: business name + KRA PIN + contact verification before their first campaign goes live; certificate of incorporation for credit terms or invoicing.

REC **The M-Pesa-name-match check is your single highest-value fraud control** and it is nearly free: the payout name must match the KYC name. It defeats most account-takeover and mule-account patterns in one step, because M-Pesa registration is already ID-bound.

The tax issue you must design for now

FACT Kenya applies a **5% withholding tax on digital content monetisation** for residents (**20% for non-residents**), in law since the Finance Act 2023 and effective 1 July 2023. Enforcement moved to withholding-at-source during 2026: **Meta began withholding 5% from Facebook and Instagram creator payouts in January 2026**, and **Google/YouTube began withholding from September 2026 earnings (paid October 2026)**, requiring a verified **KRA PIN on file in AdSense by 1 October 2026**. KRA guidance lists digital content monetisation among payments subject to withholding, covering ads, subscriptions, **brand deals**, and affiliate income. The Digital Content Creators Association of Kenya has publicly urged the Treasury and KRA to pause collection pending industry engagement. (Techweez, TechTrends KE, KICTANet)

Why this is a product decision and not a footnote:

If your platform is a payer of digital content monetisation income, ASSUMPTION it may itself carry a withholding obligation on creator payouts. Whether it does — and on which collaboration types — is a **question for a Kenyan tax advisor, urgently, before launch.** Getting it wrong in either direction is expensive: withhold when you should not and you underpay creators; fail to withhold when you should and you accrue a liability with penalties.

REC **Build the capability now, switch it on when advised:** - `withholding_rate` as a configurable field per collaboration type and residency status - KRA PIN capture at Tier 3 KYC (and encourage earlier) - **Automatic withholding certificate generation** for every payout — this is a genuine creator benefit, because most creators cannot produce their own tax records - Annual earnings statements per creator - Gross/net clearly separated everywhere in the UI, never conflated

REC **Turn compliance into a feature.** *"We handle your creator tax paperwork"* is a real differentiator in a market where FACT withholding-at-source has just arrived and creators are visibly anxious about it. It is also, straightforwardly, the right thing to do. The informal WhatsApp economy cannot offer it, and that is a genuine reason to transact on-platform rather than off it.

Reconciliation and the ledger

REC **Double-entry from commit one.** Retrofitting a ledger onto a payments system that has been running for a year is one of the most expensive mistakes available to you.

```
Accounts:
  brand_receivable        (per brand)
  escrow_held             (per collaboration)   ← liability
  platform_revenue        (fees earned)
  creator_payable         (per creator)         ← liability
  payment_costs           (expense)
  tax_withheld            (liability, if applicable)

Invariant, always:
  Σ escrow_held + Σ creator_payable == aggregator settlement balance
```

Daily automated reconciliation against the aggregator statement, with any break over KSh 100 raising an alert. **REC** **A named person owns reconciliation from month one.** Payment breaks compound silently and are discovered at the worst possible moment.

Required per-transaction record: M-Pesa receipt number, phone number (masked in UI, full in ledger), amount, timestamp, collaboration ID, direction, tariff applied, aggregator reference, reconciliation status. Retain for **7 years** **ASSUMPTION — confirm the applicable retention period with counsel**, and note that this interacts with Data Protection Act minimisation obligations (see `13-legal-compliance.md`).

Multi-currency and the export path

REC Architect for it now, ship it in V3. Store **every** monetary amount as `{amount_minor, currency}` — never a bare number. Retrofitting currency is brutal.

When export becomes real: brand pays USD by card → platform converts → creator receives KSh via M-Pesa. FX spread becomes an additional revenue line, and **ASSUMPTION** a materially better-margin one than the take rate. Regional expansion adds MTN MoMo and Airtel Money (Uganda, Tanzania, Rwanda) — which is precisely why the payments layer must be **provider-abstracted from day one**:

```
PaymentProvider (interface)
  ├── MpesaDarajaProvider      (via aggregator at V1, direct at scale)
  ├── AirtelMoneyProvider      (V4)
  ├── MtnMomoProvider          (V4)
  └── CardProvider             (V3, export)
```

Every collaboration references a provider-agnostic `PaymentInstruction`. If M-Pesa is hard-coded into your domain logic, East African expansion becomes a rewrite rather than a configuration.

06

Trust, Reputation, Disputes, Fraud

The framing correction

You wrote: *"The biggest problem is not discovery. It is TRUST."* Correct — but trust is not one problem. It is **four different problems with four different solutions**, and platforms fail by building a rating system and calling it done.

Question	Solved by	Not solved by
"Is this creator real?"	Identity + social verification	Ratings
"Will they deliver?"	Reliability history + escrow	Follower count
"Will the work be good?"	Portfolio + quality score	Reliability score
"Will I actually get paid?"	**Escrow + auto-release + payout speed**	**Anything else**

REC The fourth is the one that decides whether creators join, and it is solved by **payment architecture, not reputation design**. Escrow-funded-before-work plus five-day auto-release plus sub-hour M-Pesa payout does more for trust than any scoring system you could build. Build that first; the score is a refinement.

Part 6 — The Creator Reputation Score

Principle: one number for ranking, five for humans

REC Compute a single internal score for ranking and matching, but **never show the composite to users**. Show the five components. A creator who sees "72/100" learns nothing and feels judged; a creator who sees "On-time: 94% · Approval: 88% · Quality: 4.6" knows exactly what to fix. Composites also invite gaming in ways components do not, because the target is ambiguous.

The five components

```
CRS = 0.30·Reliability
    + 0.25·Quality
    + 0.20·BrandSatisfaction
    + 0.15·AudienceAuthenticity
    + 0.10·Performance
```

Reliability (30%) — the heaviest weight, deliberately. It is the most objective and the most predictive of a bad experience.

```
on_time_rate          0.40   delivered before deadline
completion_rate       0.35   accepted → completed
response_time         0.15   median first response to a brief
cancellation_rate     0.10   inverted; creator-initiated only
```

Content Quality (25%) — decoupled from audience entirely. This is what makes a 2,000-follower videographer rank above a 100,000-follower poster.

```
brand_quality_ratings   0.45   1–5, per completed job
revision_rate           0.20   inverted — fewer revisions = better briefs met
first_pass_approval     0.20   approved without revision
portfolio_assessment    0.15   human/model review at onboarding, decays over time
```

Brand Satisfaction (20%)

```
average_rating          0.40
repeat_booking_rate     0.35   ← the strongest signal in the entire system
would_recommend         0.15
dispute_rate            0.10   inverted
```

Audience Authenticity (15%) — weighted *down* on purpose, and set to zero for UGC-only creators.

```
follower_growth_pattern 0.30   organic curve vs step-jumps
engagement_consistency  0.25   variance across recent posts
audience_geography      0.25   Kenyan audience for Kenyan brands
comment_authenticity    0.20   text diversity vs emoji-bot patterns
```

Performance (10%) — only for creators with sufficient completed campaigns.

```
views_vs_predicted      0.40   actual/expected given follower count
engagement_vs_category  0.30
conversion_rate         0.30   where trackable
```

Design rules that make it survive contact with reality

REC

1. **Cold start with a neutral prior, not zero.** New creators enter at the category median with wide uncertainty, not at the bottom. Otherwise no new creator ever gets a first job and supply calcifies. Use a Bayesian shrinkage: `score = (prior·k + observed·n)/(k+n)` with `k ≈ 5`. This also makes early scores hard to game — five perfect jobs do not produce a perfect score.
2. **Confidence intervals, not point estimates.** A creator with 3 jobs and 5.0 stars must not outrank one with 60 jobs and 4.7. Rank by the **lower bound** of the confidence interval (Wilson score), which is the standard, correct answer to this problem.
3. **Recency decay.** 180-day half-life. Reputation must be losable and recoverable.
4. **Separate scores by collaboration type.** Excellence at UGC says little about reliability at a 7am location visit. Maintain per-type reliability sub-scores once volume allows.
5. **Value-weight the ratings.** A 5-star on a KSh 50,000 job carries more weight than on a KSh 1,000 job.
6. **Never let follower count enter the score.** It enters *reach estimation*, which is a different thing and must be labelled as such.

Anti-gaming

REC The attacks, in order of likelihood in this market:

Attack	Defence
Fake brand account books own creator, leaves 5 stars	**Ratings only count from escrow-settled collaborations.** Gaming costs real money through the payment rail. This one control defeats most review fraud.

Attack	Defence
Circular rings — creators book each other	Graph analysis on brand↔creator bipartite structure; flag closed loops, shared devices, shared funding instruments, and brands whose only bookings are with one creator
Many tiny jobs to farm volume	Value-weighted ratings + diminishing returns per brand pair
Bought followers/engagement	Authenticity component + growth-curve anomaly detection; note this is only 15% of the score by design
Pressuring brands for 5 stars	**Double-blind reviews** — neither side sees the other's review until both submit or 14 days elapse. Add a private "would you rebook?" field never shown to the creator.
Abandoning a damaged account, re-registering	Identity + M-Pesa number binding; device fingerprinting; the same national ID cannot hold two creator accounts
Collusion with a friendly brand for a fake track record	Repeat-booking weight caps per brand pair; require breadth of distinct brands for tier progression

REC **The single strongest structural defence: reputation is only earned through settled money.** Anchor every reputational event to an escrow transaction. It makes fraud expensive, traceable, and reversible.

Part 26 — Brand reputation (do not skip this)

REC Most platforms rate creators only. That is a design choice that tells creators they are the product rather than the customer, and in a supply-constrained market it is a strategic error.

Brand Trust Score, shown on every campaign listing:

```
payment_reliability     0.30   funds escrow promptly, no failed funding
approval_speed          0.25   median hours from submission to decision
revision_reasonableness 0.20   avg revisions requested vs platform norm
cancellation_rate       0.15   inverted
creator_rating          0.10   1–5 from creators who worked with them
```

Displayed on the campaign card as facts, not a grade:

```
Nairobi Grill  ·  ⭐ 4.7 from 23 creators
✅ Pays on time (100%)      ⏱ Approves in ~6 hours
🔁 1.2 revisions average    ↩️ 4% cancellation rate
```

REC **This is a genuine differentiator and it costs almost nothing.** Creators currently have no way to know which Kenyan brands pay and which waste their time — that information exists only as gossip in WhatsApp groups. Making it structured and public is a real service and a strong reason for creators to choose you. It also disciplines brand behaviour: a brand that sees "you approve slower than 80% of brands" will speed up.

REC **Additional brand-side controls worth having:** - **Auto-approve default** at 5 days protects creators structurally, not just reputationally. - **Revision caps** enforced by the system, not by negotiation. - **Escrow-before-visibility:** for location visits and events, do not release the venue address or booking details until funds are escrowed.

Part 13 — The dispute system

Principles

REC 1. **Most disputes are brief failures, not bad faith.** The brief template is your primary dispute-prevention tool — invest there first. 2. **Automate the majority.** Deadline breaches, non-delivery and non-response are objectively determinable from timestamps. Only genuine quality disagreements need a human. 3. **Speed beats perfection.** A dispute resolved in 48 hours at 80% fairness beats one resolved in three weeks at 95%. Both parties are small operators; time hurts them more than money. 4. **Escrow always splits; it never evaporates.** Every resolution assigns 100% of the held funds somewhere. 5. **Publish the rules in advance.** Predictability is most of perceived fairness.

Structural prevention (before any dispute exists)

- **Structured briefs.** Required fields for deliverables, deadline, platforms, must-include, must-avoid, disclosure text, rights. Free-text-only briefs are the root cause of most quality disputes.
- **Revision limits, contractual and enforced.** Default **1 included**, maximum **2**; a third is a paid add-on. This directly answers *"the brand keeps requesting unlimited revisions."*
- **Revision scope rules.** A revision must reference a specific brief requirement that was not met. **"I changed my mind" is a new order, not a revision** — the system should say so, in those words, in the revision form.
- **Concept-approval milestone** on jobs over KSh 20,000, so misalignment surfaces before filming rather than after.

The escalation ladder

```
L0  Self-serve      Revision request within the included allowance     0–24h
L1  Guided          Structured claim + evidence; counterparty 48h reply
L2  Auto-resolve    Objective rules decide (see table)                 instant
L3  Mediation       Platform proposes a split; both accept → binding   72h
L4  Adjudication    Trained ops decides using evidence rubric          5 days
L5  External        Only above KSh 200,000 — arbitration per T&Cs      —
```

REC **Target: 70% resolved at L0–L2, under 5% ever reaching L4.** If L4 volume exceeds ~5% of disputes, your briefs are broken, not your adjudicators.

Auto-resolution rules (L2)

Condition	Determination	Escrow
No submission 72h past deadline, no contact	Creator default	100% → brand
Submitted on time; brand silent 5 days	Brand non-response	100% → creator
Creator withdraws before starting	Creator cancellation	100% → brand
Brand cancels post-acceptance, pre-work	Brand cancellation	10% → creator, 90% → brand
Brand cancels after work started	Brand cancellation	50/50
Seeded product not delivered within SLA	No fault	100% → brand, no creator penalty
Post deleted before minimum live duration	Creator breach	Clawback / refund
3rd revision demanded, no new scope	Brand over-reach	Release to creator

Evidence standards (L3–L4)

Claim	Creator must show	Brand must show
"Work done, brand won't pay"	Submitted files with platform timestamps; brief compliance mapping	Specific brief clauses unmet, with reference
"Creator ignored the brief"	Mapping of each requirement to the delivery	Annotated brief with cited failures
"Unlimited revisions"	Revision log with requested changes	Justification per revision tied to brief
"Posted late"	Publish timestamp; any agreed extension	Original agreed deadline
"Product never arrived"	**Nothing — burden is on the brand**	Dispatch and delivery proof
"Post was deleted"	Platform evidence or explanation	URL + monitoring record

REC **Note the asymmetry on delivery.** The creator cannot prove a negative, and the brand controls dispatch. Placing the burden on the party that controls the evidence is both fairer and cheaper to adjudicate.

Partial-payout matrix (L4)

Outcome	Creator	Brand	Applies when
Full delivery	100%	0%	Brief met
Substantial	75%	25%	Minor deviations
Partial	50%	50%	Some deliverables met
Minimal	25%	75%	Attempted, largely non-compliant
Non-delivery	0%	100%	Nothing usable

REC **Where the platform is at fault** — a bug, a payment failure, an ops error — **pay both sides in full from platform funds.** Budget for it. It is cheap insurance against the stories that spread fastest.

Consequences

Creator	Threshold	Action
Late delivery	3 in 90 days	Ranking penalty, warning
Non-delivery	1	Warning + reliability hit
	3 in 90 days	Suspension
Fraud (fake proof, stolen content)	1	Permanent ban, funds withheld pending review

Brand	Threshold	Action
Slow approval	median > 72h	Badge shown to creators
Cancellation rate	> 20%	Prepayment required, visibility reduced
Lost disputes	3 in 90 days	Manual review, possible suspension
Non-funding after acceptance	2	Campaign posting suspended

Part 35 — Fraud

Threat model, ranked by expected loss in *this* market

ASSUMPTION Ranking is my judgement for Kenya specifically, not a global ordering.

#	Threat	Likelihood	Impact	Primary control
1	**Off-platform circumvention**	**Very high**	**Very high**	Value-based retention (below)
2	Fake proof of posting (edited screenshots)	High	Medium	URL + API verification, never screenshots alone
3	Content theft — submitting others' work	High	High	Perceptual hashing + reverse search
4	Fake followers / engagement	High	Medium	Authenticity scoring; low score weight
5	Creator takes payment, vanishes	Medium	High	Escrow (structurally solved)
6	Fake brand posts campaign, never funds	Medium	Medium	Escrow-before-visibility
7	Multiple creator accounts	Medium	Medium	ID + M-Pesa binding, device fingerprint
8	Review manipulation / collusion	Medium	High	Settled-transaction gating, graph analysis
9	Account takeover (SIM swap)	Medium	**High**	Payout cooling-off on detail change
10	Seeding fraud (keeps product, never posts)	Medium	Low	Delivery-linked obligations, reputation
11	Payment fraud / stolen instruments	Low-Med	High	Aggregator controls, velocity limits
12	Deepfaked or AI-generated "UGC" passed as real	**Rising**	Medium	Provenance requirements; see below
13	**Brand downloads the draft, then refuses to approve**	**High**	**High**	**Watermark gate — see below**

Controls that matter most

1. Content theft — perceptual hashing. Hash every submitted asset (pHash for images, video fingerprinting for clips). Check against: everything ever submitted to the platform, the creator's own claimed portfolio, and reverse image search. REC This is high-value and cheap. Stolen-portfolio fraud is endemic in freelance marketplaces and will arrive with your first hundred creators.

2. Proof of posting — never trust a screenshot.

```
Tier 1  OAuth API verification          ← strongest, use where available
Tier 2  Public URL + platform scrape    ← verify content, handles, disclosure
Tier 3  Screenshot + URL                ← fallback only, manual review
Tier 4  Screenshot only                 ← treat as unverified, never auto-release
```

FACT API verification has hard limits. **Instagram's Basic Display API was deprecated in December 2024**; all access now runs through the Graph API with app review, business/creator accounts only, and the `instagram_manage_insights` scope returns audience demographics **only for the authenticated account owner**. **TikTok does not return audience age, gender or geographic breakdown through direct API calls.** (Phyllo, Elfsight)

REC Consequence: **creator-authorised OAuth is the only path to trustworthy audience data**, and you must design onboarding to make connecting accounts feel worthwhile — a "Verified Audience" badge that visibly improves ranking. Do not promise brands audience demographics you cannot obtain.

3. The watermark gate — brand-side content theft. REC **This closes a hole in the dispute design above.** As originally specified, a brand could receive a draft, download the file, refuse to approve, open a dispute, obtain a refund, and still hold the asset.

```
DRAFT_SUBMITTED  → watermarked, low-res STREAMING preview only. No download.
PAYMENT_RELEASED → clean master unlocked via a signed, expiring URL.
```

Standard practice in stock-media and design marketplaces. It makes download-then-dispute pointless and gives the rights system real teeth: **the master is gated on settlement, not on approval.** Implementation detail in `10-technical-architecture.md`.

4. Account takeover and SIM swap. Kenya's dependence on phone-number identity makes SIM swap a live risk. REC - Changing the payout number triggers a **24-hour hold plus re-verification** — no exceptions - Any payout to a newly changed number is manually reviewed above a threshold - Alert to email and the old number on any change - Device fingerprint change + payout detail change + immediate withdrawal = automatic freeze

5. AI-generated content passed off as authentic UGC. ASSUMPTION This is a fast-growing problem that most platform designs still ignore. A brand paying for a real person's authentic testimonial is buying authenticity, and synthetic content defrauds them of exactly what they paid for. REC Require an explicit `content_provenance` declaration on every UGC submission (`filmed_by_creator` / `ai_assisted_editing` / `ai_generated`), make misdeclaration a permanent-ban offence, and let brands filter on it. Handled well, this becomes a selling point: *"real people, verifiably."*

The circumvention problem — the honest analysis

REC **You cannot prevent disintermediation in Kenya. Both parties already have WhatsApp and M-Pesa. Any control you build is a speed bump, and aggressive enforcement will simply be resented.**

Detection is still worth building — contact-pattern detection in messages, sudden conversation death after a first job, brands that view many profiles and book none, and a repeat-rate that is anomalously low for a given brand. But **detection without an answer is just surveillance.**

REC **The strategy is to make staying more valuable than leaving:**

Off-platform	On-platform
Trust the brand to pay	Escrow, guaranteed
No recourse	Dispute resolution
No contract	Signed rights contract
Creator vanishes → you lose	Free replacement
No record	Verified earnings history → **advances, credit**
No tax paperwork	Withholding certificates, annual statements
Manual chasing	Automated workflow, reminders, proof

And critically — REC **price the second transaction lower.** Repeat collaborations between the same pair should carry a reduced fee (15% → 10% → 8%). This directly attacks the moment disintermediation is most tempting: right after a successful first job. Upwork's descending fee schedule exists for exactly this reason.

REC **Then go further and make circumvention a product:** the **Deal Desk** (`12-gtm-liquidity-growth.md`) invites off-platform deals *onto* the platform at 5%. Rather than policing a behaviour you cannot stop, monetise it. This is the single best answer to threat #1 on the list, and it is a pricing decision, not an engineering one.

07

Product Specification

Part 7 — The creator profile

You described a blend of LinkedIn + TikTok + Upwork + Airbnb. REC **The weights should be: 60% Upwork (commercial credibility), 25% Airbnb (trust signals), 15% TikTok (work samples). Almost 0% LinkedIn** — CV-style profiles perform badly for creative hiring, because buyers judge from work, not from claims.

The mobile profile, in priority order

```
┌──────────────────────────────────────────┐
│  [Photo]  Amina Wanjiru        ✅ Verified│
│           Food & Lifestyle · Westlands   │
│           ⭐ 4.8 (34 jobs) · 96% on-time  │
│           Replies in ~2h · Available now │
├──────────────────────────────────────────┤
│  ▶ PORTFOLIO — 6 autoplaying clips       │   ← the profile IS the portfolio
├──────────────────────────────────────────┤
│  SERVICES                                │
│  TikTok video (UGC)      from KSh 4,000 │
│  Restaurant visit + post from KSh 7,500 │
│  3-video UGC package        KSh 10,000  │   [Book now]
├──────────────────────────────────────────┤
│  TRACK RECORD                            │
│  34 jobs · 96% on-time · 88% first-pass │
│  11 repeat brands · 0 disputes           │
├──────────────────────────────────────────┤
│  AUDIENCE (verified)                     │
│  TikTok 24,300 · avg 41,200 views       │
│  IG 8,100 · 72% Kenya · 68% female 18-34│
├──────────────────────────────────────────┤
│  WORKED WITH  [logos]  ·  REVIEWS        │
└──────────────────────────────────────────┘
```

REC **Six design decisions, each of which is contested:**

1. **Portfolio above audience.** Always. This one ordering choice encodes the entire "creators, not influencers" thesis. If audience sits above portfolio, you have built an influencer platform regardless of what your marketing says.
2. **Follower count is never the headline.** It appears inside the audience block, below views. **For UGC-only creators it is hidden entirely** — not de-emphasised, absent.
3. **Price is visible and bookable without conversation.** This is the Collabstr mechanic and it is the highest-leverage liquidity feature available.
4. **Response time and availability are prominent.** Airbnb's insight: in a marketplace, *responsiveness* predicts a good experience better than *quality claims*.
5. **Verified audience data must be badged and distinguished from self-reported.** Self-reported numbers are marked as such. FACT Because Instagram's Graph API only returns audience demographics for the authenticated account owner and TikTok returns no audience demographic breakdown at all, verified data is only obtainable through creator OAuth — so the badge is both honest and an incentive to connect.
6. **Show "0 disputes" as a positive.** Absence of trouble is a trust signal and costs nothing to display.

Full field inventory: identity (name, photo, location to ward, languages, gender/age where declared, verification badges); commercial (categories, creator types, services, packages, rate card, minimum booking, turnaround, revision policy, rights defaults, availability); portfolio (up to 20 assets, tagged by type, with declared provenance, plus case studies with results); audience (per connected platform: followers, avg views, engagement rate, audience geography/age/gender where API permits, growth curve, authenticity score); reputation (jobs, on-time %, completion %, first-pass approval %, avg rating, repeat brands, response time, dispute count, tier); brand fit (industries worked, past collaborations, category exclusions, content boundaries).

REC `content_boundaries` **is not optional.** Creators must be able to declare what they will not promote — alcohol, betting, political content, specific categories. Kenya's betting-advertising environment makes this a real welfare and reputational issue, and letting a creator state it in advance prevents both awkward rejections and reputational harm.

Part 8 — Creator types

REC **Your list of 25 conflates three orthogonal dimensions.** Modelling them as one flat list will make filtering incoherent. Split them:

```
CREATOR_TYPE     what they do         (the skill)
NICHE            what they cover      (the subject)
AUDIENCE_TIER    how many follow them  (the reach)
```

Creator types (the skill) — 16: `influencer` · `ugc_creator` · `videographer` · `photographer` · `actor_talent` · `model` · `voiceover_artist` · `comedian_skit` · `podcaster` · `writer_blogger` · `animator_motion` · `designer` · `editor` · `livestreamer` · `event_host_mc` · `translator_localiser`

Niches (the subject) — 24: `food_beverage` · `beauty_skincare` · `fashion` · `fitness_wellness` · `travel_tourism` · `tech_gadgets` · `finance_fintech` · `parenting_family` · `education_student` · `automotive` · `real_estate` · `home_interior` · `health_medical` · `agriculture` · `music_entertainment` · `sports` · `gaming` · `comedy` · `faith` · `business_entrepreneurship` · `pets` · `events_weddings` · `sustainability` · `news_commentary`

REC **Additions worth noting for Kenya specifically:** `agriculture` (agritech and agri-input brands are real advertisers and creators covering farming have highly engaged, commercially valuable audiences), `faith` (large audiences, significant brand caution needed), `translator_localiser` (Swahili/Sheng/vernacular localisation is a genuine paid service and a category no global platform offers), and `event_host_mc` (a live-talent category the incumbents entirely ignore).

Why the separation matters: a brand searching for "a videographer who covers food in Westlands" is filtering on all three axes independently. A flat 25-item list cannot express that query.

Part 19 — Tiers

REC **Keep audience tiers for reach estimation and pricing guidance. Do not use them for ranking. And run two parallel supply pools.**

Tier	Range	Use
Nano	1K–10K	Highest engagement, cheapest, best for volume campaigns
Micro	10K–50K	The workhorse of the Kenyan market

Tier	Range	Use
Mid	50K–250K	
Macro	250K–1M	
Mega	1M+	Rare in Kenya; usually agency-represented
UGC Creator	**N/A**	**Judged on portfolio and reliability only**

Advantages of tiers: brands understand them; they make budget estimation tractable; they support campaign-mix recommendations ("5 nano + 7 micro + 3 mid"); they let you price-band the catalogue.

Disadvantages: they entrench follower count as the organising idea; they push brands toward reach when engagement or craft matters more; they create a status hierarchy that demoralises the nano creators who are the bulk of your supply and often your best performers.

REC **The resolution: tiers are a *filter and pricing aid*, never a *sort order*.** Default sort is always the match score. Tier appears as a small label, not a rank. And **the UGC pool is a separate browsing experience entirely** — different card layout (portfolio-first, no follower count), different ranking (quality + reliability + price), different filters (content type, turnaround, language). Two audiences, two products, one platform.

Part 17 — Creator storefront

FACT This is Collabstr's core liquidity mechanic. REC **It is the single highest-leverage feature you can ship, because it makes the marketplace transactable without a single campaign being posted.**

Every creator gets `flerwa.co.ke/@aminaw` — a public, shareable, indexable storefront:

```
Amina Wanjiru · Food & Lifestyle Creator · Westlands
⭐ 4.8 (34) · 96% on-time · Responds ~2h

TikTok video (UGC)             KSh 4,000   2 days   [Book]
Restaurant visit + 1 TikTok    KSh 7,500   3 days   [Book]
3-video UGC package           KSh 10,000   5 days   [Book]
Product photography (10)       KSh 6,000   3 days   [Book]

Add-ons: Rush 24h +KSh 1,500 · Extra hook +KSh 800
         90-day ad rights +KSh 2,000
```

REC **Why this matters more than it appears:**

- **It inverts the cold-start problem.** A creator with a storefront markets *your platform* every time they share their link — in bios, WhatsApp statuses, DMs. Supply becomes a distribution channel. This is the cheapest demand acquisition available to you.
- **It captures the "brand already knows the creator" case**, which is the majority of Kenyan transactions. The brand does not need discovery; they need a safe way to pay. The storefront is that.
- **It is SEO surface.** Thousands of indexed creator pages capture "hire food creator Nairobi" long-tail search, which is exactly how FACT Collabstr built liquidity without a sales team.
- **Add-ons are the AOV lever.** Rush, extra hooks, rights upgrades routinely add 30–50% to order value — and per `04-economics-and-pricing.md`, AOV is the number that decides whether the business works.

REC **Seed the first 20 storefronts by hand, in a room, with the creators.** An empty storefront is worse than no storefront, and creators left alone will price badly and describe their services vaguely.

Part 18 — Availability

REC **Keep it simple. Elaborate calendars go stale within a week and stale availability is worse than no availability.**

```
Status:  🟢 Available  |  🟡 Busy (until date)  |  🔴 Not accepting
Open to: ☑ Paid work  ☑ Gifted products  ☑ Location visits
         ☑ Urgent (<48h)  ☐ Unpaid/exposure
Capacity: max 3 concurrent orders
Blackout dates: [calendar]
```

REC **Auto-decay availability.** If a creator has not opened the app in 10 days, flip them to "Unconfirmed" and stop surfacing them in urgent matching. A stale "Available" that produces no response is the single most damaging experience for a brand's first booking.

Should brands book specific dates? REC **Yes — but only for location visits and events, where a datetime is intrinsic to the product.** For UGC and posts, sell *turnaround* (delivered within 3 days), not a calendar slot. Calendar booking for asynchronous work adds friction with no benefit.

Part 9 — The brand experience

REC **The onboarding question set you proposed is too long.** A Kenyan SME owner will abandon it. Ask three questions, infer the rest, and collect the remainder inside the campaign flow where each field has obvious purpose.

```
1. What do you want to achieve?        [visual grid, 12 options]
2. Where are your customers?           [Nairobi / ward / national]
3. What's your budget?                 [KSh 5k / 15k / 50k / 150k+ / not sure]
        ↓
   Three recommended campaigns, priced, with expected outputs
```

Objective → campaign type mapping (this is the core of the recommendation engine):

Objective	Campaign type	Creator profile	Typical structure
Awareness	Influencer posts	Micro/mid, niche-matched	5–15 creators, 1 post each
Content production	**Paid UGC**	**UGC creators, portfolio-ranked**	**3–10 videos, rights included**
Sales	Affiliate + hybrid	Converting creators, promo codes	Guarantee + commission
App installs	UGC + paid amplification	Performance-style creators	Videos + Spark Ads rights
Foot traffic	**Location visits**	**Local creators, geo-matched**	**10–20 visits over a weekend**
Event attendance	Influencer + visits	Local, event-adjacent	Pre-event push + coverage
Product launch	Seeding + influencer	Category creators, mixed tiers	Seed 30, post 15
Reviews	Seeding	Reviewers, honest-review positioning	Product + small fee

Objective	Campaign type	Creator profile	Typical structure
UGC library	UGC bulk	UGC creators	20 videos, perpetual rights
Social proof	Seeding + UGC	Nano at volume	Many small
Lead generation	Affiliate (per lead)	Educational/explainer creators	Per qualified lead + guarantee
Foot traffic (retail)	Visits + affiliate	Local + promo codes	Visit + trackable code

REC **Note that "content production" and "foot traffic" are bolded because they are the two objectives no incumbent serves well and the two most common real needs of a Kenyan SME.** Lead with them in the UI grid.

Brand navigation: `Home (campaigns) · Discover creators · Orders · Messages · Wallet · Insights`

Parts 14 & 15 — Discovery

Creator-side discovery (Part 14)

REC **Five surfaces, in order of expected value:**

1. **"For You" feed** — ranked by fit × payout × win probability. REC **Never show a creator opportunities they will not win.** Showing a nano creator a campaign requiring 100k followers is the fastest way to churn them. Filter on eligibility *before* ranking.
2. **"Near you"** — geo-ranked visits and events. The highest-conversion surface in Kenya because travel cost is real and proximity is decisive.
3. **Browse all** — filters: campaign type, category, compensation band (Free product / KSh 1k+ / 5k+ / 10k+ / 25k+), platform, location, deadline, tier eligibility.
4. **Invitations** — direct brand invites. Highest conversion of all; make the notification unmissable (WhatsApp).
5. **Instant book** — orders arriving through the storefront with no application needed.

REC **The critical UX rule: show expected payout in the card title, in shillings, always.** `"KSh 7,500 · Restaurant visit · Westlands · 3 slots left"`. Not "Exciting collaboration opportunity." Creators optimise for money and time; respect that.

Brand-side discovery (Part 15)

REC **The default sort must never be follower count.** That single default determines whether you built an influencer platform or a creator platform.

```
DefaultRank = 0.30·CategoryMatch
            + 0.25·Reliability
            + 0.20·QualityScore
            + 0.15·PriceFit
            + 0.10·GeoProximity
```

Available filters: location (ward-level), niche, creator type, platform, follower range *(collapsed by default)*, avg views, engagement rate, audience geography/age/gender (where verified), price range, turnaround, availability, language, rating, on-time %, verification level, past brand categories, content boundaries.

REC **Three deliberate choices:** - **Follower range is collapsed under "Advanced".** Available, not default. - **Sort options offered:** Best match (default) · Most reliable · Highest rated · Lowest price · Fastest delivery · Most views. **Never a raw "most followers".** - **Never return zero results.** If filters are too narrow, widen automatically and say so: *"No exact matches in Kilimani — showing 12 creators in nearby Nairobi areas."* An empty result set is where marketplaces lose brands permanently.

Part 21 — Messaging

REC **Yes, allow direct messaging. Restricting it drives users to WhatsApp faster than any circumvention risk you are avoiding.**

Design: campaign-scoped threads (never a general inbox), file and voice-note support (REC voice notes are essential — they are how Kenyan business communication actually works), brief pinned to the thread top, templated quick replies, automated milestone and deadline reminders, and full message retention as dispute evidence.

Anti-circumvention — calibrated, not aggressive:

Control	Recommendation
Contact detail masking	REC **Only before a contract is funded.** After funding, they need to coordinate — a creator must be able to phone a venue.
Phone/email detection	Detect and log pre-funding; soft warning, not a block
Hard blocking of contact info	REC **No.** It infuriates legitimate users and is trivially bypassed ("zero seven two zero…")
Pattern detection	Yes — flag repeated exchanges that die immediately after first contact
Terms enforcement	Yes, in terms; enforce only on egregious, repeated, evidenced cases

REC **Say this plainly to the team: the answer to circumvention is the Deal Desk and descending repeat fees, not message policing.** Every hour spent building surveillance is an hour not spent making the platform worth staying on. See `06-trust-reputation-fraud.md`.

Part 25 — Creator levels: useful or gimmicky?

REC **Both. It is gimmicky if the rewards are cosmetic; genuinely useful if the rewards are economic.**

Badges alone are gimmicky — Kenyan creators are not motivated by a bronze icon. But **tiers that gate real economic benefits are a legitimate quality-control and retention mechanism**, because they align creator incentives with marketplace health.

Tier	Requirements	Economic benefits
New	Verified	Standard visibility
Bronze	3 jobs, 4.0+, 80% on-time	Apply to 10 concurrent campaigns
Silver	10 jobs, 4.3+, 90% on-time	20 applications · 24h early access · same-day payout

Tier	Requirements	Economic benefits
Gold	25 jobs, 4.5+, 95% on-time, 2+ repeat brands	Unlimited applications · 48h early access · **instant payout** · priority in matching
Elite	50 jobs, 4.7+, 97% on-time, 5+ repeat brands, 0 disputes	All the above · **access to premium/enterprise campaigns** · profile featuring · **earnings advances**

REC **Design rules:** - **Tiers must be losable.** A rolling 180-day window, not lifetime accumulation. Otherwise the tier stops predicting current behaviour. - **The most valuable rewards are payout speed and campaign access**, not badges. Both are cheap for you and highly valued. - **Never discount your take rate by tier at launch.** You need the revenue, and fee discounting is hard to reverse. Revisit at scale. - **Elite unlocks earnings advances** — this is the hook into the underwriting thesis in `00-executive-summary.md`. Tier progression becomes a credit-scoring proxy built on settled transaction history.

Part 32 — Agencies: help or hurt?

REC **They help, substantially, and you should court them — with structural guardrails.**

Why they help: agencies bring existing brand relationships and budgets (solving demand cold-start), high AOV (a single agency may spend more than 50 SMEs), professional briefs and fast approvals, low CAC, and repeat volume. ASSUMPTION Agencies are likely to be your largest GMV source in year one, well ahead of direct SME demand.

Why they can hurt: they insert themselves between you and the brand relationship; they may pressure creator rates downward; they can become a concentration risk; and if they mark up opaquely they reproduce the exact problem creators resent.

REC **The guardrails, all of which are non-negotiable:** 1. **The creator's rate is the creator's rate.** Agency markup sits on top, visible to the brand's own client if the brand wishes. Agencies never take from the creator's side of the ledger. 2. **Creators always see the end brand.** No blind campaigns — a creator must know whose product they are endorsing, both for reputational and for disclosure-compliance reasons. 3. **Reviews attach to the agency and the end brand separately.** 4. **Concentration cap as a management metric:** if any single agency exceeds ~20% of GMV, treat it as a risk to be actively diversified.

Agency account features (V2): multi-brand workspaces, team seats with roles, consolidated invoicing, saved creator pools, campaign templates, white-labelled client reporting, bulk hiring, approval workflows.

Part 39 — Navigation

Creator (mobile-first, five tabs): `Home (opportunities) · Explore · Orders · Messages · Earnings` Onboarding: phone OTP → name + photo + location → **pick your creator types** → connect socials (skippable, with a visible ranking incentive) → upload 3 portfolio items → set 1 service and price → done. REC **Target under 6 minutes to a complete profile, and let them browse before completing it.**

Brand (responsive web + mobile): `Home (campaigns) · Discover · Orders · Messages · Wallet · Insights` Onboarding: business email/phone → brand name + industry + location → objective → budget → **see recommended campaigns immediately**. REC **Show real creators before asking for payment details, always.** Value before commitment is the rule in a low-trust market.

Part 40 — Positioning: 20 concepts

Grouped by the strategic claim each makes.

Hiring / labour framing 1. *Hire creators. Not influencers.* 2. *Kenya's marketplace for creative work.* 3. *The creator workforce, on demand.* 4. *Book a creator like you book a ride.* 5. *Where brands and creators do business.*

Trust / payment framing 6. *Paid on delivery. Every time.* 7. *Escrow for the creator economy.* 8. *The only place creators always get paid.* 9. *Money in escrow. Content in hand. M-Pesa in minutes.* 10. *Trust, built into every collaboration.*

Speed / simplicity framing 11. *From brief to content in 72 hours.* 12. *Your marketing team is 5,000 creators.* 13. *Describe what you need. We'll bring the creators.* 14. *Marketing content without a marketing team.*

Breadth framing 15. *Any brand. Any creator. Any collaboration.* 16. *From product seeding to paid UGC to influencer campaigns.* 17. *Every way a brand can work with a creator.* 18. *The operating system for creator-brand partnerships.*

Africa framing 19. *The commercial marketplace for African creators.* 20. *Africa's creators, open for business.*

Evaluation of the ones you proposed

Concept	Verdict
"Hire creators, not influencers"	**Strong.** Sharp, contrarian, encodes the strategy. Weakness: negative framing, and "influencer" still carries aspirational value for creators. **Better as an internal north star than a homepage headline.**
"Any brand. Any creator. Any collaboration."	Elegant but says nothing concrete. Vagueness is the enemy in a low-trust market.
"The commercial marketplace for African creators."	Accurate; investor-legible; emotionally flat; premature (you are Kenyan, not African, for two years).
"From product seeding to paid UGC to influencer campaigns."	Good **subhead**, poor headline — a list is not a promise.
"Upwork for creators."	Useful shorthand for investors, meaningless to a Nairobi restaurant owner.
"The operating system for creator-brand partnerships."	Investor-speak. Avoid.

The recommendation

REC **Primary:**

> # Marketing content without a marketing team.
>
> **Hire Kenya's creators for UGC, TikToks, store visits and campaigns. Money held safely. Creators paid by M-Pesa within the hour.**

Why this one: it names the **customer's actual problem** rather than your category (an SME owner does not wake up wanting "creator collaborations" — they wake up needing content and customers); the subhead carries breadth, trust and payment speed in one line; it is untethered to the influencer frame without arguing against it; and it works in translation.

REC **Per-audience variants** (same product, different door): - **Creators:** *"Get hired. Get paid. Same day."* - **Agencies:** *"Source, brief, pay and report on 50 creators from one dashboard."* - **Investors:** *"The commercial infrastructure for Africa's creator economy."*

08

AI Matching and Campaign Builder

The honest framing first

REC **AI matching is not a moat, and you should stop thinking of it as your biggest differentiator.**

Three reasons: 1. With 500 creators, a good filter beats a mediocre model. Matching only becomes hard above ~5,000 creators, which is 12+ months away. 2. FACT AIfluence has been marketing AI-driven matching in this exact market since 2020. The claim is not novel here. 3. LLM capability is a commodity every competitor can buy. What is *not* commoditised is **your proprietary outcome data** — which creator actually delivered on time, whose video actually converted, which pairings produced repeat bookings.

REC **The defensible asset is the feedback loop, not the algorithm.** Ship deterministic matching first, instrument outcomes obsessively, and let the model become good because your data is good. Say this out loud to investors: *"Our matching gets better because we settle the payments and therefore see the outcomes. A discovery tool never learns whether its recommendation worked."*

Part 10 — The matching algorithm

Three-stage architecture

```
Stage 1  ELIGIBILITY (hard filters — SQL, milliseconds)
         Reduce 10,000 → ~300
Stage 2  SCORING (weighted feature model — deterministic, explainable)
         Rank 300 → top 50
Stage 3  PORTFOLIO OPTIMISATION (constrained selection)
         Select the best SET of N, not the best N individuals
```

REC **Stage 3 is the part everyone skips and it is where the real value is.** A brand asking for 20 creators does not want the 20 highest-scoring individuals — they want a *portfolio*: geographic spread, tier mix, audience diversity, no overlapping followings, within budget. Optimising the set rather than the members is a genuinely differentiated capability and it is classical optimisation, not machine learning.

Stage 1 — Eligibility (non-negotiable filters)

```
active_within_days <= 14
AND accepting_work = true
AND capacity_remaining > 0
AND creator_type IN (:required_types)
AND rate_for_service <= :max_per_creator
AND NOT category_excluded(:brand_category)     -- creator's own boundaries
AND (NOT requires_location OR ward IN :target_wards)
AND (NOT requires_min_followers OR followers >= :min)
AND account_standing = 'good'
AND NOT worked_with_competitor_within(:exclusivity_days)
```

REC `active_within_days <= 14` **is the most important line here.** The classic marketplace failure is recommending inactive supply. A perfect match who never opens the app is worse than a mediocre match who replies in an hour — it burns the brand's first impression, which you only get once.

Stage 2 — Scoring

```
MatchScore = 0.25 · ContentFit
           + 0.20 · AudienceFit
           + 0.15 · Reliability
           + 0.15 · QualityScore
           + 0.10 · PriceFit
           + 0.08 · GeoFit
           + 0.07 · PerformanceHistory
```

Feature	Computation	Notes
ContentFit	Cosine similarity between campaign brief embedding and creator's portfolio + past-brief embeddings	The one place an LLM genuinely earns its place
AudienceFit	Overlap of creator audience demographics with target; **falls back to a category prior when API data is unavailable — and is labelled as an estimate**	FACT TikTok returns no audience demographic breakdown via API; Instagram returns it only for the authenticated owner — so this feature is often unavailable and must degrade honestly
Reliability	From the CRS reliability component	
QualityScore	From the CRS quality component	
PriceFit	Gaussian around budget-per-creator; penalise both far-over and suspiciously-under	Suspiciously cheap correlates with poor delivery
GeoFit	Distance decay from target ward; step penalty across Nairobi's traffic corridors	REC Model travel *time*, not straight-line distance — Nairobi traffic makes 8km unbookable
PerformanceHistory	Actual/predicted views on past campaigns; conversion rate where tracked	Requires ≥3 completed campaigns; else neutral prior

REC **Two non-obvious weighting decisions: - ContentFit outweighs AudienceFit (0.25 vs 0.20).** This encodes "creators, not influencers" in the ranking layer, where it actually takes effect. Marketing copy does not change behaviour; weights do. - **Add an explicit exploration term.** Reserve ~15% of recommendation slots for high-uncertainty creators (few completed jobs, high early signal). Without it, the top 200 creators get all the work, the long tail churns, and supply collapses into an oligopoly. This is a **marketplace-health decision that costs short-term match quality and must be defended against the instinct to maximise it away.**

Stage 3 — Portfolio optimisation

```
maximise   Σ MatchScore(c) + λ · Diversity(S)
subject to Σ rate(c) ≤ budget
           |S| = N
           geographic_spread(S) ≥ min_wards
           tier_mix(S) ≈ target_mix
           audience_overlap(S) ≤ max_overlap
```

Greedy with diversity penalty is entirely sufficient — do not over-engineer this. REC **`audience_overlap` matters more than it seems**: 15 creators with the same 40,000 followers is one campaign reaching 40,000 people, not 600,000, and a brand that discovers this after the fact does not come back.

Explainability is a feature, not a nicety

REC **Every recommendation ships with its reason.** Not because it is nice, but because a Kenyan SME will not spend KSh 50,000 on a black box, and because it teaches the brand what to ask for next time.

> **Amina W. — 94% match** ✅ 12 food campaigns completed · ✅ 78% audience in Nairobi ✅ Based in Westlands (venue: 2km) · ✅ 96% on-time across 34 jobs ⚠️ Rate KSh 7,500 is 15% above your per-creator budget

---

Part 11 — The AI campaign builder

What it actually is

REC **Be precise internally: this is a *structured-extraction and estimation* system, not a creative AI.** The LLM's job is to turn messy natural language into a valid `CollaborationSpec`. Every number it produces must come from **your database**, never from the model. An LLM that hallucinates a KSh 8,000 rate for a category where the real median is KSh 3,500 destroys trust on first use and is worse than no feature at all.

```
Natural language
    ↓ LLM: structured extraction (typed JSON, schema-validated)
CampaignIntent { objective, category, location, count, timing, budget, deliverables }
    ↓ Deterministic: query real marketplace data
Pricing (from actual completed collaborations) + Supply check (real availability)
    ↓ LLM: brief generation from a template + retrieved similar briefs
Editable draft campaign
```

Worked example — your restaurant case

Input: *"I own a new restaurant in Westlands and want 15 creators to visit next weekend."*

Extraction:

```
{
  "objective": "foot_traffic",
  "campaign_type": "location_visit",
  "venue": {"area": "Westlands", "county": "Nairobi"},
  "creator_count": 15,
  "timing": {"window": "next_weekend", "resolved": "2026-09-12..2026-09-14"},
  "category_inferred": "food_beverage",
  "budget": null,
  "confidence": {"count": 0.95, "timing": 0.80, "budget": 0.0}
}
```

Deterministic enrichment — every number sourced: - Pricing: median completed `location_visit` rate, `food_beverage`, Nairobi, last 90 days, by tier - Supply: count of eligible creators actually available in that window within reach of Westlands - Reach: median actual views for those creators on comparable past campaigns

Generated draft:

```
📍 Westlands Restaurant Visit Campaign
Objective        Foot traffic + local awareness
Creators         15 (5 nano · 7 micro · 3 mid-tier)
Geography        Westlands, Parklands, Kilimani, Lavington
Deliverables     1 TikTok + 3 Instagram Stories per creator
Window           Fri 12 – Sun 14 Sep · 5 slots per evening
Per creator      KSh 4,000 (nano) / 6,500 (micro) / 12,000 (mid)
Consumption      KSh 2,500 allowance each (+1 guest)
─────────────────────────────────────────────────────────
Creator fees                   KSh 108,500
Consumption (15 × 2,500)       KSh  37,500   ← your cost, not ours
Platform fee (15%)             KSh  16,275
TOTAL PLATFORM SPEND           KSh 124,775

Estimated reach       380,000–520,000    ⓘ from these creators' actual results
Estimated content     15 TikToks + 45 Stories
Supply check          ✅ 34 eligible creators available that weekend

[Edit] [Generate brief] [Publish campaign]
```

REC **Six design rules for this feature:**

1. **Never invent a price.** Every figure traces to completed transactions. If you lack data for a segment, say *"we don't have enough data on this yet — here's a range from adjacent categories"* and let the brand set it.
2. **Always run the supply check before showing a plan.** Promising 15 creators when 6 are available is the fastest way to lose a brand permanently. If supply is short, say so and offer alternatives (widen geography, extend the window, adjust the mix).
3. **Show confidence honestly.** Low-confidence extractions become questions, not assumptions. *"You said 'next weekend' — do you mean 12–14 September?"*
4. **Always editable.** The AI produces a draft, never a commitment. Every field is a form input.
5. **Separate platform spend from brand-borne cost.** The KSh 37,500 consumption allowance is the restaurant's own cost, not GMV, and conflating them misleads the brand and inflates your metrics.
6. **Reach estimates come from these creators' actual past results**, not from follower-count formulas. Label the source in the UI.

Auto-generated briefs

REC **Template-driven with LLM infill, never free generation.** The template guarantees the legally and operationally required fields are present:

```
CAMPAIGN: [name]
BRAND: [brand] — [one-line description]
OBJECTIVE: [objective]

WHAT WE NEED
[deliverables, explicit counts and formats]

MUST INCLUDE
- Tag @[handle]
- [required disclosure — SYSTEM-INSERTED, NOT EDITABLE]
- [hashtags]

MUST AVOID
[brand-safety exclusions]

CREATIVE DIRECTION
[LLM-generated from brand inputs + high-performing similar briefs]

LOGISTICS
[address / delivery / booking / contact]

DEADLINE / RIGHTS / PAYMENT
[dates] / [rights summary in plain language] / [amount, escrow status, release terms]
```

REC **The disclosure line must be system-inserted and non-editable.** FACT Kenya's advertising framework — the Advertising Standards Board of Kenya under the Marketing Society of Kenya, alongside the Communications Authority and Competition Authority — expects promotional content to be identifiable as advertising, and undisclosed advertising risks breaching consumer-protection provisions. Making disclosure a system-controlled field (with Swahili options such as *"Imefadhiliwa na [Brand]"*) removes it from negotiation, protects the creator, protects the brand, and is a genuine compliance selling point. See `13-legal-compliance.md`.

What the model must never decide

REC Hard boundary — put it in the engineering guidelines:

LLM decides	Deterministic code decides
Parsing intent from text	**Prices**
Drafting creative direction	**Match scores and rankings**
Summarising and rephrasing	**Supply availability**
Suggesting content ideas	**Payment amounts and splits**
Categorising and tagging	**Reputation scores**
	Dispute outcomes
	Disclosure requirements

Anything touching money, ranking, or reputation is deterministic, auditable, and testable. This is not a stylistic preference — it is what makes the system defensible when a creator asks why they were not selected, or a regulator asks how a payment was calculated.

Build sequence

Version	Capability
V1	No AI. Filters + rules + a hand-tuned scoring function. Instrument everything.

Version	Capability
V2	LLM brief parsing → structured campaign; deterministic pricing from real data; explainable ranking
V3	Learned ranking trained on completed-collaboration outcomes; portfolio optimisation; predicted-performance model
V4	Full conversational builder; automated campaign optimisation mid-flight; budget reallocation

REC **The V1 line is a discipline, not a limitation.** The hand-tuned function generates the labelled data the learned model needs. Skipping to V3 without outcome data produces a model trained on nothing, which is how "AI matching" becomes a marketing claim rather than a capability.

09

The Campaign Workflow

Two state machines, not one

REC The most common modelling error here is a single status field on a campaign. It cannot represent a campaign where 8 of 15 creators have delivered. Separate them:

```
CAMPAIGN  — the brand's demand object (1 brand : N collaborations)
COLLABORATION — one brand-creator contract (its own money, its own state)
```

A campaign is `ACTIVE` while its collaborations independently move through their lifecycles. All money, all reputation, all disputes attach to the **collaboration**.

Campaign states

```
DRAFT ──► PENDING_REVIEW ──► OPEN ──► FILLING ──► FULL ──► IN_PROGRESS ──► COMPLETED
  │             │              │                                               │
  │             ▼              ▼                                               ▼
  └─────────► REJECTED      CANCELLED                                      ARCHIVED
                               ▲
                            EXPIRED (deadline passed, unfilled)
```

State	Meaning	Key transitions
`DRAFT`	Being composed	→ PENDING_REVIEW on submit
`PENDING_REVIEW`	Moderation queue	**REC** Manual for first 90 days, then risk-scored. Auto-approve trusted brands.
`OPEN`	Live, accepting applications	→ FILLING on first acceptance
`FILLING`	Some slots filled	→ FULL when all filled
`FULL`	All slots filled	→ IN_PROGRESS when all funded
`IN_PROGRESS`	Work underway	→ COMPLETED when all collaborations terminal
`EXPIRED`	Deadline passed, unfilled	**REC** Auto-refund unallocated escrow immediately
`CANCELLED`	Brand cancelled	Per-collaboration cancellation rules apply

REC **Moderation is not optional at launch.** The first fraudulent or abusive campaign to reach creators does disproportionate reputational damage in a market where WhatsApp groups spread news in minutes. Review every campaign manually until you have enough volume to risk-score, and treat it as a cost of trust, not overhead.

Collaboration states — the core state machine

```
                    ┌───────────────────────────────────────────┐
                    │            APPLICATION PHASE              │
                    └───────────────────────────────────────────┘
INVITED ─────┐
             ├──► APPLIED ──► SHORTLISTED ──► ACCEPTED ──► AWAITING_FUNDING
DISCOVERED ──┘       │             │                              │
                     ▼             ▼                              ▼
                  DECLINED      NOT_SELECTED                    FUNDED
                                                                  │
                    ┌───────────────────────────────────────────┐ │
                    │            FULFILMENT PHASE               │ │
                    └───────────────────────────────────────────┘ │
                                                                  ▼
 BRIEFED ──► [PRODUCT_DISPATCHED ──► PRODUCT_DELIVERED]  (seeding)
    │        [VISIT_BOOKED ──► CHECKED_IN ──► VISIT_COMPLETE] (visits)
    ▼
 IN_PRODUCTION ──► DRAFT_SUBMITTED ──► IN_REVIEW
                        ▲                 │
                        │                 ├──► REVISION_REQUESTED ──┐
                        └─────────────────┘                         │
                                          │                         │
                                          ▼                         │
                                       APPROVED ◄─────────────────-─┘
                                          │
                    ┌───────────────────────────────────────────┐
                    │            PUBLICATION PHASE              │
                    └───────────────────────────────────────────┘
                                          │
                      ┌───────────────────┴──────────────┐
                      ▼                                  ▼
                  PENDING_PUBLICATION           (no publishing required)
                      │                                  │
                      ▼                                  │
                   PUBLISHED                             │
                      │                                  │
                      ▼                                  │
                  PROOF_SUBMITTED                        │
                      │                                  │
                      ▼                                  │
                  PROOF_VERIFIED ───────────────────────►│
                                                         ▼
                                                  PAYMENT_RELEASED
                                                         │
                                                         ▼
                                                      SETTLED
                                                         │
                                                         ▼
                                                  REVIEW_PENDING
                                                         │
                                                         ▼
                                                     COMPLETED

Terminal exceptions from any state:
  CANCELLED_BY_BRAND · CANCELLED_BY_CREATOR · EXPIRED · DISPUTED · REFUNDED
```

Every state, defined

Application phase

State	Entry	Exit	Timer	Money
`INVITED`	Brand invites directly	Creator accepts/declines	**72h** → auto-decline	None
`APPLIED`	Creator applies with pitch	Brand shortlists/rejects	**7d** → auto-expire	None
`SHORTLISTED`	Brand shortlists	Brand accepts/rejects	5d	None
`ACCEPTED`	Brand accepts creator	Funding	**48h** → auto-cancel	None
`AWAITING_FUNDING`	Contract formed	Escrow funded	**48h** → cancel + brand penalty	Pending
`FUNDED`	Escrow confirmed	Brief released	Immediate	**Held**

REC **`AWAITING_FUNDING` is where marketplaces quietly bleed creators.** A brand that accepts and does not fund has wasted a creator's time and hope. Enforce the 48-hour timer strictly and count non-funding against the brand's trust score. Two failures should suspend campaign posting.

Fulfilment phase

State	Notes
`BRIEFED`	Full brief + logistics released. **The delivery clock starts here.**
`PRODUCT_DISPATCHED`	Seeding only. Tracking attached.
`PRODUCT_DELIVERED`	**Content deadline starts HERE, not at BRIEFED.** Non-delivery within SLA → auto-cancel, no creator fault.
`VISIT_BOOKED`	Visits only. Slot reserved, capacity decremented.
`CHECKED_IN`	QR scan at venue. **Travel stipend releases here** if applicable.
`VISIT_COMPLETE`	Content deadline starts.
`IN_PRODUCTION`	Creator working. Reminders at 50% and 80% of the window.
`DRAFT_SUBMITTED`	Files uploaded. **Brand review clock starts (5 days to auto-approve).** Brand sees a **watermarked streaming preview only — no download** (see `10-technical-architecture.md`).
`IN_REVIEW`	Brand reviewing.
`REVISION_REQUESTED`	Must cite a specific brief requirement. Counts against the limit. Deadline extends by the agreed revision window.
`APPROVED`	Brand approves, **or** 5-day silence triggers auto-approval.

Publication phase

State	Notes
`PENDING_PUBLICATION`	Creator must post. Publication window begins.
`PUBLISHED`	Creator posts.
`PROOF_SUBMITTED`	URL and/or API verification.

State	Notes
`PROOF_VERIFIED`	Automated where API allows; manual fallback. REC Also schedules the **live-duration monitor** — re-check at day 7 and day 30 to catch early deletion.
`PAYMENT_RELEASED`	B2C instruction issued. **Clean master unlocked** via signed, expiring URL.
`SETTLED`	M-Pesa confirmed. REC **Target median under 60 minutes from APPROVED.**
`REVIEW_PENDING`	Both parties prompted. **Double-blind:** reviews reveal on mutual submission or at 14 days.
`COMPLETED`	Terminal. Reputation events written to the ledger.

The timers, in one table

REC **These are the most important product decisions in the entire workflow.** Each one converts a human failure into a deterministic, fair outcome — and every one of them prevents a dispute rather than resolving it.

Timer	Duration	On expiry	Protects
Invitation response	72h	Auto-decline	Brand
Application review	7d	Auto-expire	Creator
Acceptance → funding	48h	Cancel + brand penalty	**Creator**
Brief → draft	Per campaign	Late flag, then default	Brand
Draft → brand decision	**5d**	**AUTO-APPROVE + RELEASE**	**Creator**
Revision turnaround	48h default	Late flag	Brand
Approval → publication	72h default	Breach process	Brand
Publication → proof	24h	Reminder, then flag	Brand
Approval → payout	**<60 min target**	Escalation alert	**Creator**
Review window	14d	Reviews reveal	Both
Escrow maximum life	**60d**	**Force-resolve**	**Compliance**
Minimum live duration	30d default	Breach + clawback	Brand

REC **If you implement only one thing from this document, implement the 5-day auto-approve.** It is the structural counterweight to escrow. Escrow protects the brand from a creator who vanishes; auto-approve protects the creator from a brand that goes quiet. A marketplace with only the first is trusted by only one side — and the side it fails is the side you cannot buy.

Every state emits an event

REC Append-only event log from commit one. This is not infrastructure indulgence — it is what makes disputes adjudicable, reputation auditable, analytics possible, and the AI training set real.

```
{
  "event_id": "uuid",
  "collaboration_id": "uuid",
  "type": "DRAFT_SUBMITTED",
  "actor": {"type": "creator", "id": "uuid"},
  "at": "2026-09-12T14:32:11Z",
  "from_state": "IN_PRODUCTION",
  "to_state": "DRAFT_SUBMITTED",
  "payload": {"asset_ids": ["..."], "hours_before_deadline": 6.2},
  "idempotency_key": "..."
}
```

Every reputation metric, every dispute determination, and every analytics number is **derived from this log**, never stored as a mutable field. When a creator disputes their on-time rate, you can reconstruct it exactly. When you change the reputation formula, you can recompute history. When you train a ranking model, the labels already exist.

REC **This is the single highest-leverage architectural decision in the codebase, and it is nearly free if made on day one and extremely expensive if made in month eighteen.**

10

Technical Architecture

Part 37 — The stack

The database decision — answered directly

You asked: *"Firebase/Firestore or recommend an alternative if better."*

REC **Use PostgreSQL. Do not use Firestore. This is the most consequential technical decision in the project and it is not close.**

Requirement	Postgres	Firestore
Multi-row ACID transactions for escrow/ledger	✅ Native	⚠️ Limited, awkward
Foreign keys and integrity constraints	✅	❌ None
Joins across creators × socials × services × availability	✅	❌ **No joins at all**
Compound filters (12+ discovery dimensions)	✅	❌ Composite index per query shape
Geospatial (ward proximity, travel time)	✅ PostGIS	❌ Bolt-on only
Full-text + vector search for matching	✅ `pg_trgm` + `pgvector`	❌ External service
Aggregate analytics	✅	❌ Must denormalise everything
Double-entry ledger with invariants	✅ Constraints + transactions	❌ Application-enforced only

The decisive argument: your discovery and matching queries filter on **location + niche + type + price + availability + rating + reliability + audience simultaneously**. This is the defining query of the product. Firestore fundamentally cannot express it — every filter combination needs a pre-built composite index, and the combinatorics explode. You would end up shipping a search service alongside Firestore and syncing between them, which is strictly worse than starting with Postgres.

The second argument: **you are moving other people's money.** A financial ledger without foreign keys and multi-row transactions is a source of quiet, compounding corruption that surfaces as unreconciled balances six months in.

REC **Supabase** (managed Postgres + auth + storage + realtime + row-level security) for V1 — it gives you Firebase's developer velocity on a real relational database. **Neon** if you prefer to assemble the pieces yourself.

Recommended stack

Layer	V1 (MVP)	Why
Frontend	Next.js 15 (App Router), TypeScript, Tailwind	Your stated preference; SSR matters for creator-storefront SEO
Hosting	Vercel	Stated preference; fine at this scale
Database	**Postgres (Supabase)**	See above

Layer	V1 (MVP)	Why
Auth	Supabase Auth — **phone OTP primary**, email secondary, Google optional	REC **Phone-first. Kenyan creators may not have an email they check; everyone has a phone.**
Storage	**Cloudflare R2** for deliverable masters; Supabase Storage for avatars, ID docs, PDFs	Split by workload — see *Video and storage* below
Video	**Cloudflare Stream**	Portfolio clips and watermarked review previews. See *Video and storage* below.
Payments	Licensed aggregator (IntaSend / Paystack / Pesapal) behind your own `PaymentProvider` interface	See `05-payments-mpesa.md` **and the static-IP constraint below**
Background jobs	Inngest / Trigger.dev	Timers, reconciliation, proof re-checks, payout retries
Notifications	WhatsApp Business API (primary), Africa's Talking (SMS), Resend (email), FCM (push)	See Part 22
Search	Postgres `pg_trgm` + `pgvector`	Do not add Elasticsearch until Postgres actually fails you
Analytics	PostHog	Product analytics + feature flags + session replay in one
Errors/APM	Sentry	
AI	Claude API for brief parsing and generation	Structured extraction with schema validation
Admin	Retool or a bespoke Next.js admin	REC **Build the ops console in week one — see below**

REC **The ops console is not a V2 item.** V0 and V1 are *manually operated marketplaces*. Your team needs to intervene in every collaboration: verify creators, moderate campaigns, resolve disputes, trigger payouts, fix stuck states. Founders who defer the admin tool end up running the marketplace from the database console, which does not scale past about fifty orders and produces errors that cost real money.

Video and storage — three workloads, not one

REC **Treating "video" as a single problem is what makes these bills explode.** Flerwa has three video workloads with opposite characteristics, and they belong in different places.

Workload	Size	Reads	Private?	Transcoding?	Goes to
A. Portfolio clips (profile, storefront)	Small (~40s)	**Very high**	Public	Yes — adaptive bitrate	**Cloudflare Stream**
B. Deliverable masters (what the brand buys)	**Large** (100MB–2GB)	Very low (~3)	Private	No	**Cloudflare R2**
C. Review previews (draft under review)	Small	Low	Private	Yes — low-res	**Cloudflare Stream**

FACT **Pricing that drives the split (verified September 2026 — re-verify before committing):** - **Cloudflare Stream:** $5 per 1,000 minutes stored, $1 per 1,000 minutes delivered, **transcoding included with no encoding fees**. - **Mux:** priced separately for encoding (~$0.0075/min), storage (~$0.003/min) and delivery (~$0.0008–0.0048/min by resolution and tier). On a normalised workload Stream came out ~$150 vs Mux ~$170. - **Cloudflare R2:** ~$0.015/GB stored, **zero egress**, with a permanent free allowance (10GB stored, 1M Class A / 10M Class B ops). - **Supabase Storage (Pro):** $25/mo including 100GB storage and 250GB egress; overages ~$0.021/GB storage and **~$0.09/GB egress**. (BuildMVPFast — video, BuildMVPFast — storage, PkgPulse, Adam Arant)

REC **Stream over Mux:** cheaper, simpler, transcoding included. Mux wins on DRM and per-view analytics — you need neither, because creator performance data lives on TikTok and Instagram, not on your player.

REC **R2 over Supabase Storage for masters:** brands downloading deliverables is a pure egress workload, which is precisely what R2's zero-egress model exists for. Keep Supabase Storage for avatars, KYC documents and contract PDFs, where RLS-governed access is worth more than egress pricing.

ASSUMPTION **Rough cost at V2 scale** (5,000 creators, 1,500 collaborations/month): ~$300/mo portfolio + ~$150/mo masters (~10TB accumulated) + ~$50/mo previews ≈ **$500/month against KSh 27M GMV — immaterial.** The architecture matters not because it is cheap now, but because it prevents this becoming $5,000/month at V3.

The watermark gate — this closes a fraud hole, not just a cost problem

REC **This is a correction to the dispute design in `06-trust-reputation-fraud.md`.** As originally specified, a brand could receive a draft, **download the file**, refuse to approve, open a dispute, obtain a refund, and still hold the asset. That is free content.

The storage split fixes it, using infrastructure you are building anyway:

```
DRAFT_SUBMITTED  → brand sees a WATERMARKED, low-res STREAMING preview only
                   No download. Visible watermark. Stream-delivered, never a file.
PAYMENT_RELEASED → clean master unlocked from R2 via a signed, expiring URL
```

Standard practice in stock-media and design marketplaces, and it makes download-then-dispute pointless. It also gives the rights system real teeth: **the master is gated on settlement, not on approval.**

Upload is the hard problem in Kenya, not playback

REC **Most designs optimise playback and ignore upload. Here it is the reverse.** A creator on Nairobi mobile data uploading a 200MB video *will* fail partway, and a failed upload after a completed shoot is a churn event — the creator did the work and cannot deliver it.

Four requirements: 1. **Resumable uploads (tus protocol)** — supported by both Cloudflare Stream and Supabase Storage. Non-negotiable on mobile. 2. **Direct-to-storage via signed URL.** Never proxy video through Next.js API routes — Vercel serverless functions cap request bodies at roughly 4.5MB, and proxying is slow and expensive regardless. 3. **Client-side compression before upload**, with a visible size and time estimate so the creator knows what they are committing to. 4. **Cap required resolution at 1080p** unless the rights grant genuinely needs more. Demand a large master only when the brand purchased OOH or print rights — this ties file size to what was actually paid for.

REC **On playback, adaptive bitrate matters more here than in a Western market.** Shipping a 1080p rendition to a phone on a variable network both fails to play and burns the viewer's data bundle. That is a cost borne by your users, not your invoice — and in a market where mobile data is expensive, it is a retention issue.

The M-Pesa static-IP constraint (serverless gotcha)

FACT Vercel deployments use **dynamic outbound IPs**, and any destination that allowlists by IP will reject that traffic (Vercel — Static IPs, QuotaGuard, Fixie).

FACT — sources conflict Some Daraja documentation states the API works over the public internet with no VPN or IP whitelisting required (unlike the legacy SOAP API), while multiple go-live guides state that **Safaricom whitelists your production server IPs before enabling live endpoints**. REC **Assume whitelisting is required and design defensively** — discovering otherwise costs nothing; discovering it late blocks go-live.

Note the asymmetry: **inbound callbacks are fine on serverless** (any public HTTPS endpoint works). It is the **outbound** calls to Daraja that need a fixed source address.

REC **Three ways out, in order of preference:**

Option	Trade-off
1. Use the licensed aggregator (IntaSend / Paystack / Pesapal)	**Preferred.** They hold the Daraja relationship and the static IPs. This is already the recommendation for regulatory reasons in `13-legal-compliance.md` — that two independent constraints point to the same answer is a good sign.
2. Static-IP egress proxy (QuotaGuard, Fixie)	Route only outbound Daraja calls through it. Cheap, adds a dependency and a latency hop.
3. Small always-on VM as a payments service	Fixed IP, full control, direct Daraja relationship at scale. Vercel handles everything else. Most operational overhead.

REC **Whichever you choose, keep it behind the `PaymentProvider` interface.** Moving from aggregator (V1) to direct Daraja (at scale) should be a provider swap, not a refactor.

Connection pooling (the other serverless gotcha)

FACT Next.js on Vercel plus Postgres will exhaust connections unless you use **Supavisor's transaction-mode pooler on port 6543**, and reduce or disable your application-side pool. Transaction mode is optimised for short-lived, stateless serverless functions. Prepared-statement support in transaction mode has improved — Supavisor now parses and broadcasts named prepared statements across connections — but it historically caused problems with Prisma. (Supabase — connecting to Postgres, Supavisor 1.0, Supavisor FAQ)

REC **Spike this before committing to an ORM.** It is a one-day test that prevents a painful migration later.

REC **Two more Supabase-specific decisions:** - **Do not let the client write money.** RLS is defence-in-depth, not your authorisation model for financial logic. All escrow transitions, ledger writes, payout instructions and state-machine changes go through server-side routes using the service role. An RLS bug in a marketplace is a security incident; an RLS bug on the ledger is unrecoverable. - **Benchmark region latency from Nairobi before provisioning.** East African traffic routes both north to Europe and east via Indian Ocean cables, so do not assume Frankfurt beats Mumbai. This also interacts with the cross-border transfer question in `13-legal-compliance.md`, and a project's region cannot be changed later without a migration.

Social platform APIs — what is realistically integrable

FACT **Verified constraints as of 2026:** - **Instagram's Basic Display API was deprecated in December 2024.** All access is now via the Graph API, requires app review, and works **only for Business and Creator accounts**. The `instagram_manage_insights` scope returns audience demographics **only for the authenticated account owner** — you cannot query a creator's audience on their behalf without their explicit app authorisation. - **TikTok does not expose audience age, gender or geographic breakdown through direct API calls.** This is described as one of the most significant gaps for influencer marketing platforms. - TikTok's API surface expanded through 2025–26, notably with TikTok Shop APIs. TikTok app review is reported at 5–10 days; Instagram's is slower and stricter. Full integration is typically 4–6 weeks including review. (Phyllo social media API guide, Instagram Graph API guide)

REC **Plan honestly around these limits:**

Platform	V1	V2	V3
TikTok	OAuth login, profile, video list, **own-account metrics**	Video-level performance on submitted content	TikTok Shop affiliate attribution; Spark Ads codes
Instagram	OAuth (Business/Creator only), profile, media	Insights for authorised accounts	Meta Partnership Ads access requests
YouTube	Data API: channel stats, video stats	Analytics API for authorised channels	
Facebook	Page insights for authorised pages		
X	❌ REC **Skip.** API pricing is not justifiable for Kenyan reach		

REC **Three consequences to design around now:** 1. **Never promise brands audience demographics you cannot source.** Where API data is unavailable, show an estimate, label it an estimate, and say where it came from. 2. **Creator OAuth is the only path to verified data**, so make connecting accounts visibly rewarding: a "Verified Audience" badge plus a real ranking uplift. Track connection rate as a core funnel metric. 3. **Manual verification is a legitimate V1 fallback.** A screen-recorded walkthrough of the creator's own analytics, reviewed by ops, is slow but honest. FACT Every incumbent has some version of this. Do not block launch on API approvals.

Part 22 — WhatsApp architecture

FACT WhatsApp and TikTok were the most frequently used social platforms in Kenya in a Q2 2025 survey. REC **Treat WhatsApp as the primary notification and engagement channel, and — critically — as a *read* interface, never a *write* one.**

The architectural principle

```
      WhatsApp = NOTIFICATION + LIGHT INTERACTION
      Platform = SYSTEM OF RECORD (always)

 Platform event ──► Notification Service ──► channel router
                                              ├─ WhatsApp (primary)
                                              ├─ Push (if app installed)
                                              ├─ SMS (fallback, urgent only)
                                              └─ Email (records, receipts)

 WhatsApp reply ──► Webhook ──► Intent parser ──► Deep link into platform
                                                   (state changes happen THERE)
```

REC **The hard rule: no state-changing action completes over WhatsApp.**

A creator can tap "View campaign" in WhatsApp and land in the app. They cannot *accept a contract* over WhatsApp. The reason is not squeamishness — it is that acceptance, approval, and payment authorisation must be attributable, auditable, and consented-to against terms you can produce in a dispute. A WhatsApp message is not that record.

The one justified exception: REC **simple confirmations with an audit trail** — "Reply 1 to confirm you'll attend Friday 7pm" — where the reply is logged as an event with message ID and timestamp, and the platform holds the authoritative state. That is a confirmation, not a contract.

What goes over WhatsApp

Event	Channel	Template
New matching campaign	WhatsApp	*"KSh 7,500 · Restaurant visit in Westlands · 3 slots left. Apply → [link]"*
Application accepted	WhatsApp + push	
Payment released	**WhatsApp + SMS**	*"KSh 7,500 sent to 0712* — M-Pesa ref QK12ABC3"*
Deadline in 24h	WhatsApp	
Revision requested	WhatsApp + push	
Brand: new applications	WhatsApp + email	
Brand: content ready for review	WhatsApp + email	
Dispute update	WhatsApp + email	

REC **The payment notification is the most valuable message you will ever send.** It is the proof that the platform works, it arrives at the moment of maximum goodwill, and it is the thing creators screenshot and share in WhatsApp groups. Make it clear, include the M-Pesa reference, and never let it be late.

Constraints and cautions

ASSUMPTION — verify current WhatsApp Business Platform policy and pricing before committing Business-initiated messages generally require pre-approved templates and are charged per conversation; free-form replies are typically permitted only inside a customer-initiated service window. Template approval takes time and template rejection is common. REC Budget for per-conversation costs in your unit economics (they are real at 50,000 collaborations/month), get templates approved early, and always maintain SMS as a fallback for payment-critical messages.

REC **Also run community WhatsApp groups — but manually and deliberately.** A curated group of active creators is the highest-signal feedback channel you will have in year one, and it is where your first hundred creators will actually live. Do not automate it. Have a human in it every day.

Part 38 — Database design

Core entities and relationships

```
                              ┌──────────┐
                              │   User   │  (phone, email, auth, kyc_tier)
                              └────┬─────┘
                ┌──────────────────┼──────────────────┐
                ▼                  ▼                  ▼
          ┌──────────┐       ┌──────────┐       ┌──────────┐
          │ Creator  │       │  Brand   │       │  Agency  │
          └────┬─────┘       └────┬─────┘       └────┬─────┘
               │                  │  ▲               │
               │                  └──┴───────────────┘  (agency manages N brands)
               │
     ┌─────────┼──────────┬─────────────┬──────────────┐
     ▼         ▼          ▼             ▼              ▼
 SocialAcct Portfolio  Service    Availability   ReputationSnapshot
                          │
                          ▼
                       Package

          ┌──────────┐          ┌──────────────┐
          │ Campaign │────1:N───│Collaboration │◄──── the central entity
          └──────────┘          └──────┬───────┘
     ┌────────────┬──────────┬─────────┼─────────┬────────────┬──────────┐
     ▼            ▼          ▼         ▼         ▼            ▼          ▼
 Application Deliverable Milestone Escrow  Message   RightsGrant  Review
                  │                     │
                  ▼                     ▼
            Asset / Proof         LedgerEntry ──► Payout
                                        │
                                        ▼
                                     Dispute
```

Table sketch (the ones with non-obvious design)

```
-- One row per brand↔creator contract. All money and reputation attach here.
collaboration (
  id, campaign_id NULL,          -- NULL = direct storefront booking
  creator_id, brand_id,
  type,                          -- seeding|ugc|influencer|visit|event|affiliate|hybrid|licensing|package|custom
  state,                         -- see 09-workflow-states.md
  origin,                        -- campaign_application | brand_invite | storefront | deal_desk
  currency, creator_amount_minor, platform_fee_minor, total_amount_minor,
  rights_grant_id, brief_id,
  accepted_at, funded_at, due_at, delivered_at, approved_at, settled_at,
  auto_approve_at,               -- computed: delivered_at + 5 days
  escrow_expires_at              -- computed: funded_at + 60 days
)

-- Append-only. Every state change. The source of truth for reputation & analytics.
collaboration_event (
  id, collaboration_id, type, actor_type, actor_id,
  from_state, to_state, payload jsonb, created_at, idempotency_key UNIQUE
)

-- Double-entry. Never mutate; only append.
ledger_entry (
  id, transaction_id,            -- groups the balanced set
  account_type,                  -- escrow_held|creator_payable|platform_revenue|payment_costs|tax_withheld|brand_re
  account_ref,                   -- creator_id | brand_id | collaboration_id
  direction,                     -- debit | credit
  amount_minor, currency,
  collaboration_id, external_ref, created_at
  -- INVARIANT: SUM(debits) = SUM(credits) per transaction_id
)

-- Rights are structured data, not prose. Enables the pricing slider and machine-checkable terms.
rights_grant (
  id, base_scope,
  paid_ads_channels text[], paid_ads_until date,
  brand_organic_until date, website_until date, ooh_until date,
  whitelisting boolean, whitelisting_until date,
  exclusivity_category text, exclusivity_until date,
  territory text[], edit_rights jsonb, perpetual boolean,
  price_multiplier numeric, contract_pdf_url
)

-- Ward-level geography. PostGIS point + hierarchy.
location (id, country, county, town, ward, geo geography(Point), parent_id)

-- Per-type, time-decayed reputation. Recomputed from events, never hand-edited.
reputation_snapshot (
  creator_id, collaboration_type, computed_at,
  reliability, quality, brand_satisfaction, authenticity, performance,
  crs numeric, confidence_lower numeric, sample_size int
)
```

Design rules

REC Seven, each of which is expensive to retrofit:

1. **Money is `amount_minor bigint` + `currency`, never a float, never a bare number.** Cents/shillings as integers. Currency present from day one even while KES-only.
2. **The ledger is append-only.** Corrections are reversing entries, not updates. No `UPDATE` on `ledger_entry`, enforced by permissions.
3. **Reputation is derived, never stored as truth.** `reputation_snapshot` is a materialised cache recomputed from `collaboration_event`. This lets you change the formula and recompute history — which you will do, at least twice.
4. **Location is a hierarchy with geography, not a string.** "Westlands" as free text makes proximity matching impossible.

5. **Soft-delete everything financial or reputational.** Records referenced by disputes must survive account deletion — and note this sits in tension with Data Protection Act erasure rights, so define a retention policy with counsel (see `13-legal-compliance.md`).
6. **Idempotency keys on every payment and state transition.** M-Pesa callbacks duplicate as a matter of routine.
7. **Row-level security from the start** if using Supabase. Retrofitting authorisation is how marketplaces leak one user's data to another.

Version roadmap (technical)

	MVP (V1)	V2	V3
Auth	Phone OTP	+ Google, team seats, roles	SSO
Payments	Aggregator STK + B2C, escrow, single release	Milestones, split payments, refund automation	Trust account, multi-currency, cards, FX
Social	Manual verification + TikTok OAuth	IG/YouTube OAuth, automated proof	Spark Ads, Meta Partnership Ads, Shop attribution
Matching	SQL filters + hand-tuned score	LLM brief parsing, explainable ranking	Learned ranking, portfolio optimisation
Messaging	In-app threads	Voice notes, files, templates	—
Notifications	WhatsApp templates + SMS	Push, preference centre	Intelligent batching
Analytics	Basic dashboards	Attribution, promo codes	Full ROAS, cohorts, forecasting
Ops	**Admin console (week one)**	Automated moderation, risk scoring	ML fraud detection
Rights	Structured grant + PDF contract	Rights library, renewals	Automated enforcement monitoring
Logistics	State tracking only	Courier API integration	Consolidated dispatch

REC **Two critical-path notes.** First, resolve the **static-IP question with your aggregator in week one** alongside the Daraja paperwork — it determines whether payments can live on Vercel at all.

REC **One team-shaping note.** The MVP column is roughly **3–4 engineers for 10–14 weeks**, and the largest single risk in it is not code — it is FACT the 6–8 weeks typically required to go from Daraja sandbox to production, which includes shortcode registration, a signed go-live letter, and IP whitelisting. **Start the M-Pesa go-live paperwork in week one, before you write the first line of payment code.** It is the critical path, and it is the one part of the build that no amount of engineering effort can accelerate.

11

Analytics and Metrics

Part 23 — Brand analytics

REC **The design constraint that matters: your buyer is a restaurant owner, not a media planner.** A dashboard with CPM, CPE and ROAS above the fold will be ignored. Structure it in three layers and default to the first.

Layer 1 — "Did it work?" (default view)

```
Westlands Launch Campaign · Completed
─────────────────────────────────────────
KSh 124,775 spent      15 creators hired
60 pieces of content   487,000 views
─────────────────────────────────────────
KSh 2.08 per person reached
62 people used your code WEST20
KSh 43,400 in tracked sales      3.5x return
─────────────────────────────────────────
Best performer: Amina W. — 89,000 views, 21 code uses
[Rebook top 5 creators]   [Download all content]
```

REC **Three deliberate choices:** money-first metrics, plain language ("people reached", not "impressions"), and **the rebook button in the primary view** — repeat purchase is your most important business outcome, so put the action where the satisfaction is.

Layer 2 — Performance detail

Spend and budget remaining · creators hired/delivered/pending · content delivered by format · views, reach, engagement, ER% · **CPM, CPV, CPE** · clicks, code redemptions, leads, conversions, revenue, **ROAS, CPA** · content approval rate · average revisions · on-time delivery rate.

Layer 3 — Diagnostics

Per-creator performance table (sortable by views, engagement, conversions, cost-efficiency) · best/worst content with thumbnails · campaign-over-campaign comparison · creator-cohort performance (nano vs micro vs mid — REC **this is the analysis that will repeatedly show nano outperforming on cost-efficiency, and it is how you sell the "creators not influencers" thesis with evidence rather than assertion**) · content-type performance · time-of-post analysis · geographic breakdown.

Formulas

```
CPM   = spend / (impressions/1000)
CPV   = spend / views
CPE   = spend / (likes + comments + shares + saves)
CPA   = spend / conversions
ROAS  = tracked_revenue / spend
ER    = engagements / reach          (prefer reach; fall back to followers, label it)
Cost-efficiency index = creator_CPV / campaign_median_CPV
```

REC **Be explicit about attribution limits in the UI.** Where a promo code is the only signal, say *"62 tracked redemptions — offline sales not included."* Overstating attribution is the fastest way to lose a sophisticated buyer, and the fastest way to look dishonest to an unsophisticated one when the numbers do not match their till.

Part 24 — Creator analytics

REC **Creators are motivated by money and by getting more work.** Lead with earnings; make everything else an instrument for winning the next job.

```
YOUR EARNINGS
This month  KSh 34,500      ↑ 22% vs last month
Pending     KSh 12,000      (2 jobs awaiting approval)
Lifetime    KSh 287,000     across 41 jobs
Next payout KSh 7,500 → 0712*** on approval

YOUR PERFORMANCE
⭐ 4.8 (34 reviews)   96% on-time   88% first-pass approval
11 repeat brands      Avg project KSh 8,400

WINNING WORK
Profile views     412 this month
Applications      23 sent · 9 hired · 39% success rate
                  ⓘ Platform average is 24% — you're doing well
Response time     2.1h  ⓘ Creators who reply in <1h get 2x more hires

YOUR CONTENT
Avg views per post  41,200      Best: 187,000 (Nairobi Grill)
Views delivered to brands: 1.4M lifetime
```

REC **Four design decisions:** 1. **Benchmark against the platform, not in isolation.** "39% vs a 24% average" is actionable; "39%" alone is not. 2. **Surface the causal levers.** "Creators who reply in under an hour get 2x more hires" changes behaviour in a way that a raw response-time number does not. 3. **"Views delivered to brands" is a portfolio asset.** It is the number a creator quotes when negotiating, and giving it to them makes your profile their CV. 4. **Never show a creator their internal reputation score.** Show the components. A composite invites gaming and demoralises without informing.

Part 44 — Marketplace metrics and formulas

Core

Metric	Formula	Notes
GMV	Σ creator_amount of collaborations reaching `SETTLED`	REC **Recognise at settlement, not at funding.** Funded-but-unsettled is not GMV.
Take rate	platform_revenue / GMV	Blended across fee types
Revenue	Σ platform fees + subscriptions + services	
Net revenue	Revenue − payment costs − refunds	The number that matters
AOV	GMV / completed collaborations	**The company's primary commercial metric**

Supply and demand health

Metric	Formula
Active creators	Distinct creators with ≥1 application or delivery in 30d
Earning creators	Distinct creators with ≥1 settled collaboration in 30d
Creator activation	Creators with ≥1 settled collab / creators registered
Time to first earning	Median days, registration → first settlement
Active brands	Distinct brands with ≥1 campaign or order in 30d
Paying brands	Distinct brands with ≥1 funded collaboration in 30d
Brand activation	Brands with ≥1 funded collab / brands registered
Time to first hire	Median days, registration → first funded collaboration

REC **Track *earning* creators, not registered creators.** Registered creators is a vanity number that will be 10–20x the real one and will mislead you and your investors about supply health.

Funnel conversion

```
Campaign fill rate     = slots filled / slots posted
Applications/campaign  = applications / campaigns posted     (target 8–25)
Application→hire       = accepted / applications             (target 15–30%)
Hire→completion        = settled / accepted                  (target >85%)
Completion→repeat      = brands rebooking in 60d / brands completing
```

REC **Applications per campaign is your liquidity thermometer.** Below 5, brands see thin choice and leave. Above 40, creators waste effort and churn. Both extremes are failures; monitor the distribution, not the average, because one viral campaign with 300 applications hides fifty campaigns with two.

Retention

```
Creator retention (M3) = creators earning in M0 AND M3 / creators earning in M0
Brand retention (M3)   = brands purchasing in M0 AND M3 / brands purchasing in M0
Repeat rate            = brands with ≥2 collaborations / brands with ≥1
Repeat GMV %           = GMV from repeat brands / total GMV
NRR                    = (GMV from M0 cohort in M12) / (their M0 GMV)
```

REC **Repeat GMV % is the single best predictor of whether this company works.** Below 40% by month 12 means you are running an acquisition treadmill, and acquisition treadmills in a market this size do not reach scale.

Health, risk and efficiency

```
Marketplace liquidity  = collaborations settled / (campaigns posted + storefronts active)
Supply utilisation     = earning creators / active creators
Dispute rate           = disputes opened / collaborations funded        (target <3%)
Refund rate            = KSh refunded / KSh funded                      (target <5%)
Auto-approve rate      = collabs approved by timeout / approved         (watch: brand disengagement)
Median time to payout  = median(settled_at − approved_at)               (target <60 min)
Cost to serve          = (ops + support + payment costs) / completed collaborations
CAC (per side)         = S&M spend attributable / new activated users
LTV (brand)            = AOV × collabs/year × years × contribution margin
LTV:CAC                = target >3.0 by month 18
```

REC **"Cost to serve per completed collaboration" is the metric most founders omit and most investors ask about.** It must fall every quarter. If it does not, the Scenario 3 economics in `04-economics-and-pricing.md` never arrive.

Part 45 — The North Star Metric

The candidates, honestly assessed

Candidate	Case for	Fatal flaw
GMV	Investor-legible; direct revenue link	**Gameable by chasing a few large deals; says nothing about health.** A single KSh 2M enterprise campaign can hide a dead marketplace.
Creator earnings	Mission-aligned; drives supply	Identical to GMV; adds nothing
Successful matches	Measures the core function	An accepted match that fails is not value
Repeat collaborations	The truest quality signal	Lags too far; unusable as a weekly operating metric
Completed collaborations/month	Counts the actual unit of value; requires both sides to succeed	Ignores value — 1,000 × KSh 500 ≠ 1,000 × KSh 20,000

The recommendation

> ## North Star: Completed Collaborations per Month
>
> ***— governed by two guardrails: Average Order Value and Repeat Rate.***

Definition: collaborations reaching `SETTLED` — deliverable approved, creator paid — in a calendar month.

Why this one:

1. **It cannot be reached without both sides succeeding.** A brand had a need, a creator delivered, the brand approved, money moved. Every failure mode in the business reduces this number. That is exactly what a North Star should do.
2. **It is a count, so it resists distortion by outliers** in a way GMV cannot. Ten thousand small successful collaborations is a healthier marketplace than five large ones, and this metric says so.

3. **It is legible to everyone.** An engineer, an ops associate, and a creator all understand "collaborations completed." GMV means nothing to the person answering support tickets.
4. **It composes cleanly:** `Completed Collaborations = Active Brands × Collaborations per Brand × Completion Rate` — and every team owns one of those terms.

Why the guardrails are mandatory: optimising the count alone drives you toward high-volume, low-value work, which per `04-economics-and-pricing.md` is precisely the shape that cannot pay for itself. So:

- **Guardrail 1 — AOV must not fall.** Report it beside the North Star, always, on the same line.
- **Guardrail 2 — Repeat rate must rise.** Growth from new brands only is a treadmill.

REC **The one-line board metric:**

> **"N collaborations completed this month, at KSh X average, Y% from repeat brands."**

Any one of those numbers moving in isolation is a warning. All three moving together is the company working.

Stage-appropriate targets

ASSUMPTION These are my recommended targets, not forecasts.

Stage	Completed collabs/mo	AOV	Repeat %	Implied GMV
V0 (manual, mo 1–3)	50	KSh 8,000	20%	KSh 400k
V1 (mo 4–9)	300	KSh 12,000	35%	KSh 3.6M
V2 (mo 10–18)	1,500	KSh 18,000	45%	KSh 27M
V3 (mo 19–30)	5,000	KSh 25,000	55%	KSh 125M

Note the AOV column doing the heavy lifting: collaborations grow 100x from V0 to V3, GMV grows 312x. **That gap is where the business becomes viable**, and it is a product and commercial choice, not an emergent property.

12

Liquidity, Launch and Growth

Part 27 — Marketplace liquidity

Which side first? — the counter-intuitive answer

REC **Neither. Acquire *transactions* first.**

The conventional answer is "supply first, because supply is cheaper." In this market that is a trap. Creators are indeed cheap to acquire — you could sign 2,000 in a month with TikTok posts. **And they would all churn, because there would be nothing for them to do.** A creator who joins, applies to three campaigns, hears nothing, and leaves is not neutral: they tell forty people in a WhatsApp group that the platform is dead. In Kenya, where creator communities are dense and vocal, **a failed supply acquisition is actively negative**, not merely wasted.

REC **The correct sequence is: demand → matched supply → transaction, repeated manually, one deal at a time.**

```
Weeks 1–4   Sell 20 campaigns by hand. No product. WhatsApp + spreadsheet.
Weeks 5–8   Recruit ONLY the creators those campaigns need. ~50 people.
Weeks 9–12  Deliver every one flawlessly. Collect testimonials and proof.
Month 4+    Now open the doors. You have proof, pricing data, and a track record.
```

This is deliberately unglamorous and it is the only reliable way through the cold start.

The Deal Desk — the strongest liquidity mechanism available to you

REC **This is the most important go-to-market idea in this pack, and I would build it before the campaign marketplace.**

The insight: **you do not need to create demand that does not exist. You need to capture demand that already exists but transacts invisibly.**

Kenyan creators already have brand relationships — negotiated in DMs, agreed on WhatsApp, paid (eventually, sometimes) by M-Pesa. The pain is not finding the deal. The pain is **getting paid, on time, with a contract**.

```
Creator has an existing deal with a brand
        ↓
Creator: "Let's run this through Flerwa so we both have protection"
        ↓
Platform: contract + escrow + guaranteed payout + rights terms
        ↓
Creator pays 5%.  Brand pays 0%.  Brand is now onboarded, free.
```

What this produces, immediately:

Benefit	Why it matters
GMV from day one	Without solving two-sided cold start
Free brand acquisition	The creator does your sales. CAC ≈ 0.

Benefit	Why it matters
Real pricing data	You learn actual Kenyan rates from actual deals — the input your AI pricing needs
Real reputation seed	Genuine reviews and settled history from transaction one
Measures the informal market	Directly resolves the central uncertainty in `02-africa-kenya-landscape.md`
Converts your biggest threat into revenue	Off-platform transacting becomes 5% revenue instead of a leak

REC **The pitch to creators is one sentence:** *"Never chase a payment again. 5%."*

REC **The pitch to brands is also one sentence:** *"It costs you nothing, and you only pay when you're happy with the work."*

ASSUMPTION I believe this is the fastest path to KSh 5M monthly GMV in Kenya, and it is materially faster than building demand from scratch. It is also nearly unique — no competitor I found is doing it, because it requires giving up the fiction that the platform originates all value.

Seeding supply — the first 100, 500, 1,000, 5,000, 10,000

Stage	Method	Cost	Time	The bar
First 100	**Hand-recruited by founders.** Coffee, WhatsApp, in person. Personally onboard each one, build their storefront with them, get their first job within 14 days.	Time only	6 weeks	**Every single one must earn money.** No exceptions.
First 500	Referrals from the 100 (they know everyone) + 3 targeted WhatsApp/TikTok creator communities + 2 university campus drives (USIU, Strathmore, Daystar, Kenyatta, Multimedia)	KSh 300k	3 months	60% earn within 30 days
First 1,000	Creator ambassadors (20 paid organisers, KSh 15k/mo + per-creator bonus) + creator challenge campaign + earnings-proof content	KSh 800k	5 months	50% earn within 30 days
First 5,000	Organic storefront SEO + creator-generated content loop + regional cities (Mombasa, Kisumu, Nakuru, Eldoret) + agency creator rosters onboarded in bulk	KSh 2M	12 months	35% earn within 60 days
First 10,000	Self-sustaining loops + Uganda/Tanzania entry + partnership with a telco or a bank's youth programme	KSh 4M	20 months	30% earn within 60 days

REC **Guard the ratio, not the count.** The binding constraint is **campaigns per active creator**. Target ≥0.5 available opportunities per active creator at all times. **If that ratio falls below 0.3, stop all creator acquisition immediately and sell.** This should be a hard operational rule with a named owner, because the temptation to keep growing the supply number is enormous and it is how marketplaces die.

REC **The waitlist is a feature, not a compromise.** If demand is thin, put new creators in a queue with an honest message: *"We're onboarding creators as campaigns come in — you're #340, and we'll message you the moment there's work in your category."* Honesty preserves the relationship. A silent empty dashboard destroys it.

Getting the first 100 brands

REC **Founder-led, in person, in Nairobi. There is no scalable channel at this stage and pretending otherwise wastes the first six months.**

Source	Target	Approach
Deal Desk (creator-introduced)	40	Free, warm, pre-qualified — **your best channel**
Founder outbound to Westlands/Kilimani SMEs	25	Walk in. Restaurants, salons, gyms, clinics. Offer the first campaign at cost.
Agencies	10	Each brings multiple brands and high AOV
Startup/tech network	15	Nairobi's startup community buys quickly and refers
Inbound from creator content	10	Creators posting about earnings

REC **The opening offer: "We'll run your first campaign for free. You pay only the creators."** You forgo ~KSh 5,000 of fee and buy a case study, a testimonial, real pricing data, and a brand relationship. At 100 brands that is KSh 500,000 — cheaper and better than any advertising you could buy.

Preventing the two death spirals

Creators join and find nothing: - Waitlist by category when demand is thin - **Guarantee first work within 30 days** for hand-recruited creators, and honour it by manufacturing demand if necessary - Notify by category — never blast every campaign to everyone - Show honest supply/demand context in the app - REC Onboard by campaign, not by ambition: recruit for a specific brief that exists

Brands join and find low quality: - **Manual vetting of the first 500 creators.** Watch their content. Reject freely. - Curated shortlists at launch — do not expose raw search - **Replacement guarantee:** creator underdelivers, you replace them free - **Managed service default at launch.** For the first 90 days, a human runs every campaign. It is expensive, unscalable, and correct.

Solving liquidity manually before automating

REC **For the first 90 days, the "algorithm" is a person.** Concretely: a founder reads each brief and picks 10 creators by hand; a WhatsApp group per campaign; a spreadsheet as the source of truth; manual M-Pesa payouts with screenshots; a phone call to every creator before every deadline.

Every one of those manual steps is a specification. You are running the algorithm in your head; write down what you do and that becomes the ranking function. Teams that automate before doing this build matching logic based on assumptions and then spend a year unwinding it.

Part 28 — Kenya launch geography

REC **Launch in Nairobi only. Specifically: Westlands, Kilimani, Lavington, Karen, Parklands, Kileleshwa. Do not expand until you have 500 completed collaborations.**

City	ASSUMPTION Creator density	Brand density	Priority
Nairobi	Very high	Very high	**Launch — months 1–9**
Mombasa	Medium-high (tourism, hospitality)	Medium-high	Second — month 10
Kisumu	Medium	Medium	Third — month 14
Nakuru	Medium	Medium-low	Fourth
Eldoret	Low-medium	Low-medium	Fifth

City	ASSUMPTION Creator density	Brand density	Priority
Thika, Naivasha, Nanyuki, Diani	Low	Niche (hospitality/tourism)	Opportunistic

Why Nairobi-only, aggressively: location visits — your wedge — require **geographic density on both sides simultaneously**. A creator in Kisumu and a restaurant in Nairobi is not a marketplace, it is a rounding error. Density beats coverage at this stage, and a thin national footprint reads as an empty product everywhere.

REC **Mombasa is the strongest second city**, not because of population but because hotels, resorts and restaurants are *natural buyers of location-visit campaigns* and have real marketing budgets. It suits your wedge better than Nakuru or Kisumu do.

Launch verticals — in order, with reasons

#	Vertical	Why first
1	**Restaurants, cafés, bars**	Dense in Westlands/Kilimani; visible ROI (people walk in); low decision-making friction; owner decides on the spot; **perfect fit for location visits**; they talk to each other
2	**Beauty, salons, skincare**	Highest creator affinity; content-native; recurring need; strong seeding fit
3	**Fashion & retail**	Constant content need; product seeding natural; e-commerce attach
4	**Hotels & experiences**	High AOV; visit-native; Mombasa/Nanyuki expansion path
5	**Startups & apps**	Fast decisions; understand UGC and performance marketing; pay reliably; refer well
6	**Gyms, wellness, clinics**	Local, visit-native, recurring
7	**E-commerce & FMCG**	Highest AOV and volume, but slow procurement — REC **attack in V2, not at launch**
8	**Agencies**	High AOV, low CAC — REC **court from month 3**

REC **Deliberately avoid at launch:** banks and telcos (procurement cycles of 3–9 months), betting companies (REC **consider excluding permanently — regulatory risk, creator-welfare harm, and reputational contamination of your supply base**), politics (existential risk in an election cycle), and alcohol (restricted advertising rules; needs counsel first).

ASSUMPTION **Indicative launch pricing** — validate in week one, do not treat as fact:

Service	Nano	Micro	Mid
UGC video (no posting)	2,500–4,000	4,000–7,000	7,000–12,000
TikTok post	3,000–5,000	6,000–15,000	20,000–45,000
IG Reel	3,000–6,000	7,000–18,000	25,000–50,000
Restaurant visit + 1 post	4,000–6,000	6,500–12,000	15,000–30,000
Product photography (10)	4,000–8,000	8,000–15,000	—
Event coverage (day)	8,000–15,000	15,000–30,000	35,000–80,000

For calibration: FACT reported Kenyan micro-influencer rates run KSh 10,000–50,000 per post, and top-tier creators command KSh 100,000+ per video (The Standard, SmartBizSystems). REC **UGC-only rates should sit well below posting rates** — the creator is selling production, not audience — and establishing that norm early is one of the most valuable market-shaping things you can do.

Part 29 — Go-to-market

Creator acquisition, ranked by expected cost per *earning* creator

Channel	ASSUMPTION CPA	Quality	Notes
Founder hand-recruitment	Time	★★★★★	The only channel for the first 100
Creator referrals	KSh 500	★★★★★	Creators know creators; highest quality
Earnings-proof content	KSh 200	★★★★	*"KSh 34,500 this month on Flerwa"* — the single best-performing creative
Creator ambassadors	KSh 800	★★★★	20 organisers running local recruitment
WhatsApp creator communities	KSh 300	★★★	Needs a warm introduction; do not spam
University campus drives	KSh 600	★★★	Students are eager, skilled, cheap, reliable
TikTok/IG ads	KSh 1,500	★★	Volume, low intent
Creator academy / workshops	KSh 1,200	★★★★★	Slow, expensive, produces excellent creators and deep loyalty

REC **The highest-performing creator marketing you will ever run is a real creator showing a real M-Pesa message.** It is credible in a way no advertising is, it is free, and it is exactly what circulates in Kenyan WhatsApp groups already. Build a one-tap "share my earnings" flow into the payout notification — **make the receipt shareable by design.**

Brand acquisition

Channel	When	Notes
Founder outbound	Month 1+	Walk into Westlands. Nothing outperforms this early.
Deal Desk	Month 1+	Creators bring their own brands, free
Case-study content	Month 3+	*"How Nairobi Grill filled its restaurant with 15 creators"*
Agency partnerships	Month 3+	High AOV, low CAC
Referrals	Month 4+	SME owners talk to SME owners
SEO (storefronts + guides)	Month 6+	Compounding; FACT how Collabstr built liquidity
Paid search/social	Month 9+	Only once conversion is proven
Events, demo days	Month 6+	Nairobi's startup scene converts well

REC **Do not hire a sales team before month 9.** Founders must sell the first 100 brands personally, because the objections you hear in those conversations are the product roadmap. Delegating that away is how you build the wrong thing efficiently.

Part 30 — Growth loops

REC Ten loops, ranked by how much I would actually invest in each.

1. Creator earnings-proof loop ★★★★★ `Creator earns → shares M-Pesa proof → other creators join → more supply → better brand experience → more campaigns → more earnings` *Build:* one-tap shareable payout receipt with branded template. **The cheapest, strongest loop available to you.**

2. Storefront distribution loop ★★★★★ `Creator gets storefront → shares link in bio/status → brands discover → brands book → creator earns → shares more` *Build:* beautiful, fast, SEO-indexed public storefronts. **Supply becomes your demand channel** — this is the structural genius of the Collabstr model.

3. Deal Desk conversion loop ★★★★★ `Creator brings existing client → brand experiences escrow → brand posts an open campaign → other creators earn → they bring their clients` **Converts the informal economy into the platform, one relationship at a time.**

4. Content-in-the-wild loop ★★★★ `Campaign content published → tagged/watermarked → viewers see it → creators and brands discover the platform` *Build:* optional subtle attribution; a public gallery of campaign work.

5. Brand case-study loop ★★★★ `Brand succeeds → case study → similar SMEs see it → they join → more campaigns → more creator earnings` *Build:* systematic result capture at campaign close, while satisfaction is highest.

6. Referral loop ★★★★ — see Part 31.

7. Reputation lock-in loop ★★★★ `Creator builds verified track record → track record only exists here → creator promotes the platform to protect its value → more transactions → stronger record` **This is the moat forming.** It compounds silently and is why the ledger matters.

8. Data-quality loop ★★★ `More completed collaborations → better pricing and matching data → better recommendations → higher satisfaction → more collaborations` *Slow to start; the strongest long-term defence.*

9. Agency multiplier loop ★★★ `Agency joins → brings 8 brands → high campaign volume → creators earn well → creators recommend the platform to other agencies`

10. Geographic density loop ★★★ `Enough creators in Westlands → visit campaigns become viable → venues in Westlands join → nearby creators join → density deepens` *Build:* explicitly manage density by neighbourhood, not by city. This is why Nairobi-only matters.

REC **Loops 1, 2 and 3 are the ones to build deliberately in the first six months.** The rest emerge if those three work.

Part 31 — Referrals

Programme	Reward	Trigger	Guard
Creator → creator	KSh 500 each	Referee completes **first paid collaboration**	Max 20/month; both must be verified

Programme	Reward	Trigger	Guard
Creator → brand	**3% of that brand's GMV for 6 months**	Brand's first funded campaign	Capped at KSh 25,000/brand
Brand → brand	KSh 5,000 credit each	Referee's first funded campaign	Max 10
Agency	5% of referred GMV, 12 months	Ongoing	Contractual
Ambassador	KSh 15,000/mo + KSh 300/activated creator	Monthly	Performance-reviewed

REC **Three rules that determine whether this works:**

1. **Never pay on signup. Pay on completed, settled collaboration.** Signup bounties in Kenya reliably attract organised fraud rings; earning-gated rewards do not, because gaming them requires moving real money through a rail with real KYC.
2. **The creator→brand referral is deliberately the most generous.** 3% of GMV for six months is a lot — and it should be, because it directly buys the thing you are shortest of. A creator who brings a spending brand is worth more to you than one who brings ten creators.
3. **Prefer cash to credits for creators, credits for brands.** Creators need money; that is the entire proposition and substituting credits contradicts it. Brands are happy with credits and it improves your cash conversion.

13

Legal and Regulatory Surface

> **This is not legal advice.** I am identifying the areas that require professional Kenyan counsel and summarising publicly available information. Several items below are genuinely unsettled or fact-specific, and getting them wrong is expensive. **Engage a Kenyan advocate with fintech/payments experience and a Kenyan tax advisor before launch, not after.**

The five items that must be resolved before you take money

#	Issue	Why it blocks launch	Who resolves it
1	**Do you need a CBK PSP licence?**	Determines your entire payment architecture	Payments advocate
2	**Must you withhold 5% tax on creator payouts?**	Either underpays creators or accrues a tax liability	Tax advisor
3	**ODPC registration**	Mandatory; penalties are material	Data protection counsel
4	**Contract structure** — are you principal or agent?	Determines liability, VAT treatment, revenue recognition	Commercial counsel
5	**Are creators contractors or something else?**	Misclassification risk	Employment counsel

---

1. Payments and escrow

FACT Under the **National Payment System Act 2011** and **NPS Regulations 2014**, entities processing retail payments, facilitating e-commerce collections, operating digital wallets, or acting as aggregators require **CBK authorisation as a Payment Service Provider**. CBK requires protection of consumer funds through **segregated client accounts or escrow mechanisms**, an investment strategy for trust funds, and certified documentation of any custodial trust relationship. (CBK checklist, CBK guidelines)

REC **The mitigation is architectural, and it is in `05-payments-mpesa.md`:** operate on a licensed aggregator so the regulated float never sits in your name; bind every escrow to one identified collaboration; cap escrow life at 60 days; auto-sweep creator earnings to M-Pesa; never pay interest on or invest held funds.

The specific question for counsel: *"Given this architecture, are we a PSP requiring authorisation, or a merchant instructing payments through a licensed aggregator?"* ASSUMPTION My reading is that the aggregator model materially reduces the risk, but **this is precisely the kind of question where an informed guess is worthless and a written opinion is cheap.**

---

2. Tax — the most urgent live issue

FACT Kenya imposes a **5% withholding tax on digital content monetisation** for residents (**20% non-residents**), in law via the Finance Act 2023 and effective 1 July 2023. KRA lists digital content monetisation among payments subject to withholding, and the scope is described as covering ads, subscriptions, **brand deals** and affiliate income. Enforcement moved to withholding-at-source in 2026: **Meta began withholding from Facebook and Instagram creator payouts in January 2026**; **Google began withholding from YouTube earnings from September 2026 (paid October 2026)**, requiring a verified KRA PIN in AdSense by 1 October 2026. The Digital Content Creators Association of Kenya has publicly urged Treasury and KRA to pause collection pending consultation. (Techweez, TechTrends KE, KICTANet, K24)

Questions for a tax advisor, in priority order: 1. As a platform paying creators for brand collaborations, do we carry a withholding obligation — and does it differ by collaboration type (a UGC video licence versus a sponsored post, for example)? 2. If the brand is the principal and we are an agent, does the obligation sit with the brand instead? Does that change if we hold the funds? 3. VAT treatment of our platform fee, and of the creator's service — and the VAT registration threshold and timing. 4. Digital Service Tax / Significant Economic Presence Tax exposure, particularly for non-resident brand customers. 5. Treatment of **product-only seeding** — is gifted product taxable income to the creator, and is there a valuation and reporting obligation? 6. Withholding on non-resident creators (20%) once regional expansion begins.

REC **Build the withholding capability now, switch it on when advised** (see `05-payments-mpesa.md`), and **turn it into a creator benefit**: automatic withholding certificates and annual earnings statements. REC Most Kenyan creators cannot produce their own tax records, withholding-at-source has just become visible and stressful to them, and a platform that handles the paperwork is offering something the informal WhatsApp economy structurally cannot. That is both genuinely useful and a defensible reason to transact on-platform.

---

3. Data protection

FACT The **Data Protection Act 2019**, enforced by the **Office of the Data Protection Commissioner (ODPC)**. Under Section 18, data controllers and processors must register before processing personal data. Registration thresholds include annual turnover above **KSh 5 million**, more than **10 employees**, or processing of **sensitive personal data**; entities outside Kenya processing Kenyan residents' data are also caught. ODPC reviews within **14 days** and issues a certificate valid **24 months**. Penalties reach **KSh 5 million or 1% of annual turnover** for controllers and **KSh 3 million or 0.5%** for processors. (ODPC, Securiti, Njaga Advocates)

REC **Register early — you will cross a threshold quickly**, and registration is cheap relative to the penalties.

Your specific data-protection exposures:

Data	Risk	Mitigation
National ID + selfie (KYC)	**Sensitive; high breach impact**	Encrypt at rest; strict access control; consider a specialist KYC vendor so you hold verification results rather than raw documents
Creator home addresses (seeding)	**Safety risk, especially for women**	**Never expose to brands.** Courier-only. This is a safety requirement first and a compliance requirement second.
Phone numbers	Fraud, harassment	Mask in UI; full value in ledger only
Audience demographics	Third-party data	Consent via OAuth; process only what you display
Message content	Retained as dispute evidence	Disclose retention in the privacy notice
Location data	Tracking risk	REC **Store the declared ward, not continuous location.** Geo check-in captures a point-in-time event, not a trail.

REC **Three obligations that need real design work, not a policy page:** a lawful basis for each processing purpose (consent for marketing, contract for transactions, legitimate interest for fraud — documented per purpose); **data subject rights** (access, correction, deletion) with a genuine workflow, noting the tension with financial-record retention — resolve this with counsel and document the reasoning; and **cross-border transfer** conditions, which matter because Vercel, Supabase and your AI provider will process data outside Kenya.

---

4. Advertising and disclosure

FACT Kenya's advertising framework involves the **Advertising Standards Board of Kenya (ASBK)** under the Marketing Society of Kenya, alongside the **Communications Authority of Kenya** and the **Competition Authority of Kenya**, with consumer-protection provisions underpinning it. The general principle across jurisdictions — including guidance cited for the Kenyan context — is that consumers must be able to recognise an advertisement as an advertisement, and that material connections (payment, free products, significant discounts, affiliate commissions, ownership) must be disclosed. (ASBK Code, Iris Group, Anga Creators)

REC **Make disclosure a platform-enforced system field, not a creator responsibility.**

- Every brief carries **system-inserted, non-editable** disclosure text
- English and Swahili options (*"Imefadhiliwa na [Brand]"* for paid, *"Nimepewa kama zawadi"* for gifted)
- Proof verification **checks for the disclosure**; missing disclosure blocks approval
- Gifted product triggers disclosure requirements just as cash does — REC this is the most commonly missed case and worth an explicit product rule

REC **This is a genuine competitive advantage, not just compliance.** Brands with real legal exposure — banks, insurers, listed companies, multinationals — cannot use informal channels precisely because disclosure is unmanaged. Being demonstrably compliant is how you win the highest-AOV customers.

ASSUMPTION Sector-specific advertising restrictions (alcohol, gambling, pharmaceuticals, financial products, and content directed at children) carry additional rules. REC Build a category-restriction system, get counsel on each restricted vertical before enabling it, and — as noted in `12-gtm-liquidity-growth.md` — seriously consider excluding betting permanently on creator-welfare grounds.

---

5. Contracts, IP and classification

Contract architecture — REC **:** - **Platform Terms of Service** (both sides), **Creator Agreement**, **Brand Agreement** - A **per-collaboration contract** generated from structured fields — deliverables, deadline, compensation, rights grant, revision limits, dispute process — and **stored as a PDF at acceptance**. It must reflect the exact terms at that moment, not a mutable database row. - REC **Be explicit and deliberate about principal vs agent.** If the platform is the *agent* (creator contracts with brand; you facilitate), your liability and VAT position are narrower. If you are the *principal* (you contract with the brand and subcontract the creator), you carry delivery liability and different tax treatment. **This choice cascades into liability, VAT, revenue recognition, and how you can describe guarantees.** Decide it with counsel first — it is very hard to change later.

Intellectual property — REC **:** - **Default: the creator owns the copyright** and grants a licence of the scope purchased. This is the creator-protective position and directly opposes the perpetual-rights abuse Zaumu markets against. - Rights grants are **structured data** (see `10-technical-architecture.md`), so the contract is generated from machine-readable terms and is unambiguous. - **Moral rights, likeness and**

personality rights need explicit treatment — particularly for whitelisting, where the brand runs ads under the creator's own identity. REC Require separate, explicit, time-bounded consent for whitelisting; it is materially different from a content licence. - **Music licensing is a real trap.** Creator content using platform-native audio libraries is generally licensed for organic use only; the same track in a paid advertisement is often not. REC Warn explicitly at the point of purchasing paid-ads rights, and require the creator to confirm the audio is original or cleared.

Worker classification — REC : creators are independent contractors, and the agreement should say so with substance behind it: no exclusivity, no control over how work is performed, no set hours, freedom to work elsewhere, own equipment. ASSUMPTION Kenyan classification risk is likely lower than in the EU or California, but gig-work classification is being litigated globally and REC you should get a view from Kenyan employment counsel rather than assume it away — especially before introducing anything resembling guaranteed minimum work or earnings advances, which are exactly the features that attract classification scrutiny.

Compliance checklist

Before first shilling: company incorporation and KRA PIN · tax advisor engaged on withholding · payments advocate opinion on PSP status · ODPC registration filed · Terms, Creator Agreement, Brand Agreement, Privacy Notice drafted by counsel · aggregator contract with clear liability allocation · principal-vs-agent decision made and documented · disclosure text approved.

Before scale (KSh 10M+ GMV/month): VAT registration assessment · trust account structure reviewed · professional indemnity and cyber insurance · formal data-retention policy · incident-response plan · restricted-category rules per vertical.

Before regional expansion: licensing analysis per country · cross-border data transfer mechanisms · non-resident withholding (20%) · FX and repatriation · local entity structuring.

REC **Budget KSh 800,000–1,500,000 for pre-launch legal, tax and compliance work.** ASSUMPTION This is my estimate for Nairobi in 2026 and should be quoted properly. It will feel expensive for a pre-revenue company. It is far cheaper than any one of these going wrong — and in a business whose entire proposition is *trust*, a compliance failure is not a legal problem, it is an extinction event.

14

MVP, Roadmap, Launch Campaigns

Part 42 — The MVP

The seven things it must prove

#	Hypothesis	Kill signal
1	Brands will hire creators through a platform	<30 funded campaigns in 90 days
2	Creators will find and complete paid work	<40% of onboarded creators earn in 60 days
3	Brands trust escrow enough to prepay	>50% of interested brands refuse to prefund
4	Creators trust the payout	Creators demand payment before delivery
5	Campaigns complete end-to-end	Completion rate <70%
6	We can generate GMV	<KSh 2M cumulative in 90 days
7	**Brands come back**	**<25% rebook within 60 days**

REC **Hypothesis 7 is the only one that decides whether this is a company.** The first six are table stakes; any competent team can produce them with enough hustle. Repeat purchase is the one that cannot be faked, and it should be the headline of every investor update.

MVP feature set — build exactly this

Creator (mobile web, ~6 min onboarding): Phone OTP · profile (name, photo, ward, creator types, niches, bio, languages) · **portfolio upload (3–20 assets)** · **services with prices** (the storefront) · availability toggle · browse and filter campaigns · apply with a pitch · in-app messaging · deliverable upload · proof-of-post submission · **earnings dashboard** · M-Pesa payout details.

Brand (responsive web): Signup with business verification · **campaign wizard for four types** (visit, UGC, seeding, influencer post) · browse and filter creators · **book directly from a storefront** · review applications with match ranking · accept and fund via STK Push · messaging · review deliverables, approve or request one revision · release payment · rate the creator · basic campaign summary.

Platform: Escrow (fund → hold → release) · M-Pesa STK collection and B2C payout · **all workflow timers, especially 5-day auto-approve** · two-sided reviews (double-blind) · reputation components · WhatsApp notification templates · **admin/ops console** · double-entry ledger · dispute intake (human-resolved).

Four campaign types only: Location Visit · Paid UGC · Product Seeding · Influencer Post.

What we deliberately do NOT build

Not building	Why
AI matching	With <1,000 creators, filters plus a hand-tuned score beat a model, and you have no outcome data to train on
AI campaign builder	Needs real pricing data. Build it in V2 on real transactions.
Affiliate / performance tracking	Requires attribution infrastructure; creators distrust unverifiable conversion counts

Not building	Why
Hybrid compensation	Depends on performance tracking
Standalone content licensing	Rights are bundled into UGC orders at V1; a rights marketplace comes later
Event coverage	Complex multi-deliverable; wait for operational maturity
Milestones / split payments	Single release covers most orders under KSh 50,000
Native mobile apps	REC **Mobile web only.** App store friction kills a low-trust funnel. PWA if needed.
Agency accounts	Serve agencies manually at first
Subscriptions	Nothing to subscribe to yet
Creator tiers / gamification	Meaningless without volume
Advanced analytics / ROAS	Simple counts suffice
Logistics integration	Brands ship; you track state
Instagram/YouTube API integration	FACT App review is slow; manual verification is adequate at V1
Automated fraud detection	Manual review at this volume
Multi-currency	KES only
Public API	No demand

REC **The discipline here is the point.** Every item above is a real feature that a competitor has, and every one of them is a way to spend three months not learning whether brands rebook.

Manual processes behind the scenes (deliberately)

REC **The MVP is a manually-operated marketplace wearing a product.** Do this openly and do not apologise for it.

Function	Manual method	Automate at
Creator verification	Ops watches content, checks socials, approves	500 creators
Campaign moderation	Human review of every campaign	100 campaigns/mo
Creator shortlisting	Founder picks 10 by hand per brief	300 campaigns/mo
Brief writing	Ops writes with the brand on a call	V2 (AI)
Quality control	Ops reviews every deliverable before the brand sees it	500 collabs/mo
Proof verification	Ops opens the URL and checks	TikTok API in V2
Disputes	Founder decides	Never fully
Payouts	**Automated from day one — never manual**	—
Customer support	Founders on WhatsApp	1,000 collabs/mo

REC **Payouts are the single exception to "do things manually."** Manual payouts introduce delay, error and favouritism into the exact process your entire trust proposition rests on. Automate payment on day one even if everything else is a spreadsheet.

First 30 days

Week	Focus	Target
1	Incorporate; **start M-Pesa go-live paperwork**; engage counsel; recruit 20 creators by hand	20 creators
2	20 more creators; build their storefronts with them; pitch 15 SME brands	40 creators, 5 brands
3	**Run 5 campaigns manually** — WhatsApp + spreadsheet, no product	5 completed
4	10 more campaigns; capture every price, objection and failure	15 completed, KSh 150k GMV

REC **Ship no software in month one.** Everything above runs on WhatsApp, a spreadsheet, and a Safaricom line. You are buying the specification.

First 90 days

Month	Focus	Targets
1	Manual V0	40 creators · 15 collabs · KSh 150k GMV
2	V1 build + keep selling manually	100 creators · 50 collabs · KSh 500k GMV
3	V1 launch to existing users; Deal Desk live	250 creators · 150 collabs · KSh 1.5M GMV

Cumulative 90-day target: ~215 collaborations, ~KSh 2.15M GMV, ~KSh 320k revenue.

REC **Judge the quarter on three numbers only:** completion rate (>80%), brand repeat rate (>25%), median time to payout (<2 hours). Everything else is noise at this stage.

Part 43 — Version roadmap

V0 — Manual marketplace · Months 1–3

Features: none. WhatsApp, a spreadsheet, a phone. **Team:** 2 founders + 1 ops. **Complexity:** ★☆☆☆☆ **Main KPI:** completed collaborations (target 50 cumulative). **Main risk:** discovering brands will not prepay. REC **Test this in week two, before writing any code** — it invalidates the model if false. **Gate to V1:** 50 completed collaborations, >70% completion, ≥10 brands who would rebook.

V1 — MVP · Months 3–6

Features: the MVP set above. Four campaign types, storefronts, escrow, M-Pesa, reviews, ops console, Deal Desk. **Team:** 2 founders + 3 engineers + 1 designer + 2 ops = 8. **Complexity:** ★★★☆☆ **Main KPI:** monthly completed collaborations (300 by month 6). **Main risk:** M-Pesa go-live delay. FACT 6–8 weeks is typical — start in week one. **Gate to V2:** 300 collabs/month · >35% brand repeat · <5% dispute rate · payout median <2h.

V2 — Automated marketplace · Months 6–14

Features: all ten campaign types · milestones and split payments · TikTok/Instagram OAuth and automated proof · rights module with the pricing slider · LLM brief parsing · affiliate promo codes · agency accounts · brand subscriptions · advanced discovery · creator tiers · analytics with attribution · Mombasa launch. **Team:** 20–25 (8 eng, 2 design, 2 product, 6 ops, 3 sales, 2 finance/compliance). **Complexity:** ★★★★☆ **Main KPI:**

GMV, with AOV as the primary guardrail (target KSh 27M/month, KSh 18k AOV). **Main risk: disintermediation as relationships mature.** Watch repeat rate and the ratio of second collaborations between the same pair. **Gate to V3:** KSh 25M GMV/month · >45% repeat GMV · positive contribution margin per collaboration.

V3 — AI marketplace · Months 14–24

Features: learned ranking on outcome data · portfolio optimisation · full AI campaign builder · predicted performance · Spark Ads and Meta Partnership Ads plumbing · TikTok Shop attribution · logistics integration · **export corridor (global brands buying African creators)** · multi-currency and cards · **earnings advances (the underwriting thesis begins)**. **Team:** 45–60. **Complexity:** ★★★★★ **Main KPI:** GMV and net revenue; **repeat GMV % as the health metric**. **Main risk: that the Kenyan market caps out before the economics work.** Export and regional are the answers and must be tested by month 18, not assumed. **Gate to V4:** KSh 100M GMV/month · proven export demand · unit economics positive.

V4 — East Africa · Months 24–36

Features: Uganda, Tanzania, Rwanda · MTN MoMo and Airtel Money · multi-language · per-country compliance and entities · cross-border campaigns. **Team:** 80–120. **Complexity:** ★★★★★ **Main KPI:** GMV per market; time-to-liquidity in each new market. **Main risk: premature expansion.** REC **The rule: do not enter a market until Kenya alone is contribution-positive.** Every marketplace that expanded to escape weak home economics has failed to escape them. **Gate to V5:** two markets at KSh 30M+/month each.

V5 — Africa · Months 36+

Features: Nigeria, Ghana, South Africa, Egypt · pan-African brand accounts · full financial services (advances, credit, insurance) · creator services marketplace. **Team:** 200+. **Complexity:** ★★★★★ **Main KPI:** net revenue and contribution margin. **Main risk: Nigeria is a different market, not a bigger Kenya** — different payment rails, different creator culture, larger and better-funded local competitors. REC Treat each as a new company, not a rollout.

Part 49 — The first ten campaign templates

ASSUMPTION All prices are my recommendations for launch, calibrated against FACT reported Kenyan rates (micro-influencers KSh 10,000–50,000/post; top-tier KSh 100,000+/video). **Validate every one in week one with real creators — do not treat these as market data.**

---

1 · Restaurant Visit — *the flagship launch template*

> "Visit our new Westlands restaurant this weekend, enjoy a meal on us, and create 1 TikTok + 3 Instagram Stories."

Creators: 10–15 food/lifestyle, Nairobi (Westlands/Kilimani/Parklands), nano–micro, 5,000+ TikTok followers, must post within 48h of visit. Deliverables: 1 TikTok (30–60s) · 3 IG Stories with location tag and @mention · 1 Google review (optional, +KSh 500). Price: **KSh 5,000–8,000/creator** + KSh 2,500 consumption allowance. Campaign total ≈ **KSh 112,500** for 12 creators (incl. 15% fee). Timeline: 7 days. Payment: 100% escrow; travel stipend at check-in; balance on approval. Approval: brand reviews within 48h; auto-approve at 5 days. Metrics: views, reach, saves, location tags, **walk-ins mentioning the campaign**.

2 · Product Seeding

> "We're sending our new KSh 1,800 skincare serum to 30 creators. Free product + KSh 1,000. One honest review post required."

Creators: 30 beauty/skincare, women 20–35, Nairobi delivery, Kenyan audience >60%. Deliverables: 1 TikTok or Reel · 2 Stories · honest review encouraged. Price: product (KSh 1,800) + **KSh 1,000 cash**. Total ≈ **KSh 34,500** + product cost. Timeline: 5 days dispatch, 10 days to content **from delivery**. Payment: cash escrowed at launch, released on approval. Metrics: content pieces, aggregate reach, sentiment, cost per piece.

3 · UGC Video Pack — *the highest-margin, most repeatable template*

> "5 authentic TikTok-style videos of our product. We'll run them as ads. You don't need to post."

Creators: 5 UGC creators — **portfolio-ranked, follower count irrelevant**. Good lighting, clear audio, English/Swahili. Deliverables: 5 × 30s vertical videos, 3 hook variants on 2 of them, raw files included. Price: **KSh 4,000/video** + KSh 2,000 for 90-day paid-ads rights = **KSh 22,000** + 15% = **KSh 25,300**. Timeline: 7 days. Payment: 30% on acceptance, 70% on approval. Revisions: 1 included. Metrics: cost per asset, ad CTR/CPA when run, winning hook.

4 · TikTok Paid Post

> "One TikTok featuring our app, in your own style. Must include our download link in bio for 7 days."

Creators: 5 micro (10k–50k), Kenya-majority audience, ER >4%. Deliverables: 1 TikTok (min 20s) · link in bio 7 days · **#Ad disclosure (system-inserted)** · live minimum 30 days. Price: **KSh 8,000–15,000/creator**. Total ≈ **KSh 66,700** for 5 (incl. fee). Payment: 100% on proof verification. Metrics: views, ER, link clicks, installs.

5 · Beauty Product Review

> "Try our product for 7 days and share your honest before/after."

Creators: 8 beauty creators with genuine skincare content history. Deliverables: 1 detailed review video (60–90s) with before/after · 3 Stories across the week. Price: product + **KSh 6,000/creator** ≈ **KSh 55,200** total. Timeline: 14 days (7 trial + 7 content). REC **Do not require positive sentiment — require honesty.** It is more credible, and mandating praise is likely a disclosure and consumer-protection problem.

6 · Hotel Stay

> "One-night stay for two at our Diani resort. 1 recap TikTok + 5 Stories + 10 photos."

Creators: 3 travel/lifestyle, 20k+ followers, willing to travel. Deliverables: 1 recap video (60s+) · 5 Stories · 10 edited photos with 12-month brand usage rights. Price: stay (brand cost) + **KSh 15,000–25,000/creator** + transport. Total ≈ **KSh 86,250** for 3. Payment: 30% pre-travel, 70% on approval. REC Advance the transport component — creators should never fund travel out of pocket.

7 · Event Coverage

> "Cover our product launch on Saturday, 6–10pm. Live Stories + recap + raw photos."

Creators: 3 event/lifestyle + 1 photographer. Deliverables: 8 live Stories during the event · 1 recap TikTok within 48h · 30 raw photos (photographer) · 1 IG post. Price: **KSh 12,000–20,000/creator**; photographer **KSh 25,000**. Total ≈ **KSh 74,750**. Payment: 50% pre-event, 50% on delivery. Metrics: live reach, recap views, asset count.

8 · Affiliate Campaign — *V2, not launch*

> "Promote our online store. KSh 300 per sale with your unique code. KSh 3,000 guaranteed."

Creators: 20 with buying-intent audiences. Structure: **KSh 3,000 guarantee** + KSh 300/sale, capped at KSh 15,000. Guarantee escrowed; commission settled monthly. REC **The guarantee is mandatory.** A commission-only listing in Kenya will not fill, and should not. Metrics: code redemptions, revenue, cost per acquisition, earnings per creator.

9 · Product Photography

> "20 lifestyle photos of our furniture in a real home setting."

Creators: 2 photographers (portfolio-ranked; audience irrelevant). Deliverables: 20 edited high-res photos · 5 flat-lays · perpetual brand usage rights. Price: **KSh 12,000–18,000/creator** ≈ **KSh 34,500** total. Timeline: 10 days. Revisions: 1 round of re-edits. Metrics: cost per asset vs studio quote (typically 3–5x cheaper — a strong sales argument).

10 · App Promotion

> "Show how you use our app in daily life. 1 TikTok + 3 UGC videos we can run as ads."

Creators: 6 tech/lifestyle/student creators. Deliverables: 1 organic TikTok posted by creator · 3 UGC videos for brand ads · 90-day paid-ads rights. Price: **KSh 10,000/creator** (KSh 5,000 post + KSh 5,000 UGC pack) ≈ **KSh 69,000**. Payment: 30/70. Metrics: views, installs, cost per install, best-performing creative.

Why these ten

REC They are chosen to cover the four MVP campaign types, to span **KSh 25,000–115,000** in campaign value (proving AOV can exceed the KSh 10,000-order trap), to be sellable to the launch verticals in `12-gtm-liquidity-growth.md`, and — critically — **to be deliverable by hand in month one with no software at all.**

REC **Template 3 (UGC Video Pack) is the one to lean on hardest.** It is the most repeatable, the highest-margin, the most exportable, the least dependent on creator audience, and the only one on this list that a brand will buy again every single month.

15

Investor Case and Failure Modes

Part 46 — The investor case (written as an investor would interrogate it)

Why now?

FACT Three things became true recently that were not true five years ago: 1. **TikTok is Kenya's dominant creative platform** — 76.9% monthly use reported, ~18.4M adult ad reach — creating a large population of skilled short-form video producers who did not exist in 2020. 2. **Creator income is being formalised by force.** Meta began withholding Kenyan creator tax at source in January 2026; Google/YouTube followed from September 2026. Creator earnings are becoming a documented, taxable, bankable income stream — which makes an infrastructure layer on top of it newly viable. 3. **The UGC-as-advertising model is proven and priced.** Billo at $99–200/video, Trend from $50, Cohley $100–500 — Western brands now buy creator content as a *production* line item, not a media buy.

REC **The honest "why now" is the second point.** Formalisation of creator income is the wedge that turns a marketplace into a financial-infrastructure business.

Why Kenya?

FACT M-Pesa gives Kenya something almost no other market has: **near-universal, instant, API-addressable payment rails to individuals**. You can pay 500 creators in 500 different towns in under a minute. In Nigeria, India, or Brazil, that is a hard problem. In Kenya it is an API call. FACT English-language business environment, high mobile internet penetration (23.4M internet users), dense creative talent in Nairobi. REC **The honest caveat you must volunteer to investors before they find it:** Kenya's *measured* influencer ad market is ~$2–3M. Kenya is the right place to **build and prove** the model, and the wrong place to **cap** the ambition. Any investor who does not hear that from you first will conclude you have not done the arithmetic.

Why Africa? Why creators? Why marketplaces? Why M-Pesa?

- **Africa:** youngest population globally, mobile-first, rapidly growing creator supply, and — the real argument — **a structural cost advantage in content production that is exportable**.
- **Creators:** content demand is now permanent and recurring. Every brand running paid social needs fresh creative monthly, forever. That is a subscription-shaped need served by a fragmented, informal supply base — which is the classic marketplace setup.
- **Marketplaces:** because the transaction is repeated, fragmented on both sides, trust-constrained, and payment-mediated. All four conditions must hold; here they do.
- **M-Pesa:** it collapses the hardest part of a labour marketplace — paying many small suppliers instantly and cheaply — into solved infrastructure.

TAM / SAM / SOM

REC **Be scrupulous here. Inflated TAM is the fastest way to lose a good investor.**

	Definition	Value	Basis
TAM	African brand spend on creator content and collaborations	ASSUMPTION **Not reliably measurable.**	No credible source. REC **Do not put a number on this you cannot defend.**

	Definition	Value	Basis
SAM (Kenya, narrow)	Kenyan influencer advertising	**~US$3M by 2028**	FACT Statista
SAM (Kenya, broad)	Kenyan digital advertising	**~US$119M by 2028**	FACT Statista
SOM (5 yr)	Realistic capture	ASSUMPTION **KSh 1.2–3B annual GMV (~$9–23M)** = ~$1.4–3.5M revenue at 15%	Requires Kenya + region + export

REC **The framing that survives diligence:** *"The measured influencer market is small. We are not selling into it. We are selling into content-production and SME marketing budgets, which are larger and unmeasured — and we will prove the size empirically in the first 90 days through the Deal Desk, because creators bringing us their existing deals tells us exactly how much money is already moving."* That is an honest answer with a falsifiable test attached, which is worth far more than a large number.

Network effects and moat

Real network effects: more creators → better matches → better brand outcomes → more campaigns → more creator earnings → more creators. Plus **local density effects** for visits (Westlands liquidity is not transferable to Kisumu — which is a weakness for expansion and a strength for defence).

REC **The honest moat assessment:**

Claimed moat	Real?
Network effects	**Partially.** Strong locally, weak nationally. Real but not absolute.
AI matching	**No.** Commodity capability.
M-Pesa integration	**No.** Anyone can integrate Daraja.
Escrow + contracts	**No.** FACT Zaumu shipped this in April 2025.
Supply relationships and ops reliability	**Yes.** Earned slowly, hard to copy — this is Billo's actual moat.
The settlement + reputation ledger	**Yes, and it is the real one.** Verified earnings history enables underwriting; underwriting makes leaving expensive.
Rights + ad-platform plumbing	**Yes, partially.** Insense's Spark Ads/Meta plumbing is genuinely hard.

The four "why won't X kill you" questions

Why won't TikTok crush us? FACT TikTok Creator Marketplace requires **10,000 followers**, is free, single-platform, and monetises downstream ad spend. It structurally cannot serve sub-10k UGC creators (the majority of your supply), cannot do location visits or seeding logistics, has no M-Pesa settlement, no escrow, no dispute process, and no cross-platform campaigns. REC **It is not a competitor; it is a channel and a partial substitute for one of your ten campaign types.** The honest risk is not that TikTok crushes you — it is that TikTok Shop's affiliate mechanics absorb the *commerce* use case if they launch fully in Kenya. Watch that specifically.

Why won't Collabstr expand into Africa? They are already present via SEO (Nairobi landing pages) but not operationally. To actually compete they would need M-Pesa collection *and* B2C payout, Kenyan KYC, local ops for disputes and visits, local supply recruitment, and a fee model that works at KSh 5,000 orders. REC

The honest answer: their ~25% blended take rate does not survive at Kenyan ticket sizes, and Kenya is a rounding error in their TAM. But do not tell an investor they *cannot* — tell them the ROI does not justify it, which is more credible and more accurate.

Why won't local competitors win? REC **This is the question to be most honest about — they might.** Wowzi has $3.2M raised and telco relationships. Zaumu shipped your core feature set in April 2025. **The differentiation must be execution and category, not concept:** the non-influencer campaign types (visits, UGC at scale, seeding logistics), AOV discipline, the Deal Desk, and payout speed. REC **If an investor asks "what if Zaumu just does this?", the honest answer is "then we compete on operational reliability and category breadth, and we may lose."** Anyone who claims a concept moat here is bluffing.

Why will creators and brands stay? Creators: verified earnings history that exists nowhere else, fastest payouts, 0% fees, and eventually advances underwritten by their history. Brands: the roster of creators who already delivered for them, past campaign performance, rights library, and descending repeat fees. REC **Both answers are weak in year one and strong in year three.** Say so. Retention is something you build, not something you have.

Part 47 — Twenty ways this fails

You asked for genuine criticism and for me not to make the idea sound good. Ordered by my estimate of probability × severity.

---

1. The Kenyan market is too small to support a venture-scale take-rate business. *Why:* FACT ~$2–3M measured influencer spend. Even total capture yields ~$400k revenue. *Prevention:* Design for content-production and SME budgets, not influencer budgets. Architect for export and region from day one. *Warning:* Blended AOV stuck under KSh 15,000 at month 9; GMV growth flattening below KSh 10M/month. *Mitigation:* Accelerate the export corridor; consider repositioning as African-creator-supply-to-global-demand — a much larger market where Kenya is the supply base rather than the demand base. REC **This is the most likely way this company fails to become large, and it is a strategy risk, not an execution risk.**

2. Disintermediation after the first transaction. *Why:* Both sides have WhatsApp and M-Pesa. The fee is pure friction once trust exists. *Prevention:* Descending repeat fees (15→10→8%); make escrow, rights, disputes and advances genuinely valuable; the Deal Desk. *Warning:* Repeat-collaboration rate <25% at month 6; conversations dying immediately after first contact. *Mitigation:* Reprice repeats aggressively; shift value to services that only work on-platform (rights, tax paperwork, advances).

3. Ops cost per order never falls below gross profit per order. *Why:* A KSh 10,000 order consuming 20 minutes of human ops is permanently unprofitable. *Prevention:* Instrument cost-to-serve from month one; ruthless AOV growth; automate QC and proof verification early. *Warning:* Cost-to-serve flat or rising quarter-on-quarter. *Mitigation:* Minimum order value; push packages and multi-creator campaigns; automate or refuse the small tail.

4. Zaumu or Wowzi executes faster with more capital. *Why:* FACT Zaumu already ships escrow, milestones, contracts and reviews. Wowzi has $3.2M and telco relationships. *Prevention:* Compete on category (visits, UGC, seeding logistics) and reliability, not concept. *Warning:* Losing head-to-head brand deals; creators reporting better experience elsewhere. *Mitigation:* Narrow to the category you win; consider partnership or acquisition conversations early rather than late.

5. Creators join, find no work, and tell everyone the platform is dead. *Why:* Kenyan creator communities are dense and vocal. Negative word-of-mouth is fast and durable. *Prevention:* Demand-first sequencing; waitlists; guaranteed first work for hand-recruited creators; the 0.3 campaigns-per-creator hard stop. *Warning:* Applications per campaign >40; creator 30-day activation <40%. *Mitigation:* Halt supply acquisition entirely and sell. This must be an explicit, pre-agreed rule with a named owner.

6. Brands do not trust prepaying an unknown platform. *Why:* Kenya has a history of digital payment scams. Prepaying a startup is a real leap. *Prevention:* Test in week two before writing code. Company registration visible; licensed aggregator named; testimonials; start with small orders. *Warning:* >50% of interested brands refuse to prefund. *Mitigation:* Invoice-after-delivery for vetted brands (you absorb the risk); a partner-bank escrow arrangement for credibility.

7. Payment or reconciliation failure destroys trust irrecoverably. *Why:* One publicised "Flerwa didn't pay me" thread can end supply acquisition. *Prevention:* Double-entry ledger day one; daily reconciliation with a named owner; automated payouts; over-communicate on every delay. *Warning:* Any unreconciled break; any payout over 24h. *Mitigation:* Pay from platform funds immediately and reconcile later. REC **Always pay first, investigate second.**

8. Regulatory action on holding customer funds. *Why:* FACT CBK PSP licensing requirements are real and enforced. *Prevention:* Aggregator architecture; 60-day escrow cap; auto-sweep; legal opinion before launch. *Warning:* Any regulator contact; aggregator raising concerns. *Mitigation:* Pre-drafted plan to move to a trust structure or accelerate licensing.

9. Content quality is too inconsistent for brands to rebook. *Why:* A brand that gets three bad videos out of five does not return. *Prevention:* Manual vetting of the first 500 creators; ops QC before the brand sees anything; replacement guarantee. *Warning:* First-pass approval <70%; brand repeat <25%. *Mitigation:* Curated "verified quality" tier; managed service as default; remove weak supply.

10. Take rate is unsustainable at Kenyan ticket sizes. *Why:* 15% of KSh 5,000 is KSh 750 — less than the cost to serve. *Prevention:* Minimum order value; AOV focus; package-first catalogue. *Warning:* Median order below KSh 6,000. *Mitigation:* Flat minimum fee for small orders; deprioritise the low tail.

11. Fraud at scale — fake creators, stolen portfolios, collusion rings. *Prevention:* ID + M-Pesa name matching; perceptual hashing; settled-transaction-gated reviews; graph analysis. *Warning:* Rising dispute rate; clustered new accounts; review-pattern anomalies. *Mitigation:* Slow onboarding; manual review; ban aggressively and publicly.

12. Founder-led sales does not scale, and hired sales cannot sell it. *Why:* Early sales depends on founder credibility that does not transfer. *Prevention:* Document objections and scripts from campaign one; productise the offer so it sells itself. *Warning:* First sales hire's conversion under half the founders'. *Mitigation:* Shift to self-serve + inbound; reduce reliance on high-touch selling.

13. Creators price too low, and the market never becomes worth serving. *Why:* Marketplace transparency drives commoditisation; a race to the bottom shrinks GMV. *Prevention:* Pricing guidance based on real data; no "lowest price" default sort; quality-first ranking. *Warning:* Median rates falling quarter on quarter. *Mitigation:* Price floors by category; promote value-based packages; surface quality signals harder.

14. WhatsApp policy or pricing changes break the notification layer. *Prevention:* Channel-abstracted notification service; SMS fallback maintained; push for app users. *Warning:* Template rejections; per-conversation cost rising. *Mitigation:* Shift to SMS + push; the abstraction makes this a config change.

15. Tax treatment turns out to be adverse. *Why:* FACT 5% withholding on digital content monetisation, enforcement tightening through 2026. *Prevention:* Tax advisor before launch; withholding capability built and dormant. *Warning:* KRA guidance changes; competitors withholding. *Mitigation:* Switch on withholding; market the certificates as a benefit.

16. Key-person dependency on founders for disputes and matching. *Prevention:* Document every decision rule from day one; hire an ops lead by month 6. *Warning:* Founders spending >50% of time on operations at month 9. *Mitigation:* Codify rules into the product; the manual process was always the specification.

17. A safety incident on a location visit. *Why:* You are sending individuals — often young women — to venues you do not control. `REC` **This is the risk most likely to be underweighted in a plan like this, and the one with the worst human consequences.** *Prevention:* Venue verification; creator-visible venue ratings; +1 allowed by default; emergency contact in-app; **never expose creator personal details to venues**; clear reporting channel. *Warning:* Any report of harassment or unsafe conditions. *Mitigation:* Immediate venue suspension; support the creator; publish the policy. **Treat one incident as a company-level event, not a support ticket.**

18. Agency concentration becomes existential. *Prevention:* 20% GMV concentration cap as an actively managed metric; direct-brand acquisition in parallel. *Warning:* Any agency above 20% of GMV. *Mitigation:* Diversify deliberately before it becomes leverage against you.

19. Building too many features before proving repeat purchase. *Why:* 50 parts of scope in this document. The temptation to build them all is enormous. *Prevention:* The MVP discipline in `14-roadmap-mvp.md`; the "do not build" list is as binding as the build list. *Warning:* Six months in with no completed collaborations. *Mitigation:* Stop, run 20 campaigns manually, rebuild from what you learn.

20. The founders solve the interesting problem instead of the boring one. *Why:* AI matching is fun. Reconciling M-Pesa callbacks and phoning creators about deadlines is not. `REC` **The boring one is the business.** *Prevention:* North Star is completed collaborations, not features shipped. Founders in ops weekly, permanently. *Warning:* Engineering velocity high, GMV flat. *Mitigation:* Freeze the roadmap; sell.

The one-paragraph honest assessment

`REC` This is a **good business with a capped local market and a credible path past the cap**, entering a category where a well-executed competitor already exists. The concept is not defensible; the execution and the ledger are. Success depends on three things that have nothing to do with the feature list: **selling the first 100 campaigns by hand, raising average order value relentlessly, and paying creators faster than anyone else in Kenya.** If you get those three right, the rest of this document is implementation detail. If you get them wrong, no amount of AI matching will save it.

Blueprint, Wedge, Founder Brief

Part 41 — The strategic wedge

Evaluating the candidates you proposed

Positioning	As a *market message*	As a *strategic wedge*
"Hire creators, not influencers"	Good — sharp and contrarian	**Weak.** It is a *category* claim, not a *defensibility* claim. Any competitor can say it tomorrow.
"Any brand. Any creator. Any collaboration."	Weak — vague	Weak — breadth is not a moat, it is a roadmap
"The commercial marketplace for African creators"	Adequate	Weak — geography is not defensible
"From seeding to UGC to influencer campaigns"	Good subhead	Weak — a feature list
"Upwork for creators"	Useful investor shorthand	Weak — analogy, not advantage
"The OS for creator-brand partnerships"	Poor — jargon	Weak

REC **None of these is a wedge.** They are all descriptions of *what you sell*. A wedge is a description of *why you win and keep winning*, and it usually looks boring from the outside.

The three-layer answer

Layer 1 — The entry wedge (how you get in):

> **Physical, local, non-influencer collaborations that global platforms structurally cannot serve.**

Location visits, event coverage, seeding with logistics. FACT These are empty columns across the entire global competitive matrix — no major platform supports geo-booked venue visits as a first-class product. They are unattractive to US-centric platforms because Western creator marketing is remote-first and asynchronous. They are *perfect* for Nairobi, where the buyer is a physical business with a physical location and a footfall problem.

Layer 2 — The volume engine (how you get large):

> **UGC as a recurring content-production subscription, decoupled from audience.**

Every brand running paid social needs new creatives every month, forever. This is the only collaboration type that is recurring, quality-assessable, supply-unconstrained, and **exportable**. It is where AOV and repeat rate come from.

Layer 3 — The moat (why you cannot be displaced):

> **The settlement and reputation ledger.**

The one core product insight

> ## In a market where the median transaction is KSh 5,000 and the median buyer is an SME, no marketplace survives on the transaction. It survives on the record of the transaction.
>
> ## Whoever accumulates the verified, escrow-settled earnings history of African creators owns the only dataset capable of underwriting them — and underwriting is what makes leaving expensive.

Why this is the right answer and the others are not:

- A creator will leave over a 15% fee. A creator will **not** leave the place that holds their income history and lends against it.
- FACT Kenya's creator income is being formalised *by force* right now — Meta withholding since January 2026, Google since September 2026. Creator earnings are becoming documented, taxable, bankable income. **The infrastructure layer for that income does not yet exist, and the window to become it is open now.**
- Nobody else can build this dataset. **TikTok** has no payment rail in Kenya. **Banks** have no work history. **Agencies** have unstructured data. **Modash and Collabstr** have discovery but no settlement. **Only the party that both matches and settles can see the whole picture.**
- It compounds: every collaboration makes the dataset more valuable, and the dataset makes the marketplace more valuable.

The practical sequence:

```
Marketplace  →  Settlement rail  →  Earnings ledger  →  Underwriting  →  Financial infrastructure
  (year 1)        (year 1-2)          (year 2)          (year 3)           (year 4+)
```

REC **Architect for it now (immutable event log, double-entry ledger, structured performance events — all specified in `09-workflow-states.md` and `10-technical-architecture.md`). Do not build it now. Do not pitch it as the year-one product.** But make every architectural decision as though it is coming, because it is, and retrofitting a ledger is the one mistake you cannot recover from cheaply.

Part 50 — Complete blueprint

1. Company concept. A commercial marketplace where Kenyan brands hire creators for any paid collaboration — location visits, UGC production, product seeding, influencer posts, events, affiliate — with escrow-protected payment and M-Pesa settlement.

2. Target customer. *Primary:* Nairobi SMEs with marketing budget and no marketing team (restaurants, beauty, retail, hotels, gyms, clinics). *Secondary:* startups and e-commerce brands buying recurring UGC. *Tertiary:* agencies. *Supply:* Kenyan creators of all sizes, weighted to nano/micro and UGC producers.

3. Core problem. Brands cannot reliably find, brief, pay and manage creators. Creators cannot reliably find work or get paid on time. Both sides transact informally on WhatsApp with no contract, no escrow, no measurement, and chronic payment delay.

4. Solution. A productised campaign catalogue with escrow-funded contracts, structured briefs and deliverables, sub-hour M-Pesa payouts, and two-sided reputation.

5. Differentiation. Physical/local collaboration types no global platform serves; UGC decoupled from audience; 0% creator fees; the Deal Desk; the fastest payouts in the market; a settlement-and-reputation ledger that becomes an underwriting asset.

6. Marketplace model. Two-sided, transaction-fee-based, managed at launch and progressively automated. One `Collaboration` primitive with ten presets.

7. Creator model. Free to join, 0% fees, storefront with published prices, portfolio-first profiles, two supply pools (audience-based and UGC/craft-based) with different ranking logic, reputation earned only through settled transactions, tiers gating real economic benefits.

8. Brand model. Free to browse and post, pay only on transaction, 15% service fee on top of the creator's rate, +10% for managed service. Subscriptions in V2 that buy a lower take rate.

9. Campaign types. Seeding · Paid UGC · Influencer campaigns · Location visits · Event coverage · Affiliate/performance · Hybrid fee+performance · Content licensing · Creator packages · Custom campaigns. Launch with four.

10. Payment architecture. Licensed aggregator holds the regulated float; collaboration-bound escrow with a 60-day maximum; M-Pesa STK collection and B2C payout with Business-Pays tariff; 5-day auto-approve protecting creators; double-entry ledger reconciled daily; provider-abstracted for regional expansion.

11. Trust system. Escrow + auto-release + payout speed as the foundation; five-component Creator Reputation Score with Bayesian cold-start and confidence-bound ranking; two-sided reputation including a Brand Trust Score; five-tier dispute ladder with objective auto-resolution; twelve-threat fraud model.

12. AI matching. Three-stage: hard eligibility filters → weighted explainable scoring → portfolio optimisation for creator *sets*. LLM restricted to parsing and drafting; **all money, ranking and reputation decisions deterministic**. Built in V2 on real outcome data, not before.

13. UX. Creator: mobile-first, under 6 minutes to a complete profile, earnings-led. Brand: objective-first onboarding, three questions, recommended campaigns before any payment detail. Both: WhatsApp as the notification layer, platform as the system of record.

14. MVP. Four campaign types, creator storefronts, escrow, M-Pesa, workflow timers, two-sided reviews, ops console. Everything else deliberately excluded. Manual behind the scenes except payouts.

15. Technical architecture. Next.js on Vercel; **PostgreSQL (Supabase), not Firestore**; phone-OTP auth; Cloudflare Stream for video; aggregator payments behind a provider interface; Inngest for timers; WhatsApp Business API; PostHog; Claude API for structured extraction. Append-only event log and double-entry ledger from commit one.

16. Business model. 15% brand-paid fee on top of creator rate; 0% creator fee for 24 months; 5% on creator-originated Deal Desk transactions; +10% managed service; subscriptions and agency/enterprise accounts in V2. **AOV, not take rate, is the primary commercial lever.**

17. Go-to-market. Demand first, sold by founders in person in Westlands/Kilimani. Restaurants → beauty → fashion → hotels → startups. Creators hand-recruited (first 100), then referrals, ambassadors and earnings-proof content.

18. Liquidity strategy. Deal Desk to capture existing informal deals from day one; manual matching for 90 days; guaranteed first work for hand-recruited creators; a hard stop on supply acquisition if campaigns-per-creator falls below 0.3.

19. Growth loops. Earnings-proof sharing · storefront distribution · Deal Desk conversion · content in the wild · brand case studies · referrals · reputation lock-in · data quality · agency multiplier · geographic density.

20. Network effects. Local density effects (strong, defensible, non-transferable); matching quality effects (moderate); reputation lock-in (strong, slow-building); data effects on pricing and matching (strong, long-term).

21. Competitive moat. Not the concept — FACT Zaumu already ships it. The moat is operational reliability, supply relationships, rights/ad-platform plumbing, and above all the settlement-and-reputation ledger.

22. Expansion. Nairobi → Mombasa → Kenyan secondary cities → **export corridor (global brands buying African creators)** → Uganda/Tanzania/Rwanda → West and Southern Africa. **Rule: do not enter a new market until Kenya alone is contribution-positive.**

23. Metrics. North Star: **completed collaborations per month**, guardrailed by AOV and repeat rate. Plus GMV, take rate, earning creators, paying brands, activation, completion, cost-to-serve, dispute rate, median time to payout.

24. Financial model. Loss-making below ~KSh 25–35M GMV/month; ~70% gross margin at KSh 50M; ~26% net margin at KSh 500M. Payment costs are a permanent 14–21% tax on revenue. Doubling AOV more than triples gross profit.

25. Major risks. Market too small (highest) · disintermediation · ops cost never falling · well-funded local competitors · supply churn from thin demand · brands refusing to prepay · payment failure · regulatory action on funds · quality inconsistency · creator safety on visits.

THE 10 THINGS WE SHOULD BUILD FIRST

1. **Escrow with M-Pesa STK collection and B2C payout.** Everything else is decoration without it. Start the Daraja go-live paperwork in week one — FACT 6–8 weeks is typical and it is the critical path.
2. **Creator storefronts with published prices.** The single highest-leverage liquidity feature; makes the marketplace transactable with zero campaigns posted, and turns supply into a distribution channel.
3. **The four launch campaign types** — Location Visit, Paid UGC, Product Seeding, Influencer Post — as fixed-price, outcome-named products.
4. **The workflow state machine with all timers**, especially **5-day auto-approve**. This is what makes the marketplace fair in both directions.
5. **The append-only event log and double-entry ledger.** Nearly free on day one; ruinous to retrofit. This is the foundation of the moat.
6. **The ops/admin console.** V0 and V1 are manually operated. Without this you run the company from a database client.
7. **WhatsApp notifications, with a shareable M-Pesa payout receipt.** Your best marketing asset is a real creator showing real money.
8. **Two-sided reviews and the Brand Trust Score.** Nobody else gives creators this information; it is cheap and it is a real reason to choose you.
9. **The Deal Desk (5% creator-originated).** GMV and brand acquisition without solving cold start — and it measures the informal market's true size.
10. **Structured briefs with system-inserted disclosure.** Prevents most disputes and makes you the compliant option for brands with legal exposure.

THE 10 THINGS WE SHOULD NOT BUILD YET

1. **AI matching.** Filters beat models below 1,000 creators, and you have no outcome data to train on.
2. **The AI campaign builder.** It would invent prices. Build it in V2 on real transaction data.
3. **Affiliate and performance tracking.** Needs attribution infrastructure and creator trust you have not earned.
4. **Native mobile apps.** App-store friction kills a low-trust funnel. Mobile web.
5. **Milestones and split payments.** Single release covers almost everything under KSh 50,000.
6. **The standalone rights marketplace.** Bundle rights into UGC orders at V1.
7. **Event coverage.** Operationally complex; wait for maturity.
8. **Agency and enterprise accounts.** Serve them manually; the manual process is the spec.
9. **Subscriptions.** Nothing to subscribe to yet, and they kill trial.
10. **Logistics integration.** Brands ship; you track state. Revisit at V3 with evidence.

REC **And a bonus: do not build creator tiers, gamification, or advanced analytics.** All three feel like progress and none of them moves completed collaborations.

Product name and positioning direction

REC **On "Flerwa":** it is a strong choice and I would keep it. Invented, short, phonetically clean in English and Swahili, no semantic baggage, trademarkable, and available as a category-defining word rather than a descriptor. FACT Wowzi took the same approach successfully. The risk with invented names — that they carry no meaning — is real but manageable, because a marketplace name should become a verb, not describe a feature. *"We found her on Flerwa"* works.

REC **Always pair it with a descriptor line until the brand is established:**

> ### Flerwa
>
> #### Marketing content without a marketing team.
>
> **Hire Kenya's creators for UGC, TikToks, store visits and campaigns. Money held safely. Creators paid by M-Pesa within the hour.**

Audience variants: Creators — *"Get hired. Get paid. Same day."* · Agencies — *"Source, brief, pay and report on 50 creators from one dashboard."* · Investors — *"The commercial infrastructure for Africa's creator economy."*

REC **Check trademark availability in Kenya (KIPI) and secure `flerwa.co.ke` plus the social handles before any public use.** Also check the word carries no unintended meaning in Swahili, Sheng, or major Kenyan vernaculars — this is a five-minute conversation with a native speaker and an expensive omission.

One-page founder brief

FLERWA — Founder Brief for CTO and Product Designer

What we are building. A marketplace where Kenyan brands hire creators for commercial collaborations — restaurant visits, UGC videos, product seeding, sponsored posts — with money held in escrow and creators paid by M-Pesa within the hour of approval.

Who we serve. Nairobi SMEs with a marketing budget and no marketing team. And Kenyan creators of every size, especially the ones with skill and no audience.

The problem. Brands cannot reliably find, brief, pay or manage creators. Creators cannot reliably find work or get paid. Today this happens on WhatsApp with no contract, no escrow and chronic late payment.

The one insight. We do not make money on the transaction. We make money on the *record* of the transaction. The verified earnings history we accumulate is what eventually lets us underwrite creators — and that is what makes leaving expensive. Build every system as though that future is certain.

What we build first. Escrow + M-Pesa. Creator storefronts with prices. Four campaign types. The workflow state machine with all its timers. An append-only event log and a double-entry ledger. An ops console. WhatsApp notifications. Two-sided reviews. The Deal Desk. Structured briefs.

What we do not build. AI matching. AI campaign builder. Affiliate tracking. Native apps. Milestones. Subscriptions. Agency accounts. Event coverage. Logistics. Tiers. Advanced analytics. *All of these are real features. None of them tells us whether brands come back.*

Stack. Next.js on Vercel. **PostgreSQL via Supabase — not Firestore** (we need joins, transactions, geospatial and a financial ledger). Phone-OTP auth. Cloudflare Stream for video. Payments through a licensed aggregator behind our own provider interface. Inngest for timers. WhatsApp Business API. PostHog. Claude API for parsing only.

Three engineering rules. 1. Money is `amount_minor` + `currency`. Never a float. Never a bare number. 2. The ledger is append-only and the event log is immutable. Reputation and analytics are *derived*, never stored as truth. 3. LLMs parse and draft. Deterministic code decides prices, rankings, payments, reputation and disputes.

Three design rules. 1. Portfolio above audience, always. Follower count is never the headline and is hidden entirely for UGC creators. 2. Price is visible and bookable without a conversation. 3. Creator onboarding under 6 minutes, mobile-first, and they can browse before completing it.

Critical path. Start the M-Pesa Daraja go-live paperwork in week one. It typically takes 6–8 weeks and no amount of engineering effort shortens it.

How we know it is working. Completed collaborations per month, at a rising average order value, with a rising share from repeat brands. Three numbers, one line, every week.

The number that decides everything. Brand repeat rate at 60 days. Below 25%, we do not have a company yet — we have a services business, and we should stop building and go and find out why.

Sources

All research conducted **8 September 2026** via web search. Every FACT in this pack traces to a source below. Where sources conflict or information could not be verified, that is stated in the relevant document rather than smoothed over.

Global platforms — pricing and mechanics

- Collabstr pricing · Collabstr FAQ · Collabstr — placing an order · Collabstr — payout methods · Collabstr review 2026
- TikTok Creator Marketplace on TikTok One (Insense) · TikTok Creator Marketplace guide 2026 · SARAL deep dive
- Insense pricing · Insense creator marketplace · Insense review
- Influencer marketing platform pricing 2026 (Storika) · Stack Influence pricing comparison · Influship pricing 2026
- CreatorIQ vs GRIN vs Aspire · Aspire vs Grin vs CreatorIQ 2026
- Modash pricing 2026 · Modash vs Upfluence · Modash on Capterra
- Billo — best UGC platforms 2026 · Trend vs Billo · UGC pricing guide 2026
- Freelance platform fees 2026 (Jobbers) · Upwork vs Fiverr 2026 *(note: sources conflict on Upwork's current fee tiers — flagged in `01-global-market-research.md`)*
- TikTok Shop affiliate commission rates 2026 · TikTok Shop affiliate guide

Kenya and Africa — market and competitors

- DataReportal — Digital 2026: Kenya · DataReportal — Digital in Kenya · NapoleonCat — social media users in Kenya 2026 · Statista — most used social networks in Kenya · Dotsavvy — state of social media in Kenya 2026
- Statista — Influencer Advertising, Kenya · Statista — Digital Advertising, Kenya · Statista — Social Media Advertising, Kenya
- **Wowzi:** TechCrunch — $3.2M raise · Disrupt Africa · Mastercard Newsroom
- **AIfluence:** Techpoint Africa — $1M seed · Kenyan Wall Street · OUI Capital
- **Zaumu:** Capital FM · Techish Kenya · CIO Africa · HapaKenya
- **Others:** Ushawishi · Vicomma — hire creators Kenya · Diglancers · Influencer Africa · Lit.africa · Aktivate · ViralGet (TechCabal)
- **Kenyan creator rates:** The Standard — influencer rate cards · SmartBizSystems — Kenya influencer rates 2026 · Citizen Digital

> **Not verified:** No substantive public information was found for **Oiqora**, **NingNang**, **EndaViral**, **Vumasasa**, or a Kenyan platform named **InfluencerX**. No profiles were invented for them.

Payments, M-Pesa and financial regulation

- CBK — PSP authorisation checklist · CBK — PSP authorisation guidelines · National Payment System Act 2011 · CM Advocates — PSP licence guide · KDS Advocates
- Daraja API go-live guide (PayHero) · M-Pesa Daraja integration guide (Hostiko) · Neurobyte — STK/C2B/B2C guide
- M-Pesa charges and tariffs 2026 (BusinessMax) · M-Pesa fees and limits 2026
- Payment gateways in Kenya 2026 · Paystack in Kenya — M-Pesa, Pesalink, Daraja · Kenya payment gateways compared

Tax, data protection and advertising regulation

- Techweez — Google to withhold 5% from Kenyan YouTube earnings · TechTrends KE — DCCAK pushback · KICTANet — what Kenya's digital taxes mean for creators · K24 — the 5% KRA digital tax
- ODPC — FAQs · Securiti — Kenya DPA compliance guide · Njaga Advocates — ODPC registration · CFL Advocates
- ASBK Code of Advertising Practice (PDF) · Iris Group — Kenya's advertising standards · Anga Creators — influencer disclosure Kenya 2026

Social platform APIs

- Phyllo — social media API comparison 2026 · Phyllo — Instagram vs TikTok vs LinkedIn APIs · Instagram Graph API developer guide 2026 · Instagram API changes 2026

A note on source quality

REC **Treat this pack as a well-researched starting point, not as verified market intelligence.**

Several caveats matter:

- **Much of the platform-pricing data comes from comparison and review sites**, not vendor pages. These sites have affiliate incentives and go stale. **Verify current pricing directly with any vendor before making a decision that depends on it.**
- **Statista market models are estimates**, not measured spend, and — as argued in `02-africa-kenya-landscape.md` — they very likely undercount informal creator spend in Kenya by an unknown multiple. The direction of the error is knowable; the magnitude is not.
- **Kenyan creator rate data is anecdotal**, drawn from press reporting on high-profile creators and agency blog posts. It is directionally useful and not a benchmark. Your own transaction data will be better than anything published within 90 days of launch.
- **Competitor feature claims come from their own marketing.** Zaumu's described feature set is what Zaumu says it has shipped, not what has been independently verified. REC **Sign up for each competitor and use the product before finalising positioning.**
- **Nothing here is legal, tax, or financial advice.** The regulatory sections identify areas requiring professional Kenyan counsel and summarise public information. They are a briefing for your lawyer, not a substitute for one.